

Over 7,600 enumeration forms digitised on day one of SIR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Enumeration forms of over 7,600 voters were digitised on day one of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Delhi on Tuesday, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta also filing her form and urging people to participate in the exercise to strengthen democracy.

In a post on X, the Delhi chief minister said that she filled and submitted the enumeration form with details of herself and her family.

"Fill your enumeration form on time and submit it to your BLO. An accurate and up-to-date voter list is the founda-

tion of a strong democracy. Let us fulfil our duty as conscious citizens and ensure our participation in this great 'yajna' of democracy," she said.

Delhi PWD minister Parvesh Sahib Singh also submitted the completed enumeration form from the New Delhi constituency that he represents in the Assembly.

The month-long door-to-door verification drive began with over 13,000 booth-level officers (BLOs) distributing enumeration forms and collecting the filled-up ones across the 70 Assembly segments in the capital.

A total of 1,68,291 forms were distributed on day one

and 7,605 completed forms submitted by the voters were digitised by the BLOs, said a statement of Delhi Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO) office.

Delhi CEO Ashok Kumar appealed to all eligible voters to cooperate with the BLOs and accurately fill up the forms and submit it to them. The last date of filling up the SIR forms is July 29.

Meanwhile, the BLOs in Delhi have been instructed to go door-to-door in the morning and evening hours, including on Saturdays and Sundays, when people are at home, officials said and added the door-to-door drive was largely smooth.

Some voters, however,



claimed that there were "hiccups" in filling up the forms.

Nitin, a 26-year-old resident in Mandir Marg area, said he wanted to verify some

roll before filling and submitting the form," he said.

In Ansari Nagar (West), some voters said that there was "confusion" regarding documentation and details to be filled in the forms.

A BLO in the area explained to them that they should fill up the forms carefully, furnishing their details of 2002 SIR as well as their current voter list details.

In an unauthorised settlement in Subhash Mohalla in North East Delhi, a BLO said that there were 15-20 houses carrying the same number because of division of larger plots into smaller ones.

The recognised political parties in Delhi are also

taking part in the door-to-door survey through their booth level agents (BLAs) to assist people in filling up and submitting the forms.

The national capital has 13,033 polling stations across seven Lok Sabha and 70 Assembly constituencies.

During the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, the BLOs will provide each voter with two copies of the enumeration form to fill out their details as per the last SIR in 2002.

One form will be kept as an acknowledgement, while the other will be returned to the BLO. No document needs to be submitted along with the enumeration forms.

The form must be filled by each voter so that their names appear in the final electoral roll to be published on October 7.

Names of those who fail to fill up the forms will be removed from the draft roll that will be published on August 5, according to the CEO's office.

Each BLO will make at least three visits to any house found locked during the door-to-door survey.

Delhi has 1.45 crore voters, including 77.11 lakh male and 67.98 lakh female electors. The electoral rolls were frozen on June 16 and by that date, Delhi had 1,45,10,298 registered voters.

Delhi sees 98% rise in prosecutions for wrong-side driving



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prosecutions for wrong-side driving rose by 98 per cent, and challans for unauthorised parking went up by 36.5 per cent in Delhi in the first six months of 2026 compared with the corresponding period last year, according to official data.

The police intensified enforcement after a push from Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

The enforcement figures were reviewed by Sandhu during a meeting attended by the commissioner of police, special commissioner of police (traffic), joint commissioners of police (traffic) and deputy commissioners of police (traffic).

The LG also directed the traffic police to maintain sustained enforcement and strict action against riding

without helmets and triple riding on two-wheelers.

According to the data, challans for wrong-side driving increased from 1,72,897 between Jan 1 and June 25, 2025, to 3,42,381 during the corresponding period this year, registering a 98 per cent increase.

While prosecutions for unauthorised parking rose by 36.5 per cent, from 7,78,258 to 10,62,350 in the same period.

Police also registered 2,033 FIRs for driving on the wrong side between January 1 and June 25 this year, indicating stricter criminal enforcement against the dangerous traffic violation, the data showed. The Eastern Range, comprising some of the city's most congested and crowded roads and commercial areas, recorded the highest proportional increase in action against wrong-side driving.

Woman alleges sexual harassment in moving car, accused apprehended

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

A 24-year-old woman accused a man known to her of sexually harassing and molesting her inside a moving car in Delhi's Mandawali after he allegedly lured her out on the pretext of treating her to momos.

A senior Delhi police officer said they apprehended the accused, identified as Vikas.

According to the complaint, the woman agreed to

accompany the accused after he invited her to eat momos. During the drive, he allegedly told her he needed to refill the car's CNG and took her room key. However, instead of heading to a CNG station, he allegedly drove towards a deserted location.

The woman alleged that once the car reached the isolated stretch, the accused began making obscene remarks, demanded sexual favours and touched her inappropriately.

She also claimed he pre-



vented her from getting out of the vehicle despite her repeated pleas.

As the situation escalated, the woman started recording the incident on her mobile phone. According to the police, the video purportedly captures her pleading with the accused to let her go. She

Besides incentives, new EV policy focuses on transport sector reforms: CM Rekha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The new EV policy not only offers incentives on buying an electric vehicle, but it also provides a roadmap for structural reforms in the transport sector, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Tuesday. The chief minister said the previous EV policy, introduced in 2020, played its part in starting Delhi's shift toward electric mobility but was built on a flawed assumption that offering subsidies alone would be enough to drive large-scale adoption.

"What Delhi now needed was a comprehensive policy that would gradually transform the entire transport system towards electric mobility," she said.

According to officials, the EV Policy 2026 was approved by the LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday, after which the transport department will notify the policy and launch a separate portal.



"EV policy 2026 goes beyond offering incentives for purchasing electric vehicles and lays out a clear roadmap up to March 2030 for structural reforms in the transport sector, expansion of charging infrastructure, a stronger institutional framework and the phased electrification of different vehicle categories," the chief minister said.

"Building on that framework, the new government has introduced a clear programme of phased manda-

electric vehicles," the chief minister's office said in a statement.

In addition, from January 1 next year, all new auto-rickshaws will be registered only as electric vehicles, ensuring a complete transition of this segment to electric mobility, Gupta further said.

The chief minister said the institutional framework under the new policy has also been strengthened.

While the earlier policy had only an EV Cell and the State EV Board, the new framework includes the Delhi EV Apex Committee, a High-Powered Committee and a dedicated EV Cell, she further said.

Keeping in mind the environmental aspects, the new policy also introduces battery traceability, from manufacturing to recycling through digital tracking, collection centres and a public-private-partnership (PPP) based recycling system, officials said.

Two Bangladeshi nationals apprehended

ANUSHKA DAS
■ New Delhi

The Foreigner Cell of the North West District Police apprehended two Bangladeshi nationals residing illegally in Delhi. One, aged 25, had previously been deported from India and is accused of re-entering the country without authorisation.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Akanksha Yadav stated that the operation occurred on the morning of June 25 in the N.S. Mandi area of Azadpur, under the Mahendra Park Police Station. The action was based on specific intelligence regarding the presence of Bangladeshi nationals in the district.

Police identified the apprehended individuals as MD Ruhul Amin alias Tuli Das, 25, from Madhupur in Tangail district, and MD Jibon Miah alias Lily, 36, from Brahmanbaria district, both in Bangladesh.

Police said MD Ruhul Amin



was previously apprehended by the Foreigners' Cell in June 2025 and deported from India. He is accused of re-entering the country illegally and was traced again in the Mahendra Park area.

A team led by Inspector Vipin Kumar of the Foreigner Cell, under the supervision of ACP Rajeev Dhaka, was formed to act on the intelligence. The team conducted surveillance in the area and apprehended the two Bangladeshi nationals.

Police stated that both men had been residing in North-West Delhi without valid travel documents.

The Pioneer Classified

• CHANGE OF NAME •

I, REEMA W/o SUNIL R/o R-5/3, Model Town-III, Delhi-110009, UID 758717870080, That I have declare the both name REEMA and BIJANTI KUMARI is same person and I declare my name is BIJANTI KUMARI in future for all purposes.

I, No.14658780P Hav Tapan Kumar Giri, R/o- Vill- Purba Rania, PO- Dadanpatrabarh, Dist- Purba Medinipur, W.B- 721455, declare that my Father's name is wrongly mentioned as Subodh Giri in my service record whereas his correct name is Subodh Chandra Giri, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(01)C I, Firoz Ali Khan, Father of No.16125371L SPR Suraj Ali Khan, R/o- Vill- Kotalghata, PO- Kushberia, P.S- Uluberia, Dist- Howrah, W.B- 711316, have changed my name from Firoz Ali Khan to Firoj Khan, vide affidavit dated 30/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(02)C I, Lxmi, Mother of- No.6504818A SEP Amar Nilajkar, R/o- 194 Tanaji Galli Rankundaye, Teh & Dist- Belgavi, Karnataka- 590018, have changed my name from Lxmi to Laxmi Nilajkar, vide affidavit dated 30/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(03)C I, M Venkateswara Reddy, Father of No.17006164L Nk Mudimala Venkata Reddy, R/o- H.No.- 2/94, Basuvupalli (Vill), Mukthapuram (Post), Komarole (M), Markapuram (Dist), A.P.- 523369, have changed my name from M Venkateswara Reddy to Mudimala Venkateswara Reddy, vide affidavit dated 30/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(04)C I, M Eswaramma, Mother of No.17006164L Nk Mudimala Venkata Reddy, R/o- H.No.- 2/94, Basuvupalli (Vill), Mukthapuram (Post), Komarole (M), Markapuram (Dist), A.P.- 523369, have changed my name from M Eswaramma to Mudimala Eswaramma, vide affidavit dated 30/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is publically notified that the Flat No. 05, 9th Floor, Tower -05, Paras Tiera, Plot No. GH-01, Sector-137, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, UP-201307 has been allotted in the name of Shri Syed Mohammed Javed & Smt. Shagufta Begum had sold the said flat, on the basis of GPA was executed in favour of Shri Junaid Afaq S/o Shri S.M. Afaq R/o Tower-9-1902, Jaypee Aman, Sector-151, Noida, Distt. Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201310. So with the help of the notice.
It is informed the transfer of the above flat goes in favour of Ms. Nazreen Jahan D/o Mr. Hanifor Rahman Saharia R/o Milanpur, Bye Lane-4, Bellola, Kamrup Metro, Assam.
If anyone has/have any objection he/she may submit his/her, objection in the Housing Department of Noida Authority along with sufficient proofs within 15 days of the publication this notice.
Syed Mohammed Javed

Public Notice
This is to inform the general public that M/s. V Connect Hotels & Resorts are the owner of the Plot No. Water Rate Old 64 & New No. 71, area measuring 207.56 sq. yards i.e. 173.54 sq. meter, situated in Mohalla Mathura Darwaja, Vrindavan, Tehsil & District Mathura through Sale Deed dated 29.07.2022 as doc. no. 12191 executed by (1) Mr. Pankaj Bansal & (2) Mr. Vishal Bansal in favour of M/s. V Connect Hotels & Resorts in respect of Plot No. Water Rate Old 64 & New No. 71, area measuring 207.56 sq. yards i.e. 173.54 sq. meter.
M/s. V Connect Hotels & Resorts are in the process of mortgaging the said property with Hero Fincorp Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-day period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.
If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-day period by contacting Law Firm: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. Landline: +9112-04498713, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. SHARANJEET KAUR who is owner of BUILT UP FIRST FLOOR (SOUTHERN PORTION RHS) WITHOUT ROOF/TERRACE RIGHTS PART OF PROPERTY BEARING NO. WZ-49, AREA MEASURING 83.4-1/2 SQ.YDS. OUT OF KHASRA NO. 1, ETC/883/2950, SITUATED IN THE AREA OF VILLAGE NANGLI JALIB, COLONY KNOWN AS KRISHNA PARK EXTN. GALI NO. 10, NEW DELHI by virtue of Sale Deed dated 28.06.2024, bearing Document no.2024/25/117671, Volume no.11892, Book no.1, pages no.93-110 dated 28.06.2024. SRO-West Janakpuri executed by Mrs. Josephena Devassy (Josephena Devassy), now Mrs. SHARANJEET KAUR is intend to mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667377

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is to inform to the public at large Mr. Natwar Nagar had acquired Property No. 791/2, measuring 109 sq. yds., Khara No. 299, situated at Sukhdev Nagar, Kotla Mubarakpur, New Delhi vide Relinquishment Deed dt. 17.08.2022 executed by Mrs. Kesar, Mrs. Kaushalya, Sumitra Mital, Mrs. Sampati Goyal, Mr. Mam Raj in favour of Mr. Natwar Nagar (all L's of late Mr. Madan Lal) and Now Mr. Natwar Nagar is the undupoted owner of above said property and is willing to Mortgage the said property with SHFG India Credit Company Limited.
OR
Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said Property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance howsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents as below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such person shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.
Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H No. 26/161, Basement, Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi -110024

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED
NOTICE INVITING e - TENDER
Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the work :
Tender No. T26P750010: Construction of new civil foundation for 2 Nos 220KV CGL make circuit breaker, construction of Rain water harvesting, security guard room and other require civil works at 220KV Ceeta Colony and Construction of approach rail cum road at 220 Kv GIS Substation RK Puram.
For complete details of the tender please visit following websites:-
<https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_294379_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0064-250626
Last date for bid submission:- **17.07.2026, 13:00 Hrs.**
All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

Axis Bank Ltd., Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida (U.P.)-201301.
Registered Office : "TRISHUL" - 3RD Floor Opp. Samarathwar Temple, Near Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006.
APPENDIX IV [Refer Rule – 8(1)] POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)
Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued demand notice dated 20-Jan-2026 calling MR. RAJU SINGH & MRS. RUBY to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs. 6,92,811/- (Rupees Six Lakh Ninety Two Thousand Eight Hundred Eleven Only) due as on 20-Jan-2026 and interest and cost thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) above said having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s) / Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) and the Public in General that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on 27-06-2026. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s) /Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) above said in particular and the Public in General is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount of Rs. 6,92,811/- (Rupees Six Lakh Ninety Two Thousand Eight Hundred Eleven Only) as on 20-Jan-2026 together with further interest thereon at the contractual rate of interest till the date of payment & expenses thereon. The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s)'s attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.
Description of immovable property All that part and parcel of Property bearing: Flat No 0251 (Type – C), On Ground Floor in Tower 35, Built In The Project Named As "Dineshnagar", Situated At N-24, Plakhuwa, Pargana Dasna, Tehsil- Hapur, Distt- Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh And Bounded As Under - East : As Per Title Deed, West : As Per Title Deed, North : As Per Title Deed, South : As Per Title Deed
Please Note That As Mention In Sub Section 13 Of Section 13 Of The Aforesaid Act, You Shall Not Transfer By Way Of Sale, Lease Or Otherwise Any Of The Assets Stated Under Securely Referred To In This Notice Without Priorwritten Consent Of Our Bank.
Dated: 01-07-2026, Place: GHAZIABAD
Sd/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

New Okhla Industrial Development Authority
Main Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida, G.B. Nagar (U.P.)
Website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in
E-TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender are invited from firms/contractors registered with UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on NOIDA Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <http://tender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes / amendments & corrigendum etc.
(A)
1. **32/GM/AO/Sr.M. (E&M)-II/2026-27/ET,** Annual Maintenance of street Light, Park Light, of E&M-II Area, (Sector-19, 20, 26, 27, 55, 56, 57, 58, 59, 60, 66, 67, 68, 70, 121, 123, Vill-Garhi Chaukhandi & Bishanpura, Noida. Cost Rs. 86.91 Lacs.
Which can be uploaded by date: 14.07.2026 Upto 5.00 PM. pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: 15.07.2026 at 11.00 AM
(B)
1. **23/GM(E/M)/SM(E/M)-I/E.T./2026-27,** Construction of Fountain in Sector-93B Noida. Cost Rs. 48.01 Lacs.
2. **04/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27, S/I/T/C of 02 Nos CNG Furnace in CNG Crimination at Antim Niwas Sector-94, Noida. Cost Rs. 99.84 Lacs.**
3. **08/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27,** Supply of 82.5 KVA DG set and Internal Electrification at CNC Furnance Building Hall Antim Niwas Sector-94, Noida. Cost Rs. 32.19 Lacs.
4. **12/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27,** Providing Street Lighting arrangement on Ponds at Village-Sultanpur, Noida. Cost Rs. 35.93 Lacs.
5. **14/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27,** Beautification work at Expressway Near Sector-14A, 15A Noida. Cost Rs. 36.20 Lacs.
6. **19/GM(E/M)/Sr.M (E/M)-IV/2026-27,** Annual Operation & Maintenance of UFA Musical Fountain System, Water Screen Laser, Video Projector etc. (Multimedia Show) at YRF Park Sector-15A, Noida. Cost Rs. 60.71 Lacs
Which can be uploaded by date: 07.07.2026 Upto 5.00 PM. pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date: - 08.07.2026 at 11.00 AM.
General Manager (E&M) NOIDA
CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

सर्वजनिक सूचना
हम, भगत सिंह पुत्र श्री ईश्वर सिंह व रेखा देवी पत्नी भगत सिंह निवासीगण गाँव बाघन को तहसील मानेसर जिला गुरुग्राम, हरियाणा के ब्यान करते हैं कि हमारा पुत्र जितेश कुमार व उसकी पत्नी डिप्पल हमारे कहने-सुनने से बाहर हैं, हम इन दोनों को अपनी चल-अचल संपत्ति से बेदखल करते हैं। आज के बाद हम दोनों का इन दोनों से कोई वारलुक नहीं होगी।
यदि कोई व्यक्ति इन दोनों से कोई भी लेन-देन करता है तो उसका वह स्वयं निम्मेवार रहेगा। हमारी कोई निम्मेवार नहीं होगी।
PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Smt. Shalini Chaudhary to inform to the public at large that Smt. Shalini Chaudhary is Purchasing the FIRST AND SECOND FLOOR WITH ITS ROOF TERRACE/ISKY RIGHTS WITH AN AREA MEASURING 56.66 SQ. MTRS. MORE PARTICULARLY SHOWN IN RED COLOUR IN THE PLAN ANNEXED HERETO, FORMING PART OF FREE HOLD BUILT PROPERTY BEARING MPL NO.22231 IN WARD NO.XII, SITUATED AT SHORA KOTHI, SUBZ MANDI, DELHI-110007 from Smt. Preeti & Smt. Pooja Sain who become the owner through Sale deed dated 03.09.2025 (Doc. No.2025/19/11454) Previously, this property was registered in the names of Shri Lala Pura Chand, Sh. Mangal Chand, Sh. Jhaboo Mal, Sh. Jung Bahadur Rhotiagi. Following their demise, their legal heirs, (1) SMT. SUJATA DINODIA (2) DR. MOHAN ROHTAGI (3) SH. NARENDRA KUMAR ROHTAGI (4) SH. UPENDRA ROHTAGI (5) SH. SUNIL ROHTAGI (6) DR. BIJENDRA ROHTAGI (7) SH. SURENDRA ROHTAGI, have sold this property to Smt. Preeti & Smt. Pooja Sain now Smt. Shalini Chaudhary intend to Purchase and mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667377

DU receives 82,940 registrations for UG admissions 2026-27

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

The University of Delhi has received around 82,940 registrations for undergraduate admissions for the 2026-27 academic session through its Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) as of Tuesday evening, officials said. The university commenced the first phase of registrations on June 26 for candidates who appeared in CUET-UG 2026 and wish to seek admission to its colleges.

Alongside the continuing registration process, the university will announce revised combinations for multiple BA programmes within the next two to three days, Dean of

Admissions Haneet Gandhi said. The combinations will be declared alongside the commencement of the second phase of undergraduate admissions. The revision was decided in a data-driven effort to fix chronically low seat occupancy in courses such as Urdu, Arabic, Persian, Bengali, and Telugu by pairing them with subjects that attract stronger student interest.

Gandhi said the revised combinations are based entirely on analysis of admission patterns over recent years. "We are going to make some changes in the BA programme combinations, as some of the combinations will be revised. We have analysed the data and trends

from the last few years. The decision is completely data-driven. The information will be released within this week, along with the start of the second phase," she said.

Explaining the logic behind the exercise to The Pioneer, Gandhi offered a specific example of how subject pairing affects enrolment. She said if a subject like Urdu is offered in combination with Mathematics, fewer students opt for it, but if Mathematics is replaced with Political Science, a subject that draws far greater interest among undergraduate applicants, admission numbers for Urdu Honours are likely to rise as a result of being bundled with a more



popular discipline. "We will completely look into the data and then decide the combination. We will try different combinations. The purpose is to increase the admission numbers in courses which normally interest fewer

students," Gandhi said.

She clarified that the degree awarded will remain unchanged regardless of how combinations are revised. "However, the honours will be awarded as earlier. We will only change combinations of

undergraduate courses," she said. The new combinations will be declared within two to three days, she added.

The exercise follows the recommendations of a university committee constituted earlier to examine ways of improving seat-fill rates in undergraduate programmes through restructuring of BA discipline combinations.

Among the panel's key recommendations was that colleges reassess existing combinations and merge low-demand subjects with more popular disciplines to improve enrolment, along with a specific suggestion that languages with consistently low admissions, even at established on-campus col-

leges and departments, be paired with another discipline within a single BA programme.

Admissions to 73 undergraduate programmes and more than 100 BA programme combinations across 67 colleges will continue to be based solely on candidates' CUET-UG 2026 scores, subject to programme-specific eligibility criteria set by the university. Candidates are required to register on the CSAS portal using their CUET-UG 2026 application number.

After completing initial registration, candidates will move into the second phase of CSAS, where they will submit their preferences for programme and college com-

binations. During this phase, candidates will also be required to map their CUET-UG test papers against the subjects they studied in Class 12. The university said only language and domain-specific CUET papers corresponding to subjects passed in Class 12 will be considered for determining programme eligibility and calculating scores.

Based on this mapping, the university will determine which programmes each candidate is eligible for before inviting preferences for programme and college combinations.

The schedule for the second phase of CSAS is expected to be announced this week, the university said.

Govt clears two schemes for heritage monuments' conservation, development

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Delhi Cabinet has approved two new schemes for the conservation and development of the city's heritage monuments. The government allowed public sector undertakings, private companies, NGOs, trusts, and individual citizens to adopt any of 75 historic monuments under the Delhi government's care for a five-year period.

The adopting partners, designated Monument Mitras, are expected to save the government an average of around Rs 4.5 lakh per monument annually in maintenance costs, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Tuesday.

The two schemes, launched under the "Hamare Smarak, Hamara Gaurav" initiative, are the Delhi Chief Minister Monument Adoption Scheme and the Scheme for Grant-in-Aid to Trusts, NGOs,

Foundations and Institutions for Conservation, Restoration and Development Works of Monuments. Both cover monuments of local importance protected by the Department of Archaeology under the Delhi Ancient and Historical Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 2004, meaning sites that do not fall under the Archaeological Survey of India's jurisdiction.

Under the Adoption Scheme, Monument Mitras will bear the full cost of providing and maintaining visitor amenities at their adopted site, including cleanliness, security, lighting, and

light-and-sound facilities. The Chief Minister clarified that any revenue generated by a Monument Mitra through an approved event or activity at the site must be reinvested entirely into the monument's maintenance and development and cannot be retained as private profit.

The adoption period will run for five years, governed by a tripartite Memorandum of Understanding between the Delhi government, the concerned land-owning agency, and the Monument Mitra, with regular monitoring and periodic stakeholder feedback built into the process.

Tax officials directed to follow dress code

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To maintain professionalism and decorum, the Delhi government's Trade and Taxes department has instructed all its officials to follow a standard 'dress code' and avoid turning up at the office in casuals or inappropriate clothes.

The department, which comes under the charge of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, was recently in the news over the mass transfer of 162 officials, including three assistant commissioners, over "serious irregularities" during her surprise visit in April.

A recent circular issued by the Special Commissioner of the Trade and Taxes department directed that "all officers and officials of the department will ensure that their attire is decent, sober and appropriate for a government workplace. The attire during office hours should reflect professionalism and

the dignity associated with public service."

"Clothing, which is casual, inappropriate or inconsistent with the decorum expected in a government office, will be avoided," the circular stated.

Proper decorum, discipline and professional conduct in government offices are essential for ensuring an efficient, dignified and citizen-friendly work environment, it said, asking all officials to maintain "appropriate standards of dress code", conduct and etiquette while in office.

The officers and officials of the department will report to the office in a "neat and presentable manner" and maintain professional conduct while dealing with colleagues, visitors and members of the public, it said.

Further, the officers were directed to occupy and work from their designated workplace or workstation and strictly adhere to the seating arrangement in the office.

DMRC opens Delhi Ridge interpretation centre at Patel Chowk station

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) on Tuesday opened an interpretation centre at Patel Chowk station to create awareness about the ecological importance of the Delhi Ridge.

The Delhi Ridge Interpretation Centre has been set up to showcase the unique ecological features of the Delhi Ridge, often referred to as Delhi's "green lungs", and has been established in compliance with directions of the Supreme Court following recommendations of the Central Empowered Committee (CEC), the DMRC said in a statement.

The centre also aims to educate people about its role in maintaining the city's environmental balance.

The facility was inaugurated in the presence of Chandra Prakash Goyal, Chairman of the Central

Empowered Committee under the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, P Vishwakannan, Chief Conservator of Forests, Department of Forests and Wildlife, Delhi government and Vikas Kumar, Managing Director of the DMRC.

Speaking at the inauguration, Goyal said the interpretation centre would serve as an important destination for people interested in understanding the history, heritage and ecology of the Delhi Ridge.

He said the Ridge was

expected to witness further conservation and development efforts in the coming years, which could also be reflected in the centre's exhibits. He said the facility would help generate greater public awareness about the conservation of the ecologically sensitive Ridge.

According to the DMRC, the centre has been designed to educate visitors about the Ridge's biodiversity and its contribution to Delhi's environmental health through a series of information panels and exhibits.



THE INSTITUTE OF CHARTERED ACCOUNTANTS OF INDIA (Set up by an Act of Parliament)

Celebrates
78th CHARTERED ACCOUNTANTS' DAY
1st July 2026

3:30 PM onwards | Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi



Chief Guest

SHRI C. P. RADHAKRISHNAN
Hon'ble Vice-President of India

ICAI Leadership

CA. Prasanna Kumar D, President, ICAI | CA. Mangesh Kinare, Vice-President, ICAI

Technical Sessions 2 CPE Hrs.

Income-tax Act, 2025

CA. (Dr.) Girish Ahuja
Tax Expert

Capital Market & Investment

CA. Nilesh Shah Investment Expert
CA. Sunil Singhania Investment Expert



Please Join:
<https://live.icai.org/caday2026>

Entry by Invitation only
(Please carry your ID Proof along with Invitation Card)

STRONG NETWORK PRESENCE



WORLD'S LARGEST ACCOUNTING BODY WITH OVER
15 LAKH MEMBERS AND STUDENTS



5 REGIONAL COUNCILS
186 BRANCHES



54 OVERSEAS CHAPTERS
31 REPRESENTATIVE OFFICES



GLOBAL PRESENCE IN
85 CITIES ACROSS
47 COUNTRIES

IN FOCUS



A monkey and its juvenile feed amid monsoon showers in Haldwani PTI

23 political parties write to CJI on SIR, role of ECI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Twenty-three political parties along with an independent MP on Tuesday sent a joint letter to Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on the SIR process, the role of the Election Commission and other election-related issues.

The signatories include all major INDIA bloc parties, as well as the AAP and DMK, which have distanced themselves from the alliance.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh gave this information in a post on X, saying the Opposition parties are firmly anchored in "SURE Solidarity, Unity and Resistance".

"21 political parties plus one independent attended the INDIA Janbandhan meeting on June 8, 2026, where a decision was taken to address a joint letter to the Hon'ble Chief Justice of India on the SIR process of the Election Commission of India and other election-related issues," Ramesh said on X.

"Accordingly, a joint letter now signed by 23 political parties plus one independent has been sent to the Hon'ble Chief Justice of India today,"



Jairam Ramesh

he said. The joint letter has been signed by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, TMC chief Mamata Banerjee, RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren, J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, Left party leaders, and Independent MP Kapil Sibal, among others, sources said. TMC leader Derek O'Brien said the letter has also been signed by the Aam Aadmi Party and the DMK.

"Good going from INDIA. And yes, @AamAadmiParty @arivalayam DMK also signed the joint letter to CJI," he said on X. "The letter is a total teamwork by all INDIA bloc parties," O'Brien told the media later.

IAS Officer, 2 Ex-bankers arrested in ₹504 crore Haryana fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI has arrested a senior IAS officer and two former bank officers in connection with the alleged embezzlement of ₹504 crore from the Haryana Government accounts maintained in IDFC First Bank in Chandigarh, officials said on Tuesday.

The alleged actions of the IAS officer, Pardeep Kumar, who was posted as Member Secretary, Haryana State Pollution Control Board (HSPCB), resulted in the misappropriation of funds and caused a net loss of approximately ₹169 crore to the Government, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) said in a statement. "The investigation has revealed that the



actions of Pardeep Kumar, as Member Secretary, had a direct nexus with the fraud. He himself handled the entire investment related work at his level.

Funds for fixed deposits were sent to IDFC First Bank far in excess of the prescribed limits. "For creating the fixed deposits, the funds of HSPCB were first transferred into an account opened at IDFC First Bank,

Sector 32 Branch, Chandigarh," a CBI spokesperson said in the statement.

Surprisingly, there is no record which the department could produce with regard to opening of this account, the officer said. "The conspiracy was so deep that the account got opened without any approvals and funds were transferred into the account in the name of

creating fixed deposits. The investigation conducted so far has revealed that no fixed deposits were created in this bank," the statement said.

Instead, the agency alleged, fraudulent debit transactions were carried out from this account, resulting in the misappropriation of Government funds and causing a net loss of approximately ₹169 crore to the state Government.

"This represents the single-largest financial loss suffered by any of the affected Government departments of Haryana in the overall scam (of ₹504 crore)," it said.

The spokesperson said that Kumar was not joining the investigation despite repeated efforts.

CM Revanth Reddy hits out at BRS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Hitting out at opposition BRS over its criticism of the Congress Government's agriculture record, Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Tuesday said the Government had spent about Rs 1.75 lakh crore on farmer welfare since it took office 30 months ago.

Speaking after releasing funds under the 'Rythu Bandhu' investment support scheme for farmers, he dismissed BJP national president Nitin Nabin's call to party activists to work towards a win in the next Telangana assembly polls.

It took 15 years for the BJP to win assembly polls in West Bengal, and the saffron party would meet the same



fate in Telangana, he said. Taking strong exception to the BRS questioning the Congress Government's performance in the agriculture sector, he said the Government had implemented several measures for farmers,

including a ₹20,677-crore farm loan waiver, ₹36,000 crore under the 'Rythu Bharosa' scheme, ₹30,000 crore on free power and ₹4,000 crore as bonus for fine variety paddy.

"This way, the Government has spent about ₹1.75 lakh crore for the farming community. We spend ₹6,000 crore every month for farmers on an average; you have not spent even ₹2,500 crore. Is it we who made farming a festival, or you?" the CM said. The Government would allocate ₹9,000 crore in nine days under the first phase of 'Rythu Bharosa', he added.

Reddy said he was ready for a debate on the Congress Government's last 30 months, the 10-year rule of BRS, and the 12-year rule of the NDA Government at the Centre.

Assam flood situation remains grim; one person dies, 46,000 people affected

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

The flood situation in Assam remained grim on Tuesday with one person killed in the deluge and more than 46,000 people affected in six districts, an official bulletin said.

Two major rivers, including the Brahmaputra, were flowing above the danger level, with damage to infrastructure also caused in different parts. The Assam State

Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), in its flood bulletin, said one woman died in flood waters in Sissiborgaon in Dhemaj district, the first casualty in the deluge in the State this year.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma assured of all assistance to the affected areas, with ministers touring the flood-hit districts. "We are leaving no stone unturned in our flood response. While I continue to monitor the situ-

ation closely, my Cabinet colleagues are on the ground overseeing relief efforts, protection measures & ensuring timely assistance," Sarma said in a post on X.

Water Resources Minister Susanta Borghoi and Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Keshab Mahanta visited several affected areas and interacted with the people to ensure timely relief. "As part of the Assam Government's



ongoing flood response, I visited the flood-affected areas along the Chakrang River in Gohpur today, following the directions of Hon'ble Chief Minister Dr @himantabiswa Dangoriya," Borghoi, who was accompanied by Mahanta, said in a post on the social media site. "Necessary instructions were issued to the concerned authorities to take immediate flood protection measures," he added.

VHP distances itself from Rai

The emergency session, called by Treasurer Govind Dev Giri, will decide on the resignations, introduce structural reforms, and address governance failures. Sources say the Trust plans to add more checks and balances and bring in younger members or technocrats.

The Trust is led by 87-year-old Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, a respected saint from Ayodhya's Mani Ram Das Ki Chavani.

The Trust faces increasing pressure to restore its credibility. Moving the meeting earlier shows how urgent it is to address the fallout from the ongoing police investigation into the alleged siphoning of devotees' offerings at the Ram Temple.

The Trust has promised to cooperate with investigators fully and said that all valuables donated by devotees are safe. The Trust itself requested the SIT probe after problems were identified in early June. This scandal has exposed major weaknesses in the temple's internal controls, even though it receives large donations from across India and abroad. While lower-level employees have been arrested, critics, including opposition leaders, say senior Trust officials should also be held responsible for how such a large diversion could happen under their watch.

The deletion of old CCTV footage and the reported removal of an accounts officer who raised concerns have increased suspicions. The VHP's decision to step back, while clarifying its role after the Supreme Court verdict, highlights a bigger issue: religious trusts that manage public faith and money must be fully transparent, no matter their background.

More people are now calling for independent audits, real-time digital tracking of donations, and stronger outside oversight. The Ram Mandir was built through the sacrifices and contributions of many ordinary devotees. Losing trust in its management would betray that collective faith more than the actions of a few individuals. The July 6 Trust meeting is a chance to show real commitment by making meaningful reforms.

US SC upholds birthright citizenship rights

The Republican president's restrictions had been blocked by several lower courts and had not taken effect anywhere in the US

During arguments in April, both conservative and liberal justices questioned the order's legality in a momentous case that was magnified by Trump's unprecedented attendance in the courtroom.

The case framed another test of Trump's asser-

tions of executive power that defy long-standing precedent for a court with a conservative majority and a robust view of presidential power that has largely ruled in his favour. In the notable exceptions when the court has not, Trump has responded with starkly personal criticisms of the justices.

The justices ruled on Trump's appeal of a lower-court ruling from New Hampshire that struck down the citizenship restrictions.

The birthright citizenship order, which Trump signed on the first day of his second term, is part of his administration's broad immigration crack-down. Birthright citizenship was the first Trump immigration-related policy to reach the court for a final ruling. The justices previously struck down global tariffs Trump had imposed under an emergency powers law that had never been used that way.

Trump reacted furiously to the late February tariffs decision, saying he was ashamed of the justices who ruled against him and calling them unpatriotic.

He also seemed to recognise the court was likely to rule against him on birthright citizenship, too, using his Truth Social platform to criticise "dumb judges and justices" and wealthy pregnant women from China and elsewhere who come to the US to give birth so their newborns will have American citizenship.

Trump's order would have upended widely held views that the 14th Amendment confers citizenship on everyone born in the US, excluding only the children of foreign diplomats and those born to a foreign occupying force.

The amendment was intended to ensure that Black people, including former slaves, had citizenship, though the Citizenship Clause is written more broadly. "All persons born or naturalised in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof, are citizens of the United States and of the State wherein they reside," it reads.

In a series of decisions, lower courts have struck down Trump's executive order as illegal. The decisions have invoked the high court's 1898 ruling in Wong Kim Ark, which held that the US-born child of Chinese nationals was a citizen.

The Trump administration argued that the common view of citizenship is wrong, asserting that children of noncitizens are not "subject to the jurisdiction" of the United States and therefore are not entitled to citizenship.

More than one-quarter of a million babies born in the US each year would have been affected by the executive order, according to research by the Migration Policy Institute and Pennsylvania State University's Population Research Institute.

While Trump has largely focused on illegal immigration in his rhetoric and actions, the birthright citizenship restrictions also would have applied to people who are legally in the United

FROM PAGE - 1

States, including students and applicants for green cards or permanent resident status.

NITI Aayog makes a big push for tourism

It also called for rationalising e-visa categories into broader classes — tourism, business, short-term medical, short-term student and dependents — alongside strengthening digital and payment infrastructure through real-time verification, global payment integration and biometric checks.

The report said restrictive visa requirements depress inbound travel, citing research indicating reductions of up to 70 per cent. It noted that visa liberalisation and facilitative measures such as E-Visas and VoA have increased arrivals in other markets. Between 2008 and 2023, global pre-departure visa requirements declined from about 77 to 47 per cent, while e-visa usage rose sixfold. Evidence from countries from the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) and the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (Asean) suggested that visa facilitation could raise tourist arrivals by up to 25 per cent.

India's visa openness remained below that of its peers. Its UN Tourism Visa Openness Index score of 38.14 was below the global average of 40 and trailed countries such as Malaysia, Sri Lanka, Thailand and Indonesia. India currently offers visa-free entry only to Nepal, Bhutan and the Maldives, while VoA is limited to a small set of nationalities. Although the e-visa covers 175 countries, it is constrained by category complexity, short stays, annual caps and limited flexibility for repeat travel.

Among its biggest recommendations is the introduction of a 90-day, multiple-entry Visa-on-Arrival for travellers from selected countries. Eligible visitors would be able to obtain visas at designated airports and seaports without applying in advance, reducing paperwork and making India a more accessible destination.

It identified persistent frictions in the e-visa process, including fragmented portals requiring repeated data entry, extensive form fields, technical failures such as crashes and session timeouts, incompatibility with browsers and mobile devices, rejection of foreign card payments and weak customer support.

The report also noted that a poor interface has led to the proliferation of fraudulent lookalike sites. Industry concerns, including those raised by the World Travel & Tourism Council, were cited as highlighting reputational and operational costs. The report acknowledged recent measures such as expanded e-visa access, upgraded ports of entry, a multilingual helpline, an e-Arrival card and the National Payments

Corporation of India's UPI One World pilot, but said further improvements are required to ensure reliability. It concluded that a more facilitative entry regime, balanced with digital security, could increase arrivals, drive repeat visitation and raise tourism revenues.

It has also recommended removing the requirement for an Eating House Licence for food and beverage establishments, extending the validity of liquor licences and FSSAI registrations, and simplifying approvals through digital integration and single-window mechanisms.

It also proposed to extend the minimum validity of the All India Tourist Permit from 90 days to one year. And removal of the state-level entry taxes/fees on motor vehicles already holding the All India Tourist Permit.

The NITI Aayog report also proposed to liberalise building standards for hotels to enhance usable floor area and reduce construction costs to boost the hospitality sector.

A faltering monsoon, a nervous nation and an...

Northwest India has recorded a substantial rainfall deficit of 31 per cent, receiving 53.7 mm against the seasonal normal of 78.1 mm. The delayed arrival of the monsoon has kept Delhi, Haryana, Punjab and western Rajasthan under persistent heatwave conditions for much of June. Meanwhile, the southern peninsula is experiencing a rainfall deficit of 27 per cent, with 117.4 mm recorded against a normal of 161 mm. Although parts of Kerala and the west coast received periodic heavy showers, rainfall remained uneven across several southern States. The situation in East and Northeast India was no different as the region recorded 197.5 mm of rainfall against a normal 328.4 mm, a dip of 40 per cent.

At the State level, the rainfall distribution remained highly uneven. Among the worst-affected states were Jharkhand, which recorded a 59 per cent deficit, Chhattisgarh at 65 per cent below normal, Gujarat with an 82 per cent deficit, and Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu, which witnessed an alarming 84 per cent rainfall shortfall. Several northern States also remained rain-deficient, including Uttar Pradesh (50 per cent), Bihar (47 per cent), Punjab (47 per cent), Delhi (49 per cent), Haryana (29 per cent), Madhya Pradesh (33 per cent), Maharashtra (47 per cent), Tamil Nadu (32 per cent) and Kerala (34 per cent).

Satellite imagery has captured the formation of a nearly 1,500-km-long monsoon trough stretching from the northern Bay of Bengal to Jammu and Kashmir, a crucial weather feature that could pave the way for widespread rainfall over the region in the coming days. The satellite image from INSAT-3DS shows a broad swath

PM Modi speaks to Iran President Pezeshkian

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday held a telephonic conversation with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, welcoming the understanding reached ahead of the ceasefire and reaffirming India's long-standing position that conflicts must be resolved through dialogue and diplomacy.

During the conversation, President Pezeshkian briefed the Prime Minister on the recent developments in West Asia and outlined the way forward following the latest diplomatic efforts in the region. Prime Minister Modi welcomed the understanding reached and stressed that sustained engagement and diplomatic dialogue remain the only viable path to resolving regional tensions.

He also reiterated the need for continued efforts to ensure lasting peace and stability in West Asia. The Prime Minister further emphasised the importance of safeguarding freedom of navigation and uninterrupted commerce, underscoring India's interest in maintaining stability across the strategically significant region. Separately, President Pezeshkian had earlier extended a formal invitation to Prime Minister Modi to attend the funeral ceremonies of Iran's Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Representing India at the ceremony will be Bihar Governor Lieutenant General (Retd.) Syed Ata Hasnain and Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita.

According to the announced schedule, the public farewell ceremony will begin at 6 a.m. (local time) on



July 4 at Tehran's Imam Khomeini Grand Prayer Grounds, which will be opened to mourners from that time. India has consistently called for restraint, dialogue and diplomatic engagement in addressing tensions in West Asia while emphasising the importance of regional peace, stability and the protection of global trade routes.

This marks the third conversation between the two leaders since the conflict erupted in West Asia on February 28, with Israel and the United States on one side and Iran on the other.

The leaders had spoken earlier on March 12 and March 21. In those calls, Prime Minister Modi underscored India's priorities — the safety and well-being of Indian nationals in the region, including in Iran — and the importance of ensuring unhindered transit of energy and goods. He also extended greetings on Navroz and Eid.

On June 30, 2026 — PM Modi again held a telephone conversation with President Pezeshkian after the ceasefire understanding. He welcomed the understanding reached, reiterated India's support for resolving issues through dialogue and diplomacy, and stressed the need for lasting peace, stability, and freedom of navigation in West Asia.

Govt holds rates for small savings

The interest rates for PPF and post office savings deposit schemes have been retained at 7.1 per cent and 4 per cent, respectively.

The interest rate on the Kisan Vikas Patra will be 7.5 per cent, and the investments will mature in 115 months. The interest rate on the NSC will stay at 7.7 per cent for the July-September quarter.

Like the current quarter, the monthly income scheme will earn 7.4 per cent for investors in the second quarter as well. With this, the interest rates on small savings schemes, mainly operated by post offices and banks, have been left unchanged for the ninth consecutive quarter. The Government last changed the interest rate on some schemes in the fourth quarter of 2023-24.

Small savings schemes such as the PPF, NSC, Kisan Vikas Patra, Sukanya Samridhi Yojana, Senior Citizen Savings Scheme, and Recurring Deposit remain popular among risk-averse investors. The Government reviews the interest rates on these schemes every quarter.

It is 40.5°C, but Delhi feels a scorching 53.5°C

Delhi has missed its normal southwest monsoon onset date of June 27. The IMD has not yet announced an expected arrival date for the monsoon in the national capital but it is expected to be between June 4 and June 8.

New Army chief, General Seth takes charge

Prior to becoming the 31st Chief of the Army Staff (COAS), he served as the Vice Chief of the Army Staff. Gen Seth took over as the COAS at a time when the global geo-strategic environment remains dynamic, with challenges in the security domain becoming more pronounced due to technological advancements and the ever-changing character of modern warfare.

Prior to his appointment as the Vice Chief of the Army Staff on April 1, he headed the Pune-based Southern Command, and under his leadership, the elite command maintained a high degree of operational readiness during the Operation Sindoor last year.

Mobile app soon to help farmers assess soil health: Shivraj Chouhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh/Rewari

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Tuesday said the Government will soon come out with a mobile app for farmers to help them assess soil health while stressing the balanced and judicious use of fertilisers.

The Agriculture Minister also pitched for the adoption of natural farming practices to reduce dependency on chemical fertilisers.

Addressing a gathering in the closing ceremony of 'Khet Bachao Abhiyaan' in Bawal, Haryana's Rewari district, Chouhan expressed concern over the indiscriminate use of chemical fertilisers. The month-long 'Khet Bachao Abhiyan' was launched from Raisen district in Madhya Pradesh on June 1. The minister said that soon, farmers will be able to download an app on their mobile phones.

"You will stand in your field, and your mobile will tell you what nutrients are in your soil and how much fertiliser should be applied. We are working on this too, so that you do not face difficul-



ties. By using technology, I again request you to use balanced fertilisers," he said. Currently, farmers get soil health details in a physical card issued by the respective State Governments. Around 26 crore soil health cards have been issued across the country as of March 2026, according to official data. He urged farmers to stop the indiscriminate use of fertilisers, as excessive use of urea and DAP is gradually damaging the soil. "Because of the excessive use of fertilisers and pesticides, the health of our soil is gradually deteriorating," Chouhan said.

He also asked farmers to try their hands at natural

farming. "If natural farming is conducted correctly, production does not decrease." Chouhan observed that excessive use of chemical fertilisers and pesticides destroyed countless beneficial microorganisms in the soil and that earthworms, nature's own allies in maintaining soil fertility, had become increasingly rare in agricultural fields. This trend, he said, must be reversed through conscious efforts to restore biological balance, preserve biodiversity and reduce dependence on chemical inputs. According to him, sustainable farming practices are not merely an environmental necessity but also an eco-

nomic and health imperative for future generations. He also referred to concerns arising from climate change and the possible impact of the El Niño weather phenomenon. He noted that forecasts suggested lower rainfall in certain districts of Haryana and said that both the Centre and the State Government were jointly working on promoting crop varieties that require less water and mature more quickly, enabling farmers to maintain good productivity even under conditions of reduced rainfall. Chouhan lauded Haryana for its contribution to the agriculture sector. "Here in Haryana, MSP is given on 24 crops," he said, adding that under the Bhavantar Bharpai Yojna, farmers are getting the full value for their hard work on horticulture crops. He said Haryana fills the granaries of the nation. "There was a time when we had to bring red wheat from America. But today, because of the efforts of states like Haryana, the country's food reserves are full," he said.



Two NSCN-K insurgents surrender in Arunachal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

In a major boost to the ongoing counter-insurgency operations and peace initiatives in the Northeast, two active insurgents belonging to the NSCN-K (Nikki Sumi) faction voluntarily surrendered before a joint team of security forces in Arunachal Pradesh's Tirap district. The insurgents chose to shun the path of violence and laid down their arms before the Assam Rifles and the Tirap Police in the general area of Kheti on June 28. During the formal surrender, the duo handed over two pistols along with a cache of live ammunition. According to a statement issued by the Ministry of Defence, the successful surrender reflects the growing

confidence of local communities in the security forces and the Government's ongoing mainstreaming initiatives designed to bring misguided youth back into society. The two surrendered rebels have been taken into custody for necessary legal formalities, following which they will be integrated into the State's official rehabilitation procedures. According to the statement, this development is a direct result of sustained civil outreach programmes conducted by the Assam Rifles to restore long-term peace, security, and normalcy in the region. Security forces have reiterated their commitment to encouraging remaining insurgents to give up arms and join the path of peace, development, and nation-building.

**Karnataka Bank Ltd.**
Your Family Bank. Across India.

Asset Recovery Management Branch
8-B, First Floor, Rajendra Park,
Pusa Road
New Delhi-110 060

Phone : 011-40591567(Ext-231)
E-Mail : delhiarm@ktkbank.com
Website : www.karnatakabank.com
CIN : L55110KA1924PLC001128

SALE NOTICE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 read with proviso to rule 9(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to public in general and in particular to Borrower (s) and Guarantor (s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the secured Creditor, the Physical Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Karnataka Bank Ltd, the Secured Creditor on **27.02.2023**, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and "Whatever there is" on **01.08.2026**, for recovery of **Rs.33,50,640.85 [Rupees Thirty Three Lakhs Fifty Thousand Six Hundred Forty and Paise Eighty Five Only]** under i.e. (i) **Rs.30,47,337.83** under PSOD A/c No.558700600002401 along with future interest from 01.12.2024 (ii) **Rs.3,03,303.02** under PSDPN A/c No.5587001400002201 along with future interest from **28.11.2024, plus cost**, due to the **Karnataka Bank Ltd., Karol Bagh Branch**, Plot No.5439/71, Ground Floor, Main Arya Samaj Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005, the Secured creditor from (1) **M/s Elite Advertising & Marketing, represented by its proprietor, Mr.Arun Makkar S/o Mr. Har Bhagwan Das addressed at: Unit No.26, 1st Floor, CSC No.1, A-Block, Sec.16, Near Mother Dairy, Rohini, Delhi- 110086** (2) **Mr. Arun Makkar, S/o Mr. Har Bhagwan Das, addressed at: #G1/183-184, 2nd Floor, Sector-16, Rohini, Delhi-110089** (3) **Mrs. Charu Makkar, W/o Mr. Arun Makkar addressed at: #G1/183-184, 2nd Floor, Sector-16, Rohini, Delhi-110089, being borrowers/ guarantors/ co-obligants.**
DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY:
All that part and parcel of Commercial Property Shop/ Unit Bearing No.26, situated on First Floor, Block-A, CSC-1, Sector-16, measuring 8.57 sq.mtrs., Rohini, New Delhi- 110089, belonging to Mrs. Charu Makkar. **Boundaries: East: Shop No.24 West : Shop No.28 North : Shop No.27 South : Open**
Reserve Price / Upset Price below which the property may not be sold: Rs.12,60,000.00 (Rupees Twelve Lakh Sixty Thousand only) **Earnest money to be deposited/ tendered:** Rs.1,26,000.00 (Rupees One Lakh Twenty Six Thousand Only)
(The borrower's / mortgagor's attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured asset).
(This Notice shall also serve as Notice under Sub Rule (1) of Rule (9) of Security Interest Enforcement Rules-2002 to the Borrower/Guarantors)
For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to link in Karnataka Bank's Website i.e., **www.karnatakabank.com** under the head "Mega E-Auction on 01.08.2026"
The E-auction will be conducted through portal **https://bankauctions.in/** on **01.08.2026 from 11:30 A.M to 12:30 P.M** with unlimited extension of 05 minutes. The intending bidder is required to register their name at **https://bankauctions.in/** and get the user Id and password free of cost and get **online training on E-auction (tentatively on 31.07.2026)** from M/s.4closure, 605A, 6th Floor, Maitrivanam, Ameerpet, Hyderabad-500038, **Contact No.040-23836405, Mobile 8142000809, E-mail: info@bankauctions.in.**
Date : 30.06.2026
Place : New Delhi
Sd/- For Karnataka Bank Ltd
Chief Manager & Authorised Officer

 सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया Central Bank of India 1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911		Regional Office Delhi (North) 1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk, Delhi-110006.		E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE (Under SARFAESI Act 2002)						
APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES										
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable properties mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the Physical / Symbolic Possession of which have been taken by the Authorized officer of Central Bank of India, secured creditor, will be sold on 20-07-2026 under "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in www.centralbankofindia.co.in or (https://BAANKNET.com)										
DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTY TO BE AUCTIONED ON 20.07.2026 (15 DAY'S NOTICE)										
S No.	Branch Name	Authorised Officer / Branch Head	Name of the Account	Description of the Property and Owner Name	Demand Notice Date	Amount Dues (Rs. In Lakh)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price	EMD	Bid Increase
1	Angel's Public School	Rajesh Yadav 8349135200	Anju Devi	Prop No-1/801 (Plot No.- 72/74), Third Floor (With roof rights) Situated in the area of Village-Chandrawali alias Shahdara in the abadi of opp. Rehman Building West Rohitash Nagar, Ilaqa Shahadra, Dethi-110032 Owner-Anju Devi W/o Mr. Varun Jain Area : 369 Sq Ft	16-11-2024	Rs. 15.87 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	21-07-2025 Physical	Rs. 18,00,000.00	Rs. 1,80,000.00	Rs. 20,000.00
2	Arthala	Naveen Kumar 9220402685	Chander Kali	FLAT NO SF-2, LIG, SECOND FLOOR, BACK SIDE, PLOT NO. A-2/15, DLF ANKUR VIHAR, LONI, DISTRICT GHAZIABAD-UP, OWNER CHANDER KALI AREA 37.16 SQ MTR	20-09-2021	Rs. 8.9 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	21-07-2022 Physical	Rs. 8,80,000.00	Rs. 88,000.00	Rs. 10,000.00
3	Daryaganj	Swati Kumari 7428926731	Amit Kumar	FLAT NO-301, 2ND FLOOR, FRONT SIDE, MIG, DEEP APARTMENTS-VI, PLOT NO. A-4/18, DLF ANKUR VIHAR, LONI, GHAZIABAD, UP-201102 , OWNER AMIT KUMAR (AREA 750 SQ FT.)	10-04-2019	Rs. 12.59 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	04-06-2022 Physical	Rs. 16,60,000.00	Rs. 1,66,000.00	Rs. 15,000.00
4	Daryaganj	Swati Kumari 7428926731	Mohd Nafees 3a-Fit Jeans	First floor, PVT FLAT NO 202, C-1410, CENTRAL PORTION, WITHOUT ROOF/TERRACE RIGHTS, KABIR NAGAR, GALI NO 08, BLOCK-C, 33 FT. ROAD, BABARPUR, SHAHDARA, DELHI-110094, AREA 549 SQ FT, OWNER MOHD. NAFEES & MOHD. WASEEM	30-07-2017	Rs. 26.11+3.11 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	26-02-2018 Physical	Rs. 15,85,000.00	Rs. 1,58,500.00	Rs. 15,000.00
5	Ghaziabad	Bhawani Deen 9999467102	Manish Pandey	Ground Floor, Residential Builder Flat No- GF-3 (Back/ Northern Portion), Plot No- D-9/12, DLF Ankur Vihar, Ghaziabad- 201102, Area-58.53 Sq Mtr, Owner- Manish Pandey	30-01-2023	Rs. 7.91 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	19-08-2023 Physical	Rs. 7,60,000.00	Rs. 76,000.00	Rs. 10,000.00
6	Ghaziabad	Arvind Kumar 9999917130	M/S Kartikey Trading Co.	Residential Third Floor, With Roof Rights, Part of Property No.-1/2787, Near Krishna Dairy Ram Nagar, Mandoli Road , Shahdara, Delhi-110032 Owner Umesh Rani W/o Sanjeev Kumar Dubey Area 429.70 sq ft	14.01.2022	Rs. 13.75 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	19-04-2022 Physical	Rs. 18,90,000.00	Rs. 1,89,000.00	Rs. 20,000.00
7	Ghaziabad	Arvind Kumar 9999917130	Prem Pal Bhardwaj	All Part And Parcel of Built up property, Constructed of Whatsoever upon property No. X-16, Land Area Measuring 100 Sq Yd out of Khasra No.142/2, X Block Vill- Ghonda, Street No.2, Gujran Banger , Abadi Brahampuri, Ilaqa Shahdra Delhi Area 100 SQ YD , Owner Prem Pal Bhardwaj	30-08-2024	Rs. 151.12 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	23-04-2025 Physical	Rs. 1,26,00,000.00	Rs. 12,60,000.00	Rs. 1,00,000.00
8	Indirapuram	Shruti Kumari 8800013517	Ramesh Kumar	SF4-MIG, 2ND FLOOR FRONT SIDE WITH ROOF RIGHTS, PLOT NO. F33, SLF VED VIHAR HADBAST VILLAGE SADULLABAD PARGANA LONI DASNA TEHSIL AND DISTRICT GHAZIABAD, UP , AREA 65.03 SQ METRE, OWNER-RAMESH KUMAR	01-07-2021	Rs. 17.25 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	09-09-2021 Physical	Rs. 14,56,000.00	Rs. 1,45,600.00	Rs. 15,000.00
9	Kashmere Gate	Arvind Shrivastava 8318025882	Sahil .	Entire Built Up First Floor without Roof Rights of Freehold Commercial Shop bearing No. B- 183, Block- B, Area measuring 636 sq Ft, situated at New Sabzi Mandi, Azadpur, Delhi-110033, Owner- Taj Fruit Company	26-12-2023	Rs. 92.92 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	09-08-2024 Physical	Rs. 73,00,000.00	Rs. 7,30,000.00	Rs. 1,00,000.00
10	Lawrence Road	Amit Ranjan 8800013521	Kaveri InfraTech India	Portion Of Ground Floor, Part of property No-6281/XII (old), F-87 (New), 3 Jaipuria Building, Kolhapur Road , Kamla Nagar, Delhi 110007 Owner Rishi Kumar Gupta 774 Sq Ft	14-05-2024	Rs. 82.69 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	21-01-2025 Physical	Rs. 67,50,000.00	Rs. 6,75,000.00	Rs. 1,00,000.00
11	LRPG College	Ekta Sharma 8800013520	Aarti Kapoor	Flat No. 304 MIG First Floor Right Hand Back Side Without Roof Rights, Situated at plot No. B-11/15, DLF Ankur Vihar, Hadbast Village-Sadullabad, Pargana & Tehsil Loni Distt. Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area-55.74 Sq Mtr Owner Aarti Kapoor W/o Nitin Kapoor	22-11-2023	Rs. 22.43 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	02-12-2025 Physical	Rs. 21,60,000.00	Rs. 2,16,000.00	Rs. 20,000.00
12	MMH College	Sandhya Sharma 9818885548	Mahipal Singh	Property Bearing No.35-A Entire Ground Floor Khasra No.1025, Without Roof Rights New Friends Colony, Hadbast Village Dargal, Pargana- Jalalabad, Tehsil & Distt.-Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area 65 Sq Mtr Owner- Mahipal Singh S/o Kundan Singh	30-06-2017	Rs. 16.52 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	12-11-2025 Physical	Rs. 20,34,000.00	Rs. 2,03,400.00	Rs. 20,000.00
13	New Seelampur	Md Yunus 8800013530	Shekh Anoar Hussain	Ground Floor property No.A-19 Flat No. g-1, MIG Khasra No. 1076/5/219 Situated in area of Village- Jhilmil tahrirpur Residential Colony Known As Dilshad Colony Ilaqa - Shahdara Delhi Area 750 Sq Ft Owner Shek Anor Hussain & Sahana Bibi	10-01-2024	Rs. 29.36 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	28-01-2025 Physical	Rs. 28,80,000.00	Rs. 2,88,000.00	Rs. 30,000.00

S No.	Branch Name	Authorised Officer / Branch Head	Name of the Account	Description of the Property and Owner Name	Demand Notice Date	Amount Dues (Rs. In Lakh)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price	EMD	Bid Increase
14	Patel Nagar	Vinod Meena 9694707646	Mr. ABHAY SHARMA	Flat Bearing No. G-01, Ground Floor Without Roof Rights, Plot No. 46, out of Khasra No.- 1586, Krishna Enclave, Vill- Harsaon, Tehsil and Distt. Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area- 57.00 Sq Mtr Owner- Abhay Sharma	02-07-2019	Rs. 14.38 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	09-01-2026 Physical	Rs. 13,42,000.00	Rs. 1,34,200.00	Rs. 15,000.00
15	Patel Nagar	Vinod Meena 9694707646	Soniya --	Residential Flat No. NyayKhand-3487, E.W.S Ground Floor Without Roof Rights, Loni Indrapuram Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Area-24.65 Sq Mtr Owner- Ms. Soniya W/o Vikram Singh	01-03-2025	Rs. 9.67 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	05-12-2025 Physical	Rs. 11,00,000.00	Rs. 1,10,000.00	Rs. 10,000.00
16	Patparganj	Mohit Kumar 8800013534	Shefali Aqua Solution	First Floor (Adjoining to Property No. 87), Without Roof Rights, Upto the extent of Ceiling Level, Part of Property Bearing No. 86 out of Khasra no.5/30, Situated in layout plan of Ram Nagar in the Area of Village Khureji Khas, Ilaqa Shahdara, Delhi -110051 Area- 85 Sq Yard Owner- Sapna W/o Rakesh Kumar	26-10-2018	Rs. 29.28 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	12-01-2026 Physical	Rs. 40,70,000.00	Rs. 4,07,000.00	Rs. 40,000.00
17	Pitampura	Poonam Kumari 8383803088	Feba Sabu	First Floor No.203 Without Roof/terrace Rights built On Property Bearing Plot No. B-63, Admeasuring 57.25 Sq Yard i.e 47.87 Sq Mtr(Out Of 229 Sq Yard) Out of Khasra No.317 Situated In The Revenue Estate of Village Bindapur Area Abadi Known as Colony Sanjay Enclave , Uttam Nagar New Delhi-110059 Owner -Smt Febu Sabu & Sh. Subin T. Area-515.27 Sq Ft	03-02-2025	Rs. 16.86 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	27-10-2025 Physical	Rs. 21,00,000.00	Rs. 2,10,000.00	Rs. 20,000.00
18	Sadar Bazar	Sanny Kumar 8800013540	Amit Saini	Flat Bearing No. J-44/ SL-4 on Second Floor with Roof Rights, Area measuring 600 Sq Feet, under LIG Category situated at Dilshad Garden Extension No 1 now known as Dilshad Colony, Village- Jhilmil Tahripur, Shahdara, Delhi- 110095, Owner- Amit Saini and Vandana Saini	17-02-2021	Rs. 31.03 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	30-12-2024 Physical	Rs. 20,40,000.00	Rs. 2,04,000.00	Rs. 20,000.00
19	Sadar Bazar	Sanny Kumar 8800013540	Sanjay Thakur	Property bearing no. K-4A, Third Floor without Roof Rights, Khasra No. 87/23, situated in the area of Village- Palam known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi-110045, Area 70 Sq Yards, Owner- Sanjay Thakur and Ranjeet Thakur	18-08-2020	Rs. 14.36 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	21-11-2024 Physical	Rs. 15,00,000.00	Rs. 1,50,000.00	Rs. 15,000.00
20	SDS School	Bhawesh Kumar 8521795402	Shree Agencies	Entire Ground Floor without (Roof Rights Built up on Property Bearing No.29 Khasra No.430. Situated at Village Maujpur in the abadi of Bhagat Singh Gali West Babar Pur, Shahdara, Delhi-110032 Owner- Smt. Deepa Bhardwaj W/o Shri Vikas Bhardwaj, Area-360 Sq Ft	20-10-2023	Rs. 58.7 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	10-06-2025 Physical	Rs. 19,00,000.00	Rs. 1,90,000.00	Rs. 20,000.00
21	SDS School	Bhawesh Kumar 8521795402	Shree Agencies	Property Bearing No.1/1218-A, Second Floor (Right Side Portion), Gali No. 13 Subhash Park Shahdara Delhi 110032 Owner- Smt. Deepa Bhardwaj W/o Shri Vikas Bhardwaj, Area -405 Sq ft	20-10-2023	Rs. 58.7 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	10-06-2025 Physical	Rs. 18,00,000.00	Rs. 1,80,000.00	Rs. 20,000.00
22	Usmanpur	Husnain Ali 9568431985	Deepak Tiwari	Built-Up Free Hold Residential Property Bearing no. A-113, Second Floor, Pvt Flat No. SF-1, Front left Side (South West), With Roof /Terrace Rights, Situated at Colony Known as SLF Ved Vihar, Pargana Loni, Tehsil & Distt Ghaziabad , Uttar Pradesh, 201102 Owner- Sh. Deepak Tiwari S/o Shri Ganesh Tiwari, Area-400 Sq Ft	21-05-2024	Rs. 11.29 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	19-07-2025 Physical	Rs. 11,60,000.00	Rs. 1,16,000.00	Rs. 10,000.00
23	Usmanpur	Husnain Ali 9568431985	Mushahid Alam	Property Bearing No. F-32 & F-33, Ground Floor, Pvt Flat No. GF-2, Without Roof/terrace Rights, Situated at Colony SLF Ved Vihar, Pargana- Loni, Tehsil and Distt. Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh- 201102 Owner- Mushahid Alam S/o Jamshed Alam, Area -400 Sq Ft	28-05-2024	Rs. 10.45 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	19-07-2025 Physical	Rs. 11,52,000.00	Rs. 1,15,200.00	Rs. 10,000.00
24	Vasundhara	Anand Jaiswal 8800013545	Anita Sharma	RESIDENTIAL BUILDER FLAT.ON PART OF KHASRA NO. 380, OUT OF FOUR STOREY BUILDING, GROUND FLOOR, WITHOUT ROOF RIGHTS, VILL-INDERGARHI, PARAGNA DASNA, NEAR BLOCK-C, GOVINDPURAM, GHAZIABAD UP-201001, AREA 60 SQ MTRS, OWNER ANITA SHARMA	29-09-2020	Rs. 21.3 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	16-11-2021 Physical	Rs. 17,30,000.00	Rs. 1,73,000.00	Rs. 20,000.00
25	Vasundhara	Anand Jaiswal 8800013545	Vishal Kumar Sharma	RESI. FLAT, IST FLOOR (WITHOUT ROOF RIGHTS), PART OF RUDRA NIWAS ON KHASRA NO. 380, INDERGARHI, VILL. AND PARAGNA DASNA, GHAZIABAD, AREA 70 SQM (OWNER VISHAL KR SHARMA AND PREMLATA SHARMA)	02-09-2020	Rs. 18.78 Lakh + Other Charges Applicable deductions/ repayments	20-12-2021 Physical	Rs. 16,00,000.00	Rs. 1,60,000.00	Rs. 15,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 20.07.2026 TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 4:00 P.M WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES
Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: **20.07.2026 Upto 3:30 P.M.** Bidder will register on website: (**https://BAANKNET.com**) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (**https://BAANKNET.com**)).
The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider "**https://BAANKNET.com**" E-auction will be held on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever is there is" basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).
For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in **www.centralbankofindia.co.in** Secured Creditor or Auction Platform (**https://BAANKNET.com**) Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

NOTICE FOR STATUTORY 15DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF SARFAEST ACT 2002
The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.
DATE: 30.06.2026
PLACE: DELHI
Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, R.O. Delhi (North), Chandni Chowk, Delhi

India to see below-normal rain in July: IMD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The monthly average rainfall over India is expected to be below normal during July, the India Meteorological Department said on Tuesday in its monthly forecast. The weather department stated that July is most likely to see 94 per cent of the long-period average rainfall (1971-2020). The LPA rainfall over India in July is about 280.4 mm.

LPA refers to the rainfall recorded over a particular region for a given period, such as a month or a season, averaged over a long period, typically 30 to 50 years. Some areas of northwest and north-east India, east-central India and the eastern peninsular region are likely to receive normal to above-normal rainfall, the IMD said.

In a statement, Dr Mrutyunjay Mohapatra, director general of meteorology at the IMD, said, "During July, below-normal

rainfall is likely across most parts of the country except some areas of northwest and northeast India, east-central India and the eastern peninsular region, where normal to above-normal rainfall is likely."

In June, India as a whole witnessed a rainfall deficit of about 40 per cent, with Central India worst affected with a deficit of 50.4 per cent. The country experienced the fifth-lowest (99.5 mm) rainfall in June since 1901.

This below-normal rainfall during the monsoon season occurred due to five main factors, according to Mohapatra.

First, an unfavourable phase of the Madden-Julian Oscillation (MJO), which is a moving system of wind, cloud, and pressure that brings rain as it circles the equator. During a favourable phase, the MJO brings more clouds to southern India, which are then carried



northwards by the monsoon winds, leading to enhanced rainfall.

Second, there were no low-pressure systems (LPSs) formed during June. LPSs are essentially areas where atmospheric pressure is lower than in their surrounding regions.

Given that winds travel from high-pressure to low-pressure areas, these systems act like a magnet, pulling in

moisture-laden winds, helping trigger rainfall, and pushing the monsoon inland.

Third, most of the typhoon systems that formed during June recurved to the North-Northwest direction, which led to subdued LPS over the Indian Ocean region.

Fourth, the emergence of El Niño conditions this month also negatively impacted the rainfall activity.

El Niño is one of the three

phases of the El Niño Southern Oscillation (ENSO) - a climate phenomenon characterised by changes in sea temperatures along the central and eastern tropical Pacific Ocean, accompanied by fluctuations in the atmosphere overhead.

While El Niño, which leads to less monsoon rainfall in India, is known to have a warming effect over the planet, its opposite phase, La Nina, usually results in a cooling effect. ENSO also has a neutral phase.

As Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) conditions are currently neutral, they cannot help to counter the El Niño's negative impact - positive IOD conditions typically result in more rainfall.

Speaking about the advancement of the south-west monsoon, Mohapatra noted that conditions are favourable for further movement into the remaining parts of Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, and

Ladakh, and more parts of Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh in the next 2-3 days.

During this period, the monsoon is also likely to advance into the entire Daman and Diu, Jammu and Kashmir, most parts of Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, and Punjab, and some parts of Rajasthan.

As for temperatures in July, the IMD has said that maximum temperatures are expected to remain above normal across most parts of India, except a few isolated areas in West Central India, where normal to below-normal maximum temperatures are likely.

"Meanwhile, the minimum temperatures are also expected to be above normal over most regions of the country, except some isolated pockets of Central and Northeast India, where normal minimum temperatures are likely," the IMD said.

VB-G RAM G Act comes into force



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Viksit Bharat — Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 will come into force from July 1, with the Centre on Tuesday stating that all arrangements have been made for its implementation.

The Ministry of Rural Development said the Act provides a statutory guarantee of up to 125 days of wage employment to eligible rural households, compared to the 100 days provided under the existing rural employment framework.

The ministry said an interim allocation of ₹95,692.31 crore has been made to states and Union Territories to ensure a smooth transition, timely wage payments and uninterrupted implementation of works under the new framework.

Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said the Government's priority was to ensure that "no eligible rural worker remains without work even for a single day". He said the Centre and states had worked together to complete administrative, financial and technical preparations for the rollout.

The Government said existing e-KYC-verified job cards will remain valid until the new Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards are issued.

The gram panchayats will continue to play a key role in the implementation of the scheme, with a focus on areas such as natural resource management, water conservation, agriculture and allied activities, rural infrastructure and women's empowerment, it added.

Amit Shah launches revamped FCRA portal, e-OCI card

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday launched a revamped online portal for regulating foreign contributions and the e-OCI Card, initiatives which would simplify compliance, improve public services and strengthen national security through greater use of technology.

In his address, the Home Minister said that prior to 2014, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) system was entangled in files and procedures and was beyond proper oversight.

Shah said that after the Government led by Prime Minister Modi was formed in

2014, the system was strengthened.

"The renewal of the FCRA portal today will greatly enhance ease of operations for organisations," he said.

The minister said that in the past years, there has been a significant increase in the number of applications and the flow of donations.

Keeping this in view, reducing paperwork and ensuring effective, real-time monitoring of foreign contributions are very important for the country's security.

He said that due to the FCRA law, monitoring of foreign contributions coming with wrong intentions will increase.

The initiatives reflected the Government's commit-



ment to improving governance through technology while making services more accessible to citizens and organisations, he said.

The FCRA 2.0 Portal digitises all major processes related to foreign contribution regulation, including registration, renewal, annual

returns and other services under the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act.

The key provisions of the new FCRA Amendment rules, 2026, have also been incorporated into it.

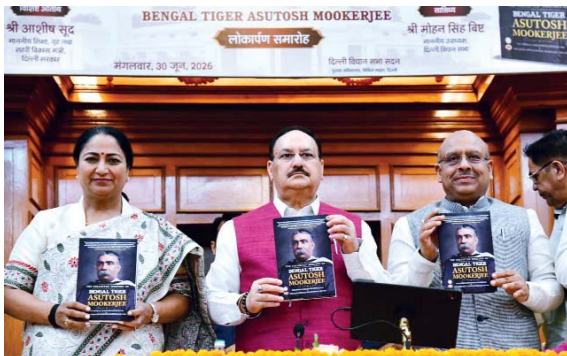
According to the Ministry, the platform has been devel-

oped to simplify compliance while strengthening the monitoring and enforcement of foreign funding received by organisations.

"At present, around 14,500 active FCRA organisations are working across the country. Every year, approximately 15,000 to 20,000 applications and about 17,000 annual returns are received," a Government statement said.

Hosted on the Government's MeghRaj cloud platform, the portal includes Aadhaar-based authentication, e-Sign verification, Optical Character Recognition technology for document analysis and integration with NGO Darpan.

Union minister Nadda unveils book on Asutosh Mookerjee's speeches



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Health Minister JP Nadda on Tuesday unveiled "The Collected Speeches of Bengal Tiger Asutosh Mookerjee." The book is published by the Delhi Legislative Assembly, compiling 32 legislative speeches of educationist and jurist Dr Ashtosh Mookerjee. The book is unveiled at a function marking his 162nd birth anniversary at the Assembly House.

Nadda compared the speeches to a daily source of intellectual renewal for public life. "Just as a mobile phone must be recharged every day, public life too

requires constant intellectual renewal. Dr Ashtosh Mookerjee's speeches continue to recharge our minds with constitutional values, reasoned debate and a deep sense of nationalism," he said.

The event was attended by Union Minister Harsh Malhotra, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta, ministers Ashish Sood, Manjinder Singh Sirsa, and Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh, and Deputy Speaker Mohan Singh Bisht, along with MPs, MLAs, and academicians. A documentary on Anupam Kher was also screened.

Speaker Vijender Gupta called Mookerjee the "Tiger of Bengal," noting that he defended educational institutions' autonomy under colonial rule, backed scholars including CV Raman and Meghnad Saha, and supported students such as Subhas Chandra Bose. He cited Mookerjee's tenure as Vice-Chancellor of Calcutta University, Calcutta High Court judge, and member of the Bengal and Imperial Legislative Councils.

The Chief Minister said great personalities must continue inspiring new generations rather than remain confined to history, linking Mookerjee's educational philosophy to the National Education Policy's focus on Indian languages.

Education Minister Sood said Mookerjee demonstrated that education is the strongest foundation of nation-building. Deputy Speaker Bisht said legislators must preserve the ideas that shaped India's democratic evolution, calling the publication an important step in that direction.

Ram Temple trust advances key meeting to July 6 as leadership faces crisis

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust has moved its next meeting up to July 6, instead of July 11. All 14 members have been asked to be available as the Trust prepares to decide what happens next for General Secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra. Both have resigned on moral grounds after the donation embezzlement controversy.

The Trust is led by 87-year-old Mahant Nritya Gopal Das, a respected saint from Ayodhya's Mani Ram Das Ki Chavani. The Trust is under growing pressure to restore its credibility. Moving the meeting earlier shows the urgency to address the fallout from the ongoing police investigation into the alleged siphoning of devotees' offerings at the Ram Temple.

Champat Rai, a longtime RSS pracharak and VHP leader who has played a key role in the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, and Anil Mishra resigned a few days after eight trust employees were arrested in the case. Police took Rai's statement on June



29, in which he reportedly denied any personal involvement and said he acted as soon as he learned of the irregularities. Rai was questioned for more than three hours. So far, no charges have been filed against him or other top trust leaders, but the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya is still under investigation due to financial allegations.

The Trust has confirmed it received the resignations and has assured devotees that all donated valuables are safe.

The July 6 meeting is expected to address more than just the resignations. Sources say the Trust will likely discuss ways to make its finances more transparent, possibly reorganise its struc-

States Focus



AIR MARSHAL ASHUTOSH DIXIT TO BE NEXT VICE CHIEF OF IAF

Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, a senior military officer with over 3,300 hours of flying experience, is set to be the next Vice Chief of the Air Staff (VCAS).

He will take charge on July 1, succeeding Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor, an official said on Tuesday.

Air Marshal Dixit was commissioned into the fighter stream of the Indian Air Force in December 1986. He is an alumnus of National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla; Defence Services Staff College (Bangladesh) and National Defence College, New Delhi, the defence ministry earlier said. (PTI)



SATHEESAN CALLS FOR TEAMWORK TO DRIVE KERALA'S DEVELOPMENT

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Tuesday said coordinated efforts by officers of the All India Services, the Secretariat and other government departments are essential to drive the state's development. Speaking at a farewell function organised by the state government for retiring Chief Secretary A Jayathilak and Additional Chief Secretary Dr Rajan N Khobragade at the Secretariat Darbar Hall here, the CM said retirement is not the end of life but the beginning of a new phase. With life expectancy increasing, people now have a longer and more productive post-retirement life, he said. (PTI)

Amarnath pilgrims directed to use Jammu-Srinagar National Highway only

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Amid heightened security arrangements, Amarnath-bound pilgrims have been directed to travel only on the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway. As per the advisory of the UT administration, movement of pilgrims on alternative routes, including the Mughal Road and Dhar Road, will not be permitted for Yatra traffic due to security considerations.

As the first batch of devotees is scheduled to be flagged off from the Bhagwati Nagar base camp on July 2, the Jammu and Kashmir administration on Tuesday said that elaborate arrangements, including enhanced security and accommodation for around 55,000 pilgrims, have been put in place

for this year's annual Amarnath Yatra.

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha, who is also the chairman of the Shri Amarnath Shrine Board (SASB), will flag off the first convoy at 4 am on July 2.

Separate escorted convoys will proceed to the twin base camps of Pahalgam and Baltal, from where pilgrims will begin their trek to the holy cave shrine on July 3.

As of now, arrangements have been made to accommodate around 55,000 pilgrims across the Jammu division. Comprehensive arrangements have been made for all pilgrims arriving in the Jammu division, including facilities for accommodation, food and sanitation, so that no pilgrim faces any inconvenience,"



Divisional Commissioner Jammu Ramesh Kumar told reporters.

"The Shri Amarnath Ji Yatra is an annual event. Every year, extensive security

arrangements are made for the pilgrimage, and this year we are making efforts to

provide an even stronger security cover than before," Inspector General of Police, Jammu range, Bhim Sen Tuti said during a press briefing in Jammu on Tuesday.

He said pilgrims reaching Lakanpur between 6 am and 8 am would be escorted to Jammu under security cover, while those arriving after 8 am would have to halt there due to security restrictions.

"Pilgrims have been directed to travel only on the Jammu-Srinagar National Highway. Movement on alternative routes, including the Mughal Road and Dhar Road, will not be permitted for Yatra traffic in view of security considerations," he said.

The IGP said mini-convoys would also operate between Udhampur and Banihal under a fixed schedule.

"Pilgrims have been advised to adhere to the cut-off timings notified by the traffic department, which may revise the schedule depending on weather or road conditions," he said.

On-the-spot registration for pilgrims will commence on Wednesday at the Tawi River Front in Jammu, where the registration centre has been shifted to minimise inconvenience to city residents. Tokens have already been distributed, and registration will be carried out according to the daily quota fixed by the Shrine Board, Kumar said.

Mandatory RFID cards for security and tracking will be issued at designated centres, including Jammu Railway Station, Bhagwati Nagar, Tawi River Front, Udhampur Railway Station,

Chanderkote, Banihal, Lakanpur and Samba. Pilgrims who have completed online registration and e-KYC verification have been advised to collect their RFID cards before proceeding to the base camp.

"Separate registration facilities have been established for sadhus at Geeta Bhawan and Purani Mandi temple, while general pilgrims will be registered at the Tawi River Front and Mahajan Sabha," Kumar said.

The district commissioner appealed to pilgrims to strictly follow the Shrine Board guidelines and carry mandatory health certificates. Elderly pilgrims and those suffering from cardiac or respiratory ailments have been advised to undertake the pilgrimage only after obtaining proper medical clearance.

Gujarat can emerge as major defence hub: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vadodara

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Tuesday said Gujarat can potentially emerge as a major hub for defence manufacturing and technology and play a pivotal role in India's journey towards self-reliance through its industrial strength, skilled workforce and entrepreneurial spirit.

Addressing the valedictory function of the 4th Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference (VGRC) for the central Gujarat region, Singh said India has made significant strides in defence production and exports over the past decade, but "still has a long way to go" in achieving complete self-reliance.

He said India's domestic defence production has increased from around ₹46,000 crore in 2014 to about ₹1.78 lakh crore, while defence exports have grown from nearly ₹1,000 crore to around ₹39,000 crore during the same period.

"However, I consider this to be merely the beginning. We still have a long way to go, and I believe that Gujarat can play a very significant role in achieving the goal of self-reliance in defence production," the minister said.

Singh said the country had moved from being heavily



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh at the Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference

PTI

dependent on defence imports to building a strong indigenous defence ecosystem driven by private industry, startups and innovation.

He said initiatives such as Make in India, the Defence Acquisition Procedure, Technology Development Fund, Srijan Portal, Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX), defence testing infrastructure, Green Channel Certification and self-certification had encouraged domestic industries, particularly MSMEs and startups, to participate in defence manufacturing.

The Government has also simplified industrial licens-

ing procedures and liberalised the foreign direct investment policy to attract greater investment into the sector, he said.

Highlighting Gujarat's growing importance in defence manufacturing, Singh said Vadodara is home to India's first private-sector military aircraft manufacturing facility under the Tata Airbus C-295 transport aircraft programme, calling it a landmark in the country's aerospace journey.

He also noted that the K9 Vajra self-propelled artillery platform, one of the world's most advanced artillery systems, is manufactured at

a facility in Gujarat, significantly strengthening the Indian Army's strike capability. The minister said future warfare and economic growth would increasingly be driven by advanced technologies such as semiconductors, artificial intelligence, quantum computing, cybersecurity and space technology.

He said semiconductor ecosystems being developed in Sanand and Dholera would become the foundation of India's technological sovereignty, while Gujarat's strengths in chemicals, petrochemicals, engineering, ports, shipbuilding, renewable energy and green hydrogen

could support the development of advanced defence technologies.

Earlier, Singh said the Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference had evolved beyond an investment summit into a platform for generating new ideas, partnerships and opportunities for the state's development.

He said exhibitions organised during the event showcased Gujarat's strengths across sectors including industry, MSMEs, startups, automobiles, exports, handcrafts, women entrepreneurs and tribal products.

The minister said he also interacted with representatives of Tata Advanced Systems, Larsen & Toubro, the Society of Indian Defence Manufacturers (SIDM), MSMEs, startups and academia during a seminar on defence and aerospace industries and received valuable suggestions to strengthen India's defence manufacturing ecosystem.

Describing Gujarat as the "growth engine" of the Indian economy, Singh said the Vibrant Gujarat initiative launched in 2003 under then chief minister Narendra Modi had evolved into a globally recognised platform that complements the vision of making India a developed nation by 2047. He said the goal of a developed India

was not confined to economic prosperity alone but also envisaged a technologically advanced, socially empowered and strategically secure nation, with the defence sector serving as one of its key pillars.

Earlier in the day, Singh participated in a seminar on "Self-reliant India in Aerospace and Defence", where memoranda of understanding (MoUs) worth Rs 2,550 crore for investments in Gujarat's defence sector were signed in his presence.

During an interaction with representatives of industry, startups and other stakeholders, Singh said the Government was keen to address their concerns and sought feedback on policy support required to accelerate indigenous defence production. Participants raised issues relating to the development of globally competitive testing facilities, the availability of raw materials, Gujarat's role in the defence sector and the need for a defence industrial corridor in the State.

Responding to a startup founder who highlighted difficulties in identifying suitable end-users for defence products, Singh said entrepreneurs need not wait for formal conferences to engage with the Government.



Indian Army spearheads Assam flood rescue operations

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In a swift and coordinated humanitarian effort, the Indian Army has stepped in to mitigate the crisis arising out of the worsening flood situation in Assam. Troops of the Spear Head Division, operating under the Spear Corps, actively joined hands with the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and the civil administration to launch extensive rescue operations in the deluge-hit Arun Chapori area of Dhemaji district.

The region has been reeling under severe inundation triggered by incessant rainfall and rapidly rising water levels.

Responding immediately to the escalating crisis, Army personnel mobilised resources to support the

ongoing local relief efforts.

Despite braving treacherous weather conditions and highly challenging terrain, the joint rescue teams successfully located and evacuated 27 stranded civilians from heavily flooded pockets, moving them to safer, designated relief locations.

"The operation showcased a high level of preparedness, discipline, and dedication by the Indian Army in extending timely assistance to the civil populace during natural calamities," an official release stated. Working shoulder to shoulder with civilian authorities, the troops ensured that the affected citizens received immediate relief and were extricated from danger zones in an efficient manner.

NIA arrests TMC councillor in Ram Navami violence case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Tuesday arrested Trinamool Congress (TMC) councillor Shakir Ali, husband of former party MP Aparupa Poddar, in connection with its probe into the 2023 Ram Navami violence in West Bengal's Hooghly district, a senior official said.

Ali, a councillor of Ward No 4 of the Rishra Municipality, was taken into custody from his residence in Rishra after an NIA team, accompanied by CRPF personnel, carried out a search operation there on Tuesday morning, he said.



(TMC) councillor Shakir Ali

"Shakir Ali has been arrested in connection with the agency's investigation into the 2023 Rishra Ram Navami violence case. He was produced before the competent court following his arrest. The investigation is continuing, and we are examining the role of all individuals connected with the conspiracy and the violence," the official said. He, however, declined to comment on further investigative leads, saying, "As the probe is at a crucial stage, it would not be appropriate to disclose additional details at this point."

SC sub-categorisation only after talks: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Tuesday said the State Government has not taken any final decision on the sub-categorisation of Scheduled Castes (SCs) and will act only after extensive consultations while strictly complying with the directions of the Supreme Court.

Speaking in the Legislative Assembly, Fadnavis said the exercise aims to identify Scheduled Caste communities that have remained deprived of adequate representation despite the existing reservation system.

He stressed that the issue is not about introducing a fresh reservation within the SC quota, but about examin-



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis arrives during the State Assembly Monsoon session in Mumbai on Tuesday

PTI

ing the representation of different communities in accordance with the Supreme Court's directions on sub-classification.

He said the Government had constituted the Badar Committee, which has sub-

mitted its report. "The report was placed before the State Cabinet, where it was decided that suggestions and objections should be invited from all stakeholders because the matter affects a large section of society," the chief minister

added. Fadnavis said a committee headed by the Chief Secretary has been formed to receive suggestions and objections and conduct hearings before making any recommendations.

He said the Government has not introduced any Bill on the issue in the legislature. "The Government's stand is clear. A final decision will be taken only after wide consultations, and while taking that decision, the directions of the Supreme Court will be followed in letter and spirit," he added.

The chief minister further said the Government has no intention of doing injustice to any community and that appropriate measures would be taken if any Scheduled Caste community was found to have been left behind.

Wrongdoers will face action in Sabarimala case: Chennithala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala on Tuesday asserted that wrongdoers will have to face the consequences in the alleged Sabarimala gold loss case, while maintaining that the SIT probe into it was "not politically motivated".

The Kerala High Court has constituted the Special Investigation Team (SIT), and the investigation is proceeding under its supervision, he told reporters.

"The Government has no role in the probe. Since assuming office as Home Minister, I have neither contacted them (SIT personnel)



Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala

nor issued any instruction regarding the investigation," Chennithala said.

Maintaining that the investigation should be allowed to proceed independently, the minister said, "those who have done wrong will have to face the consequences".

His remarks came a day after the High Court permitted the SIT probing the alleged Sabarimala gold loss to register a fresh criminal case after it reported that evidence had emerged against former Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) president PS Prashanth in connection with the 2025 replating of the temple's Dwarapalaka (guardian deity) idols.

The SIT was constituted on the directions of the High Court to investigate two cases relating to the alleged loss of gold from the Dwarapalaka idols and the gold-plated doorframes of the Sreekovil (sanctum sanctorum), which were removed and taken to Chennai for replating in 2019.

Amarnath Yatra: Forces conduct full-scale mock drill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

A comprehensive multi-layer security arrangement has been established for the Amarnath Yatra, and a mock drill involving all relevant agencies was conducted to test the effectiveness of the system, police said on Tuesday.

The 57-day annual pilgrimage to the 3,880-metre-high Amarnath cave shrine is scheduled to begin on July 3 from two routes: the traditional 48-km Nunwan-Pahalgam track in Anantnag district and the shorter yet steeper 14-km Baltal route in Ganderbal district. The first group of pilgrims will depart from Bhagwati Nagar Yatri Niwas in Jammu on July 2. "ICG Kashmir Zone, VK Birdi, informed reporters that the Jammu and Kashmir Police have implemented these multi-tiered security measures.



Security personnel during a mock drill ahead of Amarnath Yatra in Srinagar on Tuesday

PTI

"We are carrying out a full dress rehearsal and mock drills to ensure clarity among all security personnel regarding their roles," he said.

If any contingency comes up, every security force can handle it properly, he added.

"As far as area monitoring and supervision are concerned, we have kept systems

in place so we can monitor from a height. If there's any aberration or abnormal observation, we can respond to it immediately," he said.

Birdi said technology was being used to make the security system robust.

"This time as well, the J&K Police have set up a grid of CCTV surveillance cameras

across the entire yatra routes and tracks. It has recognition features that will flag any adverse entities entering the system, so that security forces deployed there can remove them from the area or handle the situation," he added.

Regarding the challenges posed by nature, Birdi acknowledged vulnerabilities related to weather and natural disasters on the upper tracks.

"NDMA conducts a tabletop exercise with all stakeholders — J&K Police, paramilitary, and local district disaster management authorities. They do vulnerability mapping of slide-prone areas, avalanche-prone areas, glacier features, etc. Based on that, Mountain Rescue Teams are also deployed so that any weather-related contingency can be responded to properly," he said.

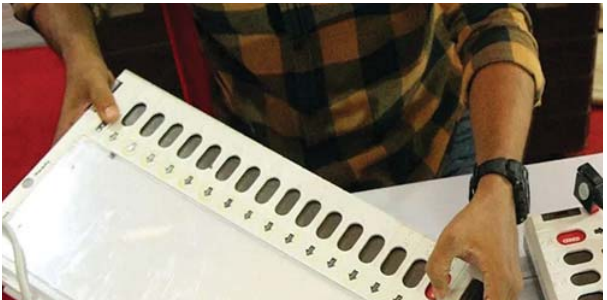
Karur seat vacant, TN set for bypolls in 7 constituencies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

The Karur Assembly constituency in Tamil Nadu has been declared vacant following the resignation of former State minister MR Vijayabaskar as MLA, taking the total number of vacant seats in the state to seven, an official said on Tuesday.

The State is set for bypolls in the seven Assembly constituencies.

Vijayabaskar, who won from Karur defeating the TVK candidate VP Mathiyalagan in the April 23 Assembly election, quit as a legislator on June 29. He is likely to join the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam. He was among 25 rebel AIADMK MLAs who voted in favour of the TVK



Government during the floor test in the Assembly on May 13.

He was the sixth legislator from the AIADMK to quit the position following the party's electoral setback in the Assembly election. The party has been facing the crisis of exodus of its cadres since the poll results were announced on May 4. Following his res-

ignation, the total number of vacancies in the Assembly has risen to seven — six vacancies created by the resignations of AIADMK MLAs and the Tiruchirappalli East constituency vacated by Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay following his victory from two seats. He has retained the Perambur constituency in Chennai.

Karnataka LoP Ashoka slams CM Shivakumar over Bengaluru infrastructure fund allocation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Senior BJP leader R Ashoka on Tuesday questioned Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, asking whether he is the CM only of Congress-represented constituencies, while accusing the Government of "discriminatory allocation" of the ₹2,000 crore package for Bengaluru's infrastructure and road development.

The Leader of the Opposition in the Karnataka Assembly also asked whether the lakhs of Bengaluru residents living in constituencies represented by BJP MLAs do not pay taxes. "Chief Minister D K Shivakumar, are you the CM of the entire state, or only of constituencies rep-



Karnataka LoP Ashoka

resented by Congress MLAs?" Ashoka posted on X. "In the ₹2,000 crore special package announced for Bengaluru's infrastructure and road development, the Congress Government has adopted an extremely discriminatory approach against constituencies represented by BJP MLAs," he

alleged. "On one hand, constituencies represented by Congress MLAs have received hundreds of crores of rupees in funding," he claimed, adding, "On the other hand, the 16 constituencies in the capital represented by BJP MLAs have been completely neglected and given only token amounts, as though they were receiving charity."

According to reports, the allocation list shows that constituencies represented by Congress MLAs, such as Chamaraipet, Gandhi Nagar, Vijayanagar, Shanthinagar, Hebbal, Govindaraja Nagar, Pulakeshi Nagar, Shivajinagar, BTM Layout, Sarvagnanagar and Byatarayanapura, have each been allocated ₹100 crore, while allocations for BJP-

represented constituencies range from ₹40 crore to ₹80 crore. Addressing Shivakumar and Minister Krishna Byre Gowda, Ashoka said, "Don't the lakhs of Bengaluru residents living in constituencies represented by BJP MLAs also pay taxes? Don't they deserve good roads and infrastructure? Your politically motivated and vindictive decision will adversely affect the overall development of Bengaluru."

"The people of Bengaluru are closely watching this discriminatory governance and politics of vendetta. In the upcoming Greater Bengaluru Authority elections, the people of the Capital will certainly teach you an appropriate lesson for this discriminatory policy and partisan conduct," he added.

2 Maoist splinter group members held in Jharkhand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chatra

Two members of the banned Tritiya Sammelan Prastuti Committee, a splinter group of the proscribed CPI (Maoist), were arrested in Jharkhand's Chatra district, police.

The police apprehended the accused during a raid near Kalyanpur village under the Piparwar Police Station limits on Monday, a senior officer said.

According to the police, the arrested Maoists were identified as Massi Tigga (29), a resident of Khandhar village, and Kiran Nagadwar (45), who hails from Chirlounga village under the Tandwa Police Station limits.



Editor's
TAKE

How India cushioned the consumer during oil crisis

The Indian govt chose preparation over panic. It deserves credit for ensuring that a global energy shock did not become an Indian consumer crisis

The world had seen this crisis coming. As tensions deepened between Washington and Tehran, markets had already begun to price in danger, and energy analysts had warned that the Strait of Hormuz could become the fault line of a wider shock. But what few expected was the scale and ferocity of the confrontation once it broke open. This escalation in West Asia carried the old, unsettling echo of the 1980s, when the tanker war turned the Gulf into a theatre of disruption and reminded the world how quickly oil can become a weapon, and how brutally the costs can spread.

That historical memory matters because oil shocks are never just about crude. They are about confidence, inflation, logistics, and political nerve. They expose which governments have prepared and which merely hope the storm passes elsewhere. In this case, the Indian government chose preparation over panic, and execution over rhetoric.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas deserves credit for ensuring that a global energy shock did not become an Indian consumer crisis. Brent crude did what Brent always does in a geopolitical firestorm: it spiked hard, carrying global anxiety with it. In the United States, fuel prices rose, and households felt it quickly. In Europe, where energy is already a more painful line item than in India, the pressure was even sharper. India, however, did not hand that pain directly to its citizens. Retail petrol and diesel prices were held steady. LPG was kept affordable. That outcome was not accidental, and it was not cheap. It reflected a conscious state choice to absorb the blow through excise adjustments, under-recoveries, and administrative discipline rather than passing it straight to households. That matters politically, economically, and morally. It matters because a fuel shock is regressive by definition. It hits the poor first, the middle class next, and the broader economy soon after. It raises transport costs, feeds inflation, and punishes every household that depends on stable mobility and cooking fuel. By refusing to let that happen, the government protected economic calm.

In India, the state absorbed the pressure at the top of the system so that the shock did not cascade downward. The deeper truth is that India entered this crisis better prepared than many commentators appreciated. It had reserves, diversified suppliers, and a supply architecture built over years rather than assembled in panic. It had a crude buffer of roughly two months and LPG cover of about 45 days. It had widened its sourcing base and strengthened import infrastructure. Those are not glamorous achievements, but they are precisely what prevents global turmoil from becoming domestic disruption. That is why the Ministry's handling deserves proper credit. The real achievement here is not that India escaped unscathed. No major oil shock leaves a country untouched. The achievement is that the damage was absorbed where it belonged: in the state's finances, in corporate balance sheets, in operational planning, and in the long arc of policy choices. It was not transferred to the kitchen, the petrol pump, or the commuter.

Shiv Sena @60: Can it survive another split

As the Shiv Sena completed six decades of its turbulent political journey on June 19, the party found itself confronting yet another split — its fifth major split in six decades. The crisis raises fundamental questions about leadership, succession, ideology and the future of both the Thackeray family and Maharashtra's regional politics.



KALYANI SHANKAR

Last week, on June 19, the Shiv Sena marked its 60th anniversary. Since its inception, in the past 60 years, the party has experienced several splits, with the latest occurring on June 26. Shiv Sena's 60th anniversary is contested by two factions-Thackeray's Sena (UBT) and Eknath Shinde's Sena-each claiming the party's original ideological legacy.

On June 26, a significant political rift emerged within the Uddhav Thackeray-led Shiv Sena (UBT) when six of its nine Lok Sabha MPs defected to join Eknath Shinde's ruling Shiv Sena faction. This sudden defection severely undermined Uddhav Thackeray's group, reducing its representation in the Lok Sabha to just three members and bolstering the Shinde faction's parliamentary strength.

The ongoing political contest across Parliament, courts, and streets underscores the urgency for strategic responses. In its 60 years, the Shiv Sena has split five times, highlighting its vulnerability to internal divisions and the need for effective management of such conflicts.

Just before the party founder, Bal Thackeray, named his son, Uddhav, as the Sena executive president in 2003, senior party leaders had begun pressing for a key organisational role for him. Later, Uddhav's son Aaditya Thackeray's elevation in the Sena followed a similar trajectory, with party leaders projecting him as its "gen-next" face before he was appointed the Yuva Sena chief.

On November 28, 2019, Uddhav Thackeray, leader of the Shiv Sena and head of the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA), was sworn in as Maharashtra's Chief Minister, marking a key leadership milestone amid ongoing political shifts. The MVA is an alliance between the Shiv Sena, the Nationalist Congress Party, and the Indian National Congress.

On June 21, 2022, Eknath Shinde, the leader of the Shiv Sena in the Legislative Assembly, went missing with several other MLAs. This 'rebel' group initially moved to Surat and then to Guwahati, claiming that the MVA alliance contradicted the Shiv Sena's ideology and expressing a lack of confidence in CM Thackeray.

After the 2022 split, 40 of the 56 Shiv Sena MLAs sided with Shinde, while 16 remained with Thackeray. In the Lok Sabha, 13 of 18 MPs joined the Shinde camp, leaving just five with Uddhav. Both factions claim to be the rightful heirs to Bal Thackeray's political legacy, with Uddhav



THE MANNER IN WHICH THE SHIV SENA SPLIT IS REMINISCENT OF PAST POLITICAL EVENTS, SUCH AS THE FRAGMENTATION OF THE NCP AND THE ONGOING ISSUES FACING THE TMC. THIS TREND IS CONCERNING. SHARAD PAWAR HAS EVEN REMARKED THAT SEVERAL REGIONAL PARTIES MAY MERGE WITH CONGRESS IN THE COMING YEARS

The writer is a popular columnist

emphasising his bloodline and Shinde arguing that he upholds the party's ideological foundation.

The manner in which the Shiv Sena split is reminiscent of past political events, such as the fragmentation of the NCP and the ongoing issues facing the TMC. This trend is concerning. Sharad Pawar has even remarked that several regional parties may merge with Congress in the coming years.

The latest split in Shiv Sena UBT raises important questions about the future of the Thackeray clan. It could unfold in several ways: Dissent among the rebel leaders has been growing due to their dissatisfaction with Thackeray's leadership. They believe he has not engaged with them enough, particularly by failing to visit their constituencies despite their requests for support.

Senior Sena leaders credit Shinde's son, Shrikant, with playing a "central role" in bringing six Uddhav Sena MPs into the party fold and increasing its bargaining power vis-à-vis the BJP.

To navigate the challenges following the split and ensure the survival and resurgence of the Uddhav faction, several strategic actions could be considered:

- There is an urgent need to resolve grievances and restore unity and confidence among supporters.
- If the faction fails to acknowledge divides and shifting public sentiments, they risk losing influence in the future.
- Supporting credible and relatable leaders can inspire confidence, attract new supporters, and energise the existing base
- Focusing on key issues such as employ-

ment, education, and infrastructure can empower supporters and garner their backing.

- Outreach initiatives and campaigns addressing local issues can foster trust and a sense of shared purpose.
- Leveraging cultural heritage and engaging in social activities can reinforce regional identity and goodwill among the public.
- Being responsive to changing political sentiments and the expectations of younger generations is crucial for maintaining relevance.

Fostering internal cohesion is crucial during this period. Swiftly resolving internal conflicts and creating an inclusive environment can inspire hope and a shared sense of responsibility among supporters, strengthening party unity and resilience.

By implementing these strategies, the Uddhav faction can survive and potentially regain influence in Maharashtra's politics. However, if they fail to address internal divisions and adapt to changing public opinions, they may struggle to remain relevant.

Neither faction is electorally self-sufficient: Shinde relies on the BJP's machinery, while Uddhav depends on the MVA's combined vote share.

Therefore, the upcoming IHG assembly election will be a true test of which faction of the Shiv Sena survives.

Ultimately, the outcome depends largely on their strategic decisions and their ability to respond to the evolving political landscape in Maharashtra. The choices they make will be pivotal for the future of the Thackeray family and the party.

PIC TALK



A monkey drinks water to find relief from the heat, in New Delhi

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



www.dailypioneer.com



facebook.com/dailypioneer



[@TheDailyPioneer](https://twitter.com/TheDailyPioneer)



instagram.com/dailypioneer



linkedin.com/in/ThePioneer

‘Japa’ (chanting) is the ultimate mantra to please God



AJIT KUMAR
BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

I am stating this fact with full conviction, which is based on scriptural evidences and my personal experiences. Please sample these from the Bhagavad-Gita. Lord Krishna states, "I am chanting among the yajnas (sacrifices)." (10.25) And what is the greatest sacrifice? It is to chant God's names by giving up 'ahankar' (false ego). What was standing in between the bounden duty of Arjuna - a kshatriya and leaving the battlefield, as decided by him at the beginning of the conversation with Lord Krishna. (1.43) Arjuna's ahankar was the cause, as pointed out by the Lord to him. (18.58) And what warning was given by the Lord to Arjuna? "If you will not heed on account of your ahankar you will perish." (18.58)

What is our problem generally in giving up our ahankar? This is being self-centred with "I, I, I," or "mein,



mein, mein" have done this or that. We identify ourselves with our nature, which is dominated by false ego. Where does it lead to? Yes, perishing, which, unfortunately, is where one ends up. What should we do then? Exactly what Arjuna agreed to do, which was: I shall follow Your (God's) instructions." (18.73)

What are Lord's instructions, which will please Him? "Take My shelter only." (18.66) Why? "Lord Vasudeva is everything." (7.19) "Not of anyone else", is the instruction in the verse #9.22. It must be, "In all respects take God's shelter only." (18.62) "Develop My consciousness", is the instruction in the verse #18.65. This way one will remain in shelter of God by the mind and the intelligence. (12.8)

And this is the most perfect way to please God, which will entitle one to all kinds of benefits. Give up ahankar like Arjuna did. What did Arjuna get? Lord Krishna assured

him of enjoying the kingdom (2.37 and 11.33). Additionally, Arjuna was assured of opulences, victory, wealth and definite principles. (18.78) What has Lord Krishna promised us? "I will help in getting what you do not have and provide security of what you have? (9.22) Personally speaking, I have given up my ahankar and I go Krishna, Krishna, Krishna..... and God has become karta (doer) in my life. I am assured of success in whatever I take up under God's guidance. My life is going on smoothly, much beyond my wildest imagination. Who are my role models? I will begin with Lord Shiva. I have put His large photo in my bedroom. What is the Lord doing? Yes, chanting. The next big inspiration comes from Hanumanji, who pleased Lord Ramachandra by his chanting: Rama, Rama, Rama..... Adi Shankaracharya exhorted us to: "bhaja Govindam". Mother Ahilya should not be forgotten, who kept on chanting Rama, Rama, Rama.....till the Lord liberated her. Draupadi completes my list, who prayed to Lord Krishna to save her from the ultimate humiliation by chanting: Krishna, Krishna, Krishna.....

In conclusion, please give up ahankar and get started with any: Rama, Rama, Rama.....or Krishna, Krishna, Krishna.... or Shiva, Shiva, Shiva..... or Ohm, Ohm, Ohm..... (8.13) Getting started is all-important; God takes care of the rest.

The writer is a spiritual teacher

SAVE HIMACHAL FROM TIMBER SMUGGLERS BEFORE IT IS TOO LATE

Himachal Pradesh has long been one of North India's most cherished tourist destinations, celebrated for its pristine forests, majestic mountains and serene environment. However, alarming reports of rampant timber smuggling threaten not only the state's fragile ecosystem but also its tourism-dependent economy. Unchecked deforestation increases the risks of landslides, soil erosion, drying water sources and biodiversity loss, ultimately diminishing the natural beauty that draws millions of visitors each year. Equally concerning is the apparent ease with which timber smugglers transport illegal wood despite the presence of checkpoints. This raises serious questions about administrative negligence or possible collusion by enforcement officials.

A comprehensive investigation

is essential to identify loopholes and ensure accountability.

The government must also address the increasing friction between tourists and local residents. While tourism is vital for the state's economy, irresponsible behaviour by some visitors damages Himachal's reputation as a peaceful destination. Strict penalties for unruly tourists and restrictions on access to ecologically sensitive areas should be considered.

The protection of whistle-blowers, deployment of drones and satellite monitoring, and exemplary punishment for timber smugglers and corrupt officials are crucial. Preserving Himachal's forests is not merely an environmental obligation but an investment in the state's future prosperity.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

Living for likes, forgetting life

The smartphone and social media revolution has transformed modern life, but not always for the better. Increasingly, people are confusing virtual approval with real happiness. Algorithms now shape our opinions, choices and even our self-worth, while genuine human interaction steadily declines. Everyday experiences—from meals and shopping to vacations and celebrations—are no longer complete until they are uploaded online. Instead of living in the moment, people focus on recording it for social media.

Memories are replaced by reels, and personal milestones seem meaningful only after attracting likes and comments. This obsession has also weakened relationships. Friendships collapse over online disagreements, charity is often performed for publicity, and public opinion frequently outweighs personal judgment. Technology has undoubtedly made life more convenient, bringing shopping, entertainment and information to our fingertips. Yet convenience has come at the cost of emotional connection. Technology should remain a tool, not become the master of our lives. Unless we restore balance between the virtual and the real, we risk sacrificing meaningful relationships, independent thinking and inner contentment for fleeting digital validation.

KABIR AHMED SAIKIA | JORHAT

Seychelles: India's maritime security imperative

Seychelles may be a small island nation, but its strategic location along vital sea lanes connecting Asia, Africa and the Middle East gives it immense geopolitical significance. Strengthening India's partnership with Seychelles is therefore not merely a diplomatic exercise but a strategic necessity.

Closer cooperation will enhance maritime security, protect commercial shipping routes, combat piracy, curb illegal fishing and improve surveillance across the Indian Ocean. This aligns with India's vision of being the region's preferred security partner under the SAGAR (Security and Growth for All in the Region) initiative while complementing partnerships with other island nations.

The timing is particularly important as geopolitical competition in the Indian Ocean intensifies. China's expanding naval presence and infrastructure investments across the region underscore the need for India to maintain an active and dependable engagement with its maritime neighbours.

Our outreach must reassure friendly nations that India remains committed to regional stability and shared prosperity. Seychelles should therefore be viewed not as a peripheral partner but as a key pillar of India's Indo-Pacific strategy.

R. NARAYANAN | MUMBAI

Indian cricket needs serious introspection

This refers to "2nd T20I: Ireland beat World champions India by 1-run to win series" (June 29). India's shock 2-0 defeat to Ireland—their first T20I series loss in three years—cannot be considered a 'fluke'-Ireland deserves it.

The reality points out to the team playing cricket almost non-stop for months. Fresh from the high of winning the T20 World Cup, the players were thrust into another assignment without meaningful recovery. The result was evident: lapses in sharpness, missed opportunities, and a lack of the ruthless edge that usually defines India's short-format dominance. Fatigue is not merely physical; it erodes mental clarity and tactical discipline.

Shreyas Iyer, captaining India for the first time in T20s, faced the dual challenge of leadership transition and guiding a weary squad. The defeat also calls for serious thinking about player workload management. With domestic leagues, international tours, and IPL tournaments crowding the calendar playing in harsh weather conditions, by no means suitable for cricket of 6 hrs duration, taking heavy toll on players. Rotation policies and rest periods are no longer luxuries but necessities if India is to sustain excellence. Cricket boards must balance ambition with sustainability as it should be played in relaxed way.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDRABAD

One water for all: Transcending the artificial boundaries

As climate extremes become the new normal, India urgently needs a unified water governance framework .A ‘One Water for All’ approach—integrating urban, rural and forest landscapes into a single hydrological strategy—offers the only durable pathway to safeguarding livelihoods, biodiversity and long-term economic resilience.



BKP SINHA

ARVIND KUMAR JHA

Amid an escalating global climate crisis, India's environmental security has reached a critical inflection point due to a huge monsoon deficit across the core agrarian and central forest zones. In a nation where the southwest monsoon acts as the economic lifeblood, this severe climatic stalling-compounded by an intensifying El Nino-threatens to destabilize the national economy, rural livelihoods, and our natural resource base.

A severe urban water crisis is tightening its grip across major Indian cities. In business hubs like Mumbai, dwindling reservoirs have left the city with barely over a month of water reserves, forcing municipal corporations to ban water use for non-essential purposes like swimming pools and construction. While cities like Pune have been placed on alternate-day rationing schedules; Delhi, Jaipur, and Lucknow people endure hours-long queues at public distribution sites and grapple with falling groundwater tables that are threatening the structural and ecological stability of urban landscapes.

The agricultural sector, which employs nearly half of the country's population, faces widespread crop failures and rapid depletion of surface water reservoirs. Across critical farming belts in states like Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh, the extreme rainfall deficit-which reached over 40% in mid-June-has caused water bodies and many major reservoirs to dry and reach near-zero storage levels. Dependent on single, shared hand pumps or erratic, emergency water tankers for potable water, primary summer kharif crops sowing has become difficult. There is a rapid depletion of underground aquifers because of the desperate communities intensifying groundwater extraction to survive.

For the poorest of the poor-particularly the marginalized forest dwellers directly dependent on the ecosystem for survival-this hydrological breakdown is simply an existential threat. In the tribal belts of Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, and Madhya Pradesh, many hand pumps have dried up forcing the indigenous communities to the drudgery of extracting water from makeshift sand pits or small, muddy hill streams. As the drought dries up natural streams and forest sponges, forest dwellers get caught in a devastating trap. Increasingly pushed by popular schemes for intensive agriculture on poor quality lands in and around forest areas, the depletion of water bodies and local aquifers plunges them into a desperate, zero-sum competition for water between them and resource-stressed roaming wildlife. The death of eleven wild animals including three gaur and a blue bull in Melghat reserve of Maharashtra due to poisoning of water hole is just one example of the imminent escalation of human-wildlife conflict.

To mitigate the crisis in forest areas, forest departments across multiple states are working under intense climate stress to artificially replenish solar-powered borewells and concrete water troughs inside the reserves. The expanding footprint of human settlements within protected ecological zones, however, driven by the extensive grant of both habitation and cultivation rights under the Forest Rights Act (FRA) is significantly amplifying water stress inside India's wildlife habitats. This pressure is accelerating due to a recent heavy thrust by various state governments on Rule 16 of the FRA, which mandates post-claim support and departmental convergence to provide resources for the modernization of agriculture and increased crop productivity. Under this developmental push, state agencies are introducing intensive agricultural infrastructure, such as subsidized borewells and permanent irrigation wells, directly into forest interiors and wildlife areas. While these initiatives aim to uplift indigenous farming, they inadvertently cause deep, systemic



extraction of localized groundwater tables and the diversion of pristine perennial streams that wild animals have been relying on for survival. As natural water holes dry up under the strain of automated extraction and fragmented catchments, the ecological balance of these reserves is heavily disrupted, systematically forcing thirst-driven wildlife out of woodland interiors and into perilous, direct confrontations with human populations along the newly modernized agricultural fringes.

The National Disaster Management Authority recognizes "drought", a classification that state governments can declare solely based on strict, agriculture-centric scientific indices. This legal framework completely excludes wildlife areas from National or State Disaster Response Funds (NDRF/SDRF), which are statutorily reserved for human and agricultural relief. Consequently, forest ecosystems and national parks do not qualify for emergency disaster funds when water sources evaporate. Forest departments have to independently fund emergency interventions through internal budgets just as any routine forest or wildlife management issue.

Government's water resource funding policy framework operates on a structural hierarchy that prioritizes rural infrastructure and food security over urban centres but leaves deep gaps for tribal populations and forest and wildlife areas. Rural areas receive the dominant share of funding (65-70%), spearheaded by the Jal Jeevan Mission and agricultural drought-proofing schemes like PMKSY, while urban water management receives high regulatory and statutory focus (20-25%) via AMRUT 2.0 to protect industrial GDP through recycling and conservation mandates.

In contrast, tribal areas receive moderate funding integrated into broader rural sub-plans, though remote terrains cause heavy administrative and structural delays during active monsoonal failures. Finally, forests and wildlife areas receive the lowest emphasis. Water security under the Ministry of Environment is funded via restrictive eco-budgets resulting in reactive, micro-level field interventions rather than systemic, long-term drought proofing.

Ecological studies across South Asia, including data from the Kerala State Planning Board, the Goa Forest Department, and regions like Bardia and the Terai Arc land scape on Bhutan and Nepal borders establish that maintaining interior forest water holes acts as a vital spatial anchor that restricts wildlife movement within park boundaries and reduces human-wildlife conflict on agricultural fringes during severe dry seasons. However, long-term research-most notably a multi-decade study from Kruger National Park alongside technical findings from the Wildlife Institute of India study

in reserves like Bandipur National Park of Karnataka and Tadoba Tiger Reserve in Maharashtra warns that over-reliance on permanent, deep-borewell provisioning triggers severe ecological imbalances. It drives localized groundwater depletion, permanently dries up shallow natural springs, alters predator-prey dynamics, and causes habitat degradation or invasive weed expansion due to the constant congregation and overgrazing of dominant herbivores (the Piosphere effect).

While a bore-well actively steals water out of an aquifer, a rainwater check dam does the exact opposite. It catches water to recharge the aquifer. The schemes for the forest right holders must use eco-friendly material, avoid extractive approach, and species cultivated should make the area blend with its surroundings. Reconciling short-term conflict mitigation with long-term ecosystem resilience, modern conservation must shift toward "smart" water management, replacing continuous groundwater extraction with catchment engineering techniques like rainwater harvesting, and rotational pumping that mimic natural seasonal scarcity.

Policy makers must realize that catchment treatment in forest areas ultimately benefits not just the forests and wildlife but even the populations away from them. The traditional approach of acting in isolated silos while tackling the water crises of urban, rural, and forest areas must be discarded if we are to prevent total ecological and social breakdown. Water belongs to a single, continuous hydrological cycle; a severe monsoon deficit does not stop at a city limit or a forest boundary. In fact, bringing in the Forest Department as the main player, prioritization of ecological restoration and watershed management in upstream forests, hills, and wildlife areas must become the core of our national strategy, as these natural catchments serve as the hydrological sponges that regulate groundwater recharge and river flows for the whole country.

The concept of "One Water for All" can serve as a foundational pillar for water security akin to the global "One Health" framework, which recognizes that the health of humans, domestic animals, wildlife, and our shared environment are deeply interconnected.

Water does not conform to political boundaries; it links all living beings on Earth within a shared biological destiny. Only a "One Water for All" approach-which safeguards water security across urban, rural, and wild landscapes simultaneously; can protect the ecological integrity of natural habitats and secure the collective, intertwined future of all living systems on our planet.

The writers are Former PCCFs, UP and Maharashtra

UP's silent healthcare decentralisation revolution



ARVIND MOHAN SINGH

The story of Uttar Pradesh's healthcare system is much more than the story of hospitals and medical colleges. It is the story of a state that spent decades with advanced medical care concentrated in a handful of cities, and then witnessed one of the biggest transformations in its public healthcare system. For years, quality healthcare in Uttar Pradesh largely meant travelling to Lucknow. Today, that reality is changing. The biggest achievement is not the number of medical colleges built. The real achievement is that advanced healthcare is gradually reaching people where they live.

If we trace this journey from the British era to the present day, the biggest transformation was not the construction of a single institution. It was the decentralisation of healthcare. Modern medical education in Uttar Pradesh began during British rule with the establishment of King George Medical College in Lucknow. After Independence, there was an expectation that the healthcare infrastructure would gradually spread across the state. That, however, did not happen. Lucknow continued to remain the centre of the state's medical ecosystem. Congress governments moved beyond Lucknow, but only to a limited extent. Medical colleges were established in cities such as Kanpur, Allahabad, Meerut, Jhansi and Gorakhpur, yet the overall healthcare model remained unchanged. Advanced treatment remained concentrated in Lucknow, while large parts of Uttar Pradesh continued to depend on the capital for specialised medical care. In effect, the system expanded geographically, but it was never truly decentralised. However, when it came to building centres for advanced treatment, Lucknow remained the obvious choice.

The Samajwadi Party and Bahujan Yadvav Party governments largely maintained the same centralised healthcare model. While a few medical colleges were added and the Dr Ram Manohar Lohia Institute of Medical Sciences was established during the Mulayam Singh Yadvav government, it, too, was located in Lucknow. Advanced medical care continued to be concentrated in Lucknow, and for millions of people across Uttar Pradesh, a serious illness still meant travelling to the state capital. In effect, there was some expansion in medical education, but there was no meaningful decentralisation of healthcare.

The healthcare system continued to revolve around a few major cities. Most people in Uttar Pradesh understood one simple reality. A routine illness could be treated at the district hospital. But if the disease became serious, the family would eventually have to leave for Lucknow.

The biggest weakness of Uttar Pradesh's healthcare system was not only the shortage of doctors. The larger problem was that advanced medical care remained geographically out of reach for millions of people. The story begins to change after 2017. For Yogi Adityanath, healthcare was never just another government department. His understanding came from years of public life in eastern Uttar Pradesh. He saw parents travelling from one hospital to another with almost no hope. Those experiences shaped his understanding that Uttar Pradesh needed much more than better law and order. It needed a healthcare system where modern treatment was available closer to ordinary citizens. Perhaps that is why, after becoming Chief Minister, he looked at healthcare differently. The objective was not merely to build hospitals. The objective was to make advanced healthcare accessible. That became the foundation of healthcare decentralisation in Uttar Pradesh.

The government adopted a simple but ambitious vision. Every district should gradually have access to quality medical education and modern healthcare infrastructure. People should not be forced to travel to the capital for every serious illness. Advanced treatment had to move closer to where people actually lived. The vision soon began taking shape across the state. Medical colleges were approved, constructed or expanded across districts that had never seen such institutions before. The objective was not simply to add new buildings to the government's records. Every new medical college was expected to become the backbone of healthcare for its surrounding region.

Today, almost every district in Uttar Pradesh either has a medical college or one is under construction. District hospitals that once struggled with limited resources are gradually being upgraded to include teaching hospitals, modern operating theatres, dialysis units, intensive care facilities, blood banks, advanced laboratories, and specialist doctors. The transformation, however, did not stop with medical colleges. Dialysis services expanded across the state. Trauma care facilities have increased significantly. Cardiology, neurology, urology, and several other super-specialty services gradually became available beyond traditional urban centres. Modern CT scan facilities, MRI machines, Cath labs and other advanced medical equipment have reached hospitals that had previously referred almost every serious patient to Lucknow.

As a result, many patients who once had no option but to travel hundreds of kilometres can now receive treatment much closer to home. Higher medical education also witnessed rapid expansion. AIIMS Gorakhpur emerged as a major healthcare institution for eastern Uttar Pradesh. AIIMS Raebareli strengthened access to advanced treatment for central Uttar Pradesh. Super specialty blocks were added to several government medical colleges, while postgraduate medical education expanded steadily with new MD, MS and speciality programmes. Today, Uttar Pradesh has one of the largest public healthcare and medical education networks in India. The number of medical colleges has increased significantly. MBBS and postgraduate seats have expanded. Every year, the state is producing far more doctors than it did a decade ago. The character of Uttar Pradesh's healthcare system has changed. There was a time when serious illness almost automatically meant travelling to Lucknow.

Today, for millions of people, quality treatment is available much closer to home. That is the real transformation. The greatest achievement of Uttar Pradesh's healthcare system is not merely the rise in the number of medical colleges. The greater achievement is that hope has moved beyond the boundaries of Lucknow and reached districts that had waited for decades. When a low-income family no longer has to travel hundreds of kilometres with a critically ill patient, a hospital becomes much more than a building. It becomes a symbol of trust between the state and its people. That, more than anything else, is the true meaning of healthcare decentralisation. That is Uttar Pradesh's silent revolution.

Arvind Mohan Singh is a socio-political analyst, columnist, and digital strategist



T SENTHIL SIVA SUBRAMANIAN

21st century is a technological and economic era for cooperation, and alliances thereby opening new platforms and opportunities to strengthen global growth. Countries around the world are navigating and exploring possibilities for cross functional collaboration to enhance investment which results in pronounced innovation and infrastructure, safe economic trade and secure commerce that will lead to enhance GDP.

India duly recognizes and respects the policy initiatives of global countries and stand by to provide handholding/committed support to global countries at various instances which includes Covid-19 crisis. Global leaders eye on India as we have strong ease of governance and ease of doing business, robust Swadeshi policy frameworks which forms eminent pillars for our nation's economic growth. India is spearheading in a variety of significant sectors that includes agriculture (Food security), energy security, defence systems, nuclear, semiconductor, quantum, telecom [5G and 6G] and a special focus on critical minerals which includes mineral processing, recycling, and smart waste management.

India's strong network and covalent bonding

QUAD: A Boost for India's swadeshi strategy

relationship with international countries as it is clearly visible and evident through the historic international visits by our Hon'ble Prime Minister of India Shri Narendra Modi forms a big backbone that invites enormous global investments and exchange of trade and commerce. QUAD-A strong framework initiative that covers and addresses maritime, critical minerals, new-age frontier technologies, health care which includes biomanufacturing (devices and pharmaceutical) and additional focus on disaster relief valuing human assistance. QUAD's mission will enhance economic Indo-Pacific energy security and market supply chain and logistics across the nations through common goals and shared resources. One of the most important initiative frameworks was QUAD Critical minerals which will open doors for cross critical mineral sharing among the QUAD countries that will boost and great push for many potential applications which includes automotive-Electrical Vehicle segment and defence security.

The main motto of QUAD is to have self-growth and growth of planets worldwide through shared common goals. QUAD, a new format and charged beginning in this emerging era for "like: Unified-Goal-minded countries" to harness and leverage the potential of natural resources and talent /skills available worldwide that could serve as a catalyst



for the economic growth of nation across the globe. QUAD-Open new avenues and platforms for our nation that will boost economic trade and commerce through robust and resilient policy frameworks and establishment of global hubs. QUAD countries would develop common and structured Standard Operating Procedures (SOP) for achieving smooth functions, sustainability that would lead to elevate capabilities of the global countries-India as we are aiming for Viksit Bharat@2047.

Swadeshi / Vocal for Local Formula

QUAD emerged as open-door platform for global countries to eye on significant sectors such as energy security, critical minerals and pointed focus on maritime surveillance that would enhance cross-country trade, secured and safe commerce among QUAD nations. QUAD will give a great push for our nation's critical mission, national green hydrogen mission, and semiconductor mission as well. Additionally, the QUAD has special focus and

unified approach on creating opportunities to open seaports like in Fiji that will enormously increase the exchange of trade and commerce across the countries that will add glory to economic policies and prosperities worldwide. India and global countries are intensively working to develop port infrastructure across Indo-Pacific cross corridors having a significant importance to open port in Fiji.

The tangible outcomes resulted in creating unique initiatives and formation of Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Corporation among the four countries to create a real-time maritime awareness and equivalently sharing maritime information. Through QUAD, countries are at ease and comfort to share their valuable information on collective agreement through user friendly formats. India has been strongly working to create a global HUB for maritime called as Information Fusion Centre - Indian Ocean Region in short called as IFC-IOR located in Gurugram acts as fusion among QUAD countries actively working to achieve common and shared goals. This acts as a nerve centre for Maritime awareness and economic hub.

India has been surviving successfully with sovereignty that led to climbing the ladder of stability and sustainability because of its robust resilience policy frameworks, value for peace, integrity, and human resources. These values form the basis and principal mantra for QUAD that acts as fulcrum and road map for Viksit Bharat.

The writer is Head Institute Industry Interface Program Hindustan College of Science and Technology, Mathura



**TRANSGLOBE
ADVISORS**

**Your Trusted
Management
Advisory**

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

POSCO court awards death to man for rape, murder

A POSCO court in Uttar Pradesh has awarded death penalty to a man for raping and murdering a three-year-old girl and also imposed a fine of ₹25,000 on him. District Government Counsel Manoj Kumar Pandey said Additional Sessions Judge and Special Judge (POCSO) Vinod Kumar Chaurasia on Monday sentenced Gagan Kumar to death under relevant provisions of the IPC Sections 376A (rape resulting in death), 302 (murder) and provisions of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

According to the prosecution, the court had reserved its verdict on June 8 after completion of arguments. It had convicted the accused on June 22. Pandey said that according to the prosecution case, the girl's mother had gone to her brother's in-laws' house on June 12, 2020. When she returned home around 9 pm, she found her three-year-old daughter missing.

On being questioned, the child's grandmother told her that around 7.30 pm, Kumar had taken the girl with him on the pretext of buying her toffees, he said. When the child did not return, family members launched a search and found her body near the accused's house.

An FIR was registered against Kumar at Handia police station on June 13, 2020, based on a complaint lodged by the girl's mother. The post-mortem examination confirmed that the child had been raped and strangled to death, the prosecution said. Observing the gravity of the offence, the court sentenced Kumar to death and directed him to pay the fine of ₹25,000, Pandey added.

Delhi court grants bail to former GST officer

A Delhi court has granted bail to a former Goods and Services Tax officer accused of facilitating fraudulent release of public funds, thereby causing a loss of around ₹5.50 crore to the Government exchequer. Special Judge Ruchi Aggarwal Asrani was hearing the bail plea of Ajit Singh, against whom the Anti-Corruption Branch (ACB) had registered a case.

According to the prosecution, the then Goods and Services Tax (GST) officer released 61 refund orders of around ₹5.50 crore from March to August 2023 in violation of statutory provisions and departmental safeguards. It alleged that the departmental scrutiny revealed grave irregularities, including sanction of refunds in a mechanical manner without verification; absence of mandatory financial parameters; use of fabricated or computer-generated invoices; lack of verification of business premises; processing within 7-10 days (instead of 60 days) and frequent shifting of business premises without scrutiny. The investigating officer (IO) claimed that the unusual haste in sanctioning refunds is an important incriminating circumstance in the present case, and that the "investigation has disclosed active role of applicant/accused (Singh) in facilitating fraudulent release of public funds resulting in wrongful loss of approximately 5.50 crore to the Government exchequer".

In the order dated June 27, the court noted that Singh had been in custody since May 28; all documentary evidence had been collected; only the forensic report was awaited; and the investigation regarding the accused had been completed.

Delhi HC to re-open today after summer vacations



The Delhi High Court will re-open on Wednesday after its month-long summer vacation. The high court, which continued to hold vacation benches during the summer break in June, is expected to take up several significant cases in July after its re-opening. CBI's petition against a trial court order discharging former Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, his deputy Manish Sisodia, former MLA Durgesh Pathak and all other accused persons in the liquor policy case is scheduled to be taken up on July 16.

The case was last heard by Justice Manoj Jain in May, when hearing was deferred to await the presence of counsel on behalf of the unrepresented AAP leaders, who had earlier boycotted the hearing before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma.

A division bench of the high court is scheduled to take up its suo motu contempt case against Kejriwal and others for their "vilifying" social media posts against Justice Sharma in relation on August 4. Enforcement Directorate's plea against Kejriwal's acquittal in two separate cases lodged against him for not appearing before the agency despite summonses issued in the excise policy case will also be listed on July 22.

Judicial review cornerstone of democracy: CJJ

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant has said judicial review should be viewed not as judicial supremacy but as a constitutional responsibility designed to preserve the rule of law whenever constitutional institutions fail to act within their prescribed limits.

"It would be no exaggeration to claim that this expansive power of review is a cornerstone of India's constitutional democracy, affirming that legality and constitutionality are fundamental preconditions to the exercise of Governmental authority," he said. The Chief Justice of India (CJI) made the remarks on Monday at the International Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance (IDEA) conference in Stockholm. The theme of the conference was "Safeguarding the Rule of Law — Experiences from India and Sweden".

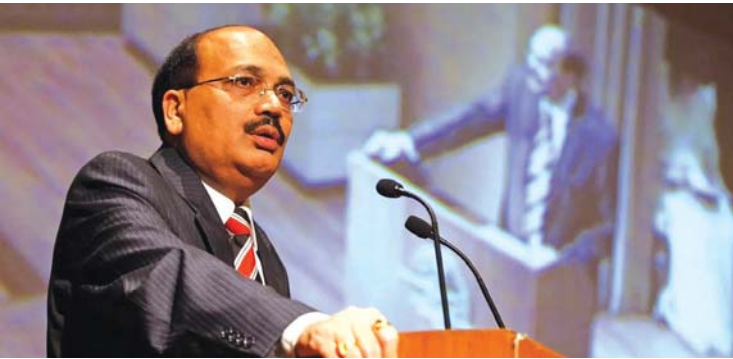
Justice Kant also underscored the centrality of the rule of law, judicial independence and constitutional democracy in safeguarding individual liberties, asserting that judicial review is not merely a power but a constitutional duty entrusted to the courts. "The rule of law is neither a welfare scheme nor an economic policy. It does not, by itself, bake bread, create livelihoods or remove poverty. What it does is something more fundamental, though less immediately visible: it disciplines the exercise of power. "It ensures that public authority acts through known,

stable and general rules; that citizens are treated as equals before the law; and that no person is left vulnerable to the whims of arbitrary Government," he said.

Tracing the roots of Indian legal consciousness to ancient traditions of "Dharma" that predate common law by millennia, the CJI said the principles of judicial independence and the rule of law are not mere "post-colonial imports" from the West.

He referred to India's constitutional journey since Independence and described the Constitution as a framework that guarantees rights while distributing powers among the legislature, executive and judiciary. He said the Constitution is a "tessellation of rights guaranteed to its citizens", while entrusting distinct duties, obligations and powers to the three pillars of governance — the legislature, the executive and the judiciary. "In the Indian template, the separation of powers is not a system of rigid, hermetically-sealed barriers, but a beautifully-calibrated network of checks and balances designed to prevent the concentration of absolute power. The Supreme Court has consistently intervened when this delicate equilibrium has been threatened," he said.

The CJI emphasised that the endurance of constitutional democracy depends not only on constitutional text but also on the faithful adherence of institutions to constitutional norms. "The greatest safeguard lies in an independent



judiciary, which must remain a vigilant guardian of constitutional supremacy," he said.

"This enduring commitment to independence enables the Indian judiciary to do more than simply resolve disputes or defend constitutional boundaries. It allows our courts to actively shape the democratic imagination of a vast and varied society and function as architects of democratic life itself," he said.

Referring to constitutional evolution, the CJI highlighted the landmark Kesavananda Bharati judgment, which established the basic-structure doctrine, and the S R Bommai decision, which strengthened federalism and democratic governance by requiring legislative floor tests before dismissing elected Governments.

He also outlined the constitutional safeguards that ensure judicial independence, including the separation of the judiciary from the executive, constitutional protections for

judges and institutional mechanisms governing judicial appointments.

Tracing the evolution of constitutional jurisprudence, Justice Kant said the Supreme Court has significantly expanded access to justice through Public Interest Litigation (PIL), enabling even disadvantaged and marginalised citizens to seek constitutional remedies.

He cited several landmark judgments that broadened the scope of Article 21 of the Constitution by recognising rights relating to speedy trial, dignity, livelihood and environmental protection.

The CJI highlighted the judiciary's contribution to environmental jurisprudence through doctrines, such as absolute liability, public trust and the polluter-pays principle.

He also referred to judicial interventions that strengthened electoral transparency, enhanced women's representation within legal institutions, addressed workplace sexual

harassment and expanded reproductive rights. While emphasising the judiciary's proactive role in protecting constitutional values, Justice Kant stressed that judicial activism must be accompanied by institutional restraint. "The rule of law is preserved only when the judiciary honours its own institutional boundaries while holding other branches to theirs," he said, adding that courts are not intended to function as "a second appellate authority or a super-executive" over policy decisions of the elected Government.

The CJI rejected the notion that judicial independence and the rule of law are exclusively western concepts and referred to the ancient Indian tradition by narrating the story of King Prahlada. He said India's constitutional experience demonstrates that constitutional values rooted in a diverse democracy possess universal relevance.

"The true strength of our judiciary lies not simply in its willingness to speak courageously when the constitutional fabric is threatened, but in its profound institutional wisdom to know when deference and restraint are themselves the highest expressions of constitutional fidelity," he said in his concluding remarks.

"The true strength of our judiciary lies not only in speaking courageously when constitutional values are threatened, but also in recognising when restraint itself is the highest expression of constitutional fidelity," the CJI said.

SC notice to Rajasthan on Asaram's plea challenging Rajasthan HC judgment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday sought response from the Rajasthan Government on a plea filed by self-styled godman Asaram challenging an order of the state high court, which had upheld his conviction and life sentence in the rape case of a minor in 2013.

While refusing to suspend Asaram's sentence, a bench of Justices MM Sundresh and Sheel Nagu issued notice to the state Government and sought its reply within two weeks.

The top court directed the jail authorities to extend medical facilities to Asaram, and said it will consider the grant of bail only if there is any grave health condition.

"We are not granting bail now. Subject to hearing the state we will consider if there is grave necessity to grant bail like in condition where his life is in danger," the bench observed orally. During the hearing, senior advocate DS



Naidu, appearing for the petitioner, submitted that Asaram is over 80 years of age and suffering from various ailments.

The Rajasthan High Court had on May 27 upheld Asaram's conviction in the case but acquitted him of charges related to gangrape and penetrative sexual assault on a child under the IPC and POCSO Act. The HC had acquitted Asaram of charges under IPC Section 376(D) and Sections 5(G)/6 of the POCSO Act. The court also discharged him under Section 120(B) of the IPC related to criminal conspir-

acy. However, the HC bench upheld his conviction under IPC Section 376(2)(F), pertaining to rape of a minor, thereby retaining the sentence of life imprisonment awarded by the trial court.

The high court had also upheld convictions under several other provisions, including Sections 342 (wrongful confinement), 370(4) (trafficking), 506 (criminal intimidation), 509 (insulting the modesty of a woman), 354(A) (sexual harassment) of the IPC, along with Sections 7/8 of the POCSO Act and Section 23 of the Juvenile Justice Act.

The bench further upheld his conviction under Section 376 of the IPC and Section 34 of the POCSO Act. The high court had acquitted co-accused Sanchita Gupta alias Shipil and Sharat Chandra.

Asaram was convicted on April 25, 2018 for sexually assaulting a minor student at his ashram and was sentenced to life imprisonment under multiple provisions of the IPC, POCSO Act, and Juvenile Justice Act.

SC directs status quo on Karnataka HC order directing enhancement of ethanol allocation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday directed status quo with regard to an order of the Karnataka High Court which directed enhancement of ethanol allocation for the Ethanol Supply Year (ESY) 2025-26.

The top court was hearing a plea filed by an oil marketing company which claimed that the high court's order would destabilise the national policy of 20 per cent ethanol blending for petrol.

A bench of Justices MM Sundresh and Sheel Nagu issued notice on the plea filed by the Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd challenging the high court order.

The high court had directed the Bharat Petroleum



Corporation Limited, Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited and Indian Oil Corporation Limited to consider and decide a representation submitted by a dedicated ethanol manufacturer seeking enhancement of ethanol allocation for the Ethanol Supply Year (ESY) 2025-26.

The high court had held that dedicated ethanol plants,

which were established pursuant to Government policy and are contractually bound to supply ethanol exclusively to Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs), cannot be denied the benefit of preferential allocation contemplated under the Long-Term Offtake Agreement (LTOA). Attorney General R Venkataramani submitted that HC's order directing OMCs to consider enhancement of ethanol allocation to VINP Distilleries and Sugars would destabilise the national policy.

The top law officer submitted that the 20 per cent ethanol blending programme in petrol is still an ongoing experiment and the impact of the policy would become clearer by next year.

Venkataramani pointed out that the ethanol supply

contracts were concluded in October 2025.

He said the ethanol allocation exercise attained finality on October 17, 2025, and allocations were communicated to 378 suppliers for a total supply of 1,050 crore litres of ethanol, of which 680 crore litres had already been supplied by them by June 18.

If one supplier's quota was enhanced, other similarly placed would claim parity which would open litigation floodgates, he said.

In its plea before the top court, Bharat Petroleum said the private supplier VINP Distilleries cannot claim an absolute right to supply ethanol based on its designed production capacity, to the detriment of other suppliers, as allocations have been made to vendors.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

The Rajasthan High Court has dismissed an election petition challenging the election of Ritu Banawat from the Bayana Assembly constituency in Bharatpur district in 2023, holding that the petitioner failed to establish any concealment of assets or other material information that could have affected the poll outcome or amounted to a corrupt practice.

A single-judge bench of Justice Sudesh Bansal, however, imposed a cost of Rs 1 lakh on Banawat for evading summons in the election petition for a prolonged period, observing that such conduct unnecessarily delayed the judicial proceedings by around 10 months.

The court on Monday directed Banawat, an independent MLA, to pay the amount to the petitioner within 30 days.

The election petition was filed by Purushottam Lal, who

also contested the Bayana Assembly seat in 2023.

Lal alleged that Banawat did not fully disclose details relating to her assets, liabilities, bank accounts and other material particulars in the Form-26 submitted along with her nomination papers.

The petitioner claimed that several columns in the affidavit were left blank and certain information was deliberately withheld, thereby infringing upon the voters' right to information.

After examining the evidence on record, the court held that the petitioner failed to prove that any alleged omission or non-disclosure by the returned candidate materially affected the election result or constituted a corrupt practice under election laws.

The court said there was no sufficient evidence to establish that the alleged deficiencies in the affidavit had misled the voters or vitiated the electoral process.

At the same time, the bench took note of the



conduct of the MLA in avoiding summons for a considerable period.

The court observed that such actions obstructed the judicial process and led to avoidable delays in adjudication of the election dispute.

The court said that even where an election is ultimately found to be valid, litigants cannot be permitted to frustrate court proceedings, and such conduct may invite financial consequences.

Accordingly, while dismissing the election petition, the court imposed costs of Rs 1 lakh on Banawat and ordered payment to the petitioner within 30 days.

TMC bank accounts: Calcutta HC refuses urgent hearing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday refused an urgent hearing to a petition by the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress over the freezing of its bank accounts.

Authorities placed a debit freeze on three TMC bank accounts, following complaints by rebel MLAs seeking a probe into the source of the funds. Refusing to give precedence in hearing of the petition by the Mamata Banerjee-led faction of the TMC, Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya said the matter will come up for hearing according to the listing serial.

The Mamata Banerjee-led faction's lawyer Kishore Dutta informed the court that three bank accounts of the party have been placed



under debit freeze, blocking all outward transactions from these accounts, and sought an urgent hearing in the matter. However, the court refused the plea for urgent hearing. The debit operations of three bank accounts of the Trinamool Congress holding around ₹440 crore have been frozen.

Delhi court grants bail to CBI official who allegedly stole ₹1 lakh during raid

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has granted bail to a CBI official accused of committing theft of ₹ one lakh during a raid at the house of a private person. Special Judge Chhavi Kapoor was hearing the bail application of the officer against whom the CBI had registered a case under Section 305 (theft in a dwelling house) of the BNS.

According to the prosecution, the accused, who was a member of the CBI search team during a raid at the premises of a private person, stole ₹ one lakh and later hid it under the mat of a vehicle. The prosecutor said that being an



officer of the CBI, the accused committed theft and betrayed the trust reposed in a public servant.

He said that an independent public witness saw the accused hiding the money under the mat. The

prosecution also claimed that the accused admitted his guilt in front of the other CBI officials after they witnessed the recovery.

In the bail order dated June 25, the court noted that the investigation had been completed and all material witnesses had been examined.

It said all essential electronic evidence had been seized and sent to FSL for forensic analysis, the alleged stolen amount was recovered and the statement of an independent public witness had been recorded.

"Since all the material aspects of investigation are complete, further custody of the accused is not required in the facts and circum-

stances of the case. The accused is reported to be a public servant and in the service of the CBI for the last several years," the court said.

It said that the accused did not appear to be at flight risk and there were no circumstances to suggest that releasing him would prejudice the probe. The court then granted him bail on a personal bond and surety bond of ₹50,000 each.

Other conditions of bail included the accused not leaving the Delhi-NCR area, not tampering with evidence or contacting witnesses, depositing his passport with the court and joining the probe when required.



ASHISH GUPTA
Co-Founder & CEO, EdNex Global

For years, students were told that a degree was the safest route to career security. That assumption no longer carries the same certainty. The debate has gained urgency because the job market has changed faster than most academic systems have been able to adapt. Automation, digital transformation and international competition are reshaping various sectors of business. However, students continue to graduate from programmes built on structures that cannot keep pace with the demands of contemporary employment. As a result, employability and competence remain misaligned. Degrees continue to hold undeniable value. They provide intellectual discipline and structured learning through the academic foundation required for profes-

sions where technical rigour and regulatory compliance are essential. However, the idea that a degree alone guarantees career readiness no longer reflects the reality of hiring. A graduate's competence to apply knowledge in real-world situations, adapt quickly to changing circumstances, and make a meaningful contribution from the outset is assessed rigorously. In sectors such as technology, business, media, design and emerging interdisciplinary domains, demonstrable capability often carries as much weight as formal qualifications. Recruiters are hiring for competence, context and readiness - not merely completion. It is often framed as a competition between traditional degrees and skill-based learning for the future of education. In reality, there is no need for students to choose between the two. They need both. The universities that will shape the future of higher education are not those that remain committed to theory without adaptation, nor those that abandon academic rigour in favour of career shortcuts. They will be the institutions that successfully combine applied learning with foundational knowledge, ensuring their graduates possess both practical competence and intellectual depth. That shift requires a more student-first approach from education providers. For too long, institutional success has been measured in isolation by admission volumes, rankings, or infrastructure metrics. Yet that is not the real test. The more meaningful benchmark is what happens after admission: whether students are equipped with the exposure, support and experience necessary to navigate a competitive global economy. This demands deeper integration with industry engagement. Experiential learning, interdisciplinary projects, international exposure and career-focused mentoring should be embedded into the student journey. Additionally, it compels educational institutions to reconsider how they define educational value. For students, the value of a qualification is ultimately determined by the range of opportunities it grants them.



Students, in turn, must become more deliberate in evaluating their choices. The right question is not which institution offers the most recognisable degree title, but which institution provides the strongest ecosystem for professional growth. Opportunities for hands-on learning, international exposure and mentorship are critical in pushing students to think beyond the classroom. The future will favour graduates who bring more than academic credentials to the table. It will favour those who combine formal education with adaptability, perspective and real-world capability. Higher education, therefore, is not moving towards a world where degrees disappear. It is moving towards one in which degrees must demonstrate greater relevance. In the years ahead, relevance will matter more than reputation, and capability will matter more than credentials alone.

SKILL-BASED EDUCATION v/s TRADITIONAL DEGREES

What should students choose?

CAMPUS CANVAS

South India leads India's online schooling boom

Nearly seven in ten metro students in Vikalp Online School's FY 2026-27 internal analysis come from Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai, highlighting the growing concentration of online schooling in India's southern technology hubs.

The data shows that metro cities account for 47 per cent of Vikalp Online School's student base in India. Among these metro enrolments, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai together contribute nearly 69 per cent, making South India the dominant region for the adoption of online schooling. Bengaluru accounts for 27 per cent of all metro enrolments, followed by Hyderabad at 23 per cent and Chennai at 19 per cent. Together, the three cities significantly outpace other metropolitan markets, including Mumbai, Delhi NCR and Kolkata. Beyond the metros, the data also indicates a widening interest in online schooling across the country. While metro cities account for 47 per cent of enrolments, Tier 1 cities contribute 35 per cent and Tier 2 cities account for the remaining 18 per cent, suggesting that alternative schooling models are gradually expanding beyond India's largest urban centres. While interest in online schooling is growing across the country, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Chennai continue to stand out as key markets. The concentration of students from these cities reflects the increasing acceptance of flexible and personalised learning pathways



Cyber talent gap widens

Nearly half of all cybersecurity roles globally remain unfilled as companies struggle to find professionals who possess both technical expertise and business acumen, according to a report by Accenture. The report, titled Reinventing the Cyber Workforce, revealed that 46 per cent of cybersecurity positions are currently vacant. It noted that while 59 per cent of open roles require a hybrid blend of technical depth, business knowledge and leadership qualities, only 40 per cent of the current workforce is employed in roles that fit that profile. "Modern cybersecurity sits at the intersection of digital platforms, AI deployment, regulatory accountability, operational resilience and customer trust. Accenture's analysis of more than 550,000 cybersecurity job postings and professional profiles reveals that the real constraint is not merely the number of cybersecurity professionals available, but whether they possess the right mix of technical and soft skills to operate effectively at the enterprise level. It is a gap between what modern cybersecurity requires and what labour markets have to offer," the report noted.



Career opportunities in India

JAYANT KHOBRADE
Ambassador of India to Spain and the Principality of Andorra

When young people ask me how to build a successful career, I offer them a few simple mantras. Careers are not built merely by securing a job; they are shaped by vision, purpose and the willingness to grow with the times. The first mantra is to choose your career in the larger context of today's Bharat and its place in the world. India is not merely a nation-state; it is a civilisation with an extraordinary legacy. For centuries, it was one of the world's leading economic powers, contributing between one-fourth and two-fifths of global GDP until the early nineteenth century. Today, India is once again on a remarkable rise. It is expected to become the world's third-largest economy before the end of this decade and remains the largest and most vibrant democracy on Earth. Our national aspiration, as given to us by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, is clear: Viksit Bharat, a developed India by 2047. While generations are commonly identified by letters such as Gen X or Gen Z, I prefer to call today's youth the Gen VB, the Viksit Bharat Generation. You are the generation that will write India's growth story and shape India's next chapter. Do not merely look for a career; build one that helps build India. My second mantra is simple: Follow your heart. Every day we make choices,

but a few decisions, such as choosing a profession or a life partner, shape the course of our lives. A career deserves careful thought, yet the most fulfilling path is often where passion and profession meet. When work becomes an expression of your passion, work-life balance ceases to be a struggle. When you look back at your life, following your heart appears to be far more rewarding than chasing recognition, money or fame. India today offers an unprecedented range of career opportunities. Alongside traditional professions such as the civil services, defence, engineering and medicine, entirely new avenues have emerged in entrepreneurship, investment banking, data science, artificial intelligence, biotechnology, cyber security and many other fields. Rapid technological advancement, digital transformation, and governance reforms have created an ecosystem in which talent can flourish across disciplines. Among these opportunities, the civil services continue to occupy a place of distinction because they provide the privilege of serving the nation directly through governance and public administration. From my own experience in the Indian Foreign Service, I can say that diplomacy is far more than ceremonial events or official receptions. Diplomacy is the art of advancing national interests while building international friendships. It involves strengthening partnerships, protecting India's interests abroad and assisting members of the Indian diaspo-

ra whenever they need support. As India's global role continues to expand, the opportunities to contribute meaningfully through public service have never been greater. Entrepreneurship is another area where India's transformation has been remarkable. Supported by initiatives such as Startup India and Digital India, the country has become the world's third-largest start-up ecosystem. Indian entrepreneurs are creating innovative solu-

FOLLOW YOUR HEART... A CAREER DESERVES CAREFUL THOUGHT, YET THE MOST FULFILLING PATH IS OFTEN WHERE PASSION AND PROFESSION MEET

industries; they are shaping the future of economies and national security alike. Programmes such as Make in India, Skill India and the Production-Linked Incentive Scheme are creating new possibilities for young Indians across technology, manufacturing, research, academia and innovation. The coming decades will reward those who combine knowledge with creativity and the courage to solve real-world problems. My third mantra is this: Securing entry into a profession, however, is only the beginning. The world is changing at an extraordinary pace, and every profession is being transformed by technology. Your choice may open the first door, but continuous learning will take you to the next step on the ladder of higher goals. Those who stop upgrading their skills will eventually be replaced by those with better skills, regardless of how successful they once were. Lifelong skilling is no longer an advantage; it is a necessity. Finally, let me share a piece of advice that I often gave my son during his student years. To achieve anything meaningful in life, keep your body fit and exercise regularly. To keep your mind calm and focused, practise meditation. A strong body gives you the energy to pursue your dreams; a peaceful mind gives you the wisdom to achieve them. I wish every young reader the courage to dream boldly, the discipline to work tirelessly, and the confidence to believe that your success and India's progress can go hand in hand.

What higher education must look like in the next decade

RAMAKRISHNAN RAMAN
Vice Chancellor, Symbiosis International (Deemed University)

Higher education has weathered disruption before. When the internet arrived, many predicted it would make universities obsolete. It did not — but it changed them in ways that took a generation to absorb fully. What we are living through now feels different. Not because the technology is louder or faster, though it is both, but because it strikes at something more fundamental: the question of what a university is actually for. Artificial Intelligence is no longer a horizon we are moving towards — it is the ground we are already standing on. In classrooms, laboratories, and administrative offices across the world, intelligent systems are reshaping how universities function, how faculty teach, and how students learn. And yet, deploying AI tools is the easier part. The harder task is reimagining education itself — so that universities produce not graduates who can operate alongside AI, but graduates



If AI can write reports, generate code, analyse data, and respond to complex queries within seconds, what will continue to distinguish a human professional?

who can lead in a world shaped by it. This raises a question every institution must answer honestly. If AI can write reports, generate code, analyse data, and respond to complex queries within seconds, what will continue to distinguish a human professional? The answer is not a longer list of technical competencies. It is something older and harder to teach — a set of enduring human capabilities that technology can support but will never authentically replace. An AI-native university has not bolted AI onto its existing structures. It has rebuilt itself around it. Students benefit from learning journeys tailored to their individual strengths, gaps, and pace — not the standardised curriculum designed for an average student who, in truth, has never really existed. Too many talented students have struggled not because they lacked ability, but because the system moved at someone else's pace. Intelligent systems can now identify knowledge gaps in real time, recommend targeted resources, and adjust evaluations based on individual progress. Learning shifts from memorisation towards mastery — and a university's relationship with students need not end at graduation, but can extend through upskilling and personalised guidance across an entire professional life.



The evolution of the faculty role deserves to be understood as an elevation, not a threat. AI can generate assessments, summarise research, and answer the kinds of questions that once consumed office hours. As these capabilities mature, educators will increasingly become mentors and facilitators — people whose value lies not in how much they deliver in a lecture, but in how effectively they help students interpret knowledge, challenge assumptions, and apply learning in situations that resist easy answers. That is, if we are honest, what the best teachers have always done. Assessment is where universities will face their most urgent reckoning. An institution that continues to evaluate students through essays and assignments that AI can complete in minutes is not assessing students at all — it is assessing the tools available to them. Future assessments must move

towards simulations, case studies, live presentations, and oral examinations that reveal how a student actually thinks. The goal is not to prevent AI use, but to design evaluations where human capability is unmistakably what is being measured. And that brings us to what universities must most deliberately protect: the capabilities that remain irreducibly human. Conflict resolution requires the emotional intelligence to transform disagreement into collaboration. Negotiation depends on reading people and building the kind of trust that comes only from authentic exchange. Empathy allows leaders to understand motivations and lived experiences in ways that no pattern-recognition system can. The ability to stand before a room and move people — to adapt a message in the moment, to earn credibility through presence — remains a fundamentally human strength. So does the resilience to guide others through uncertainty without a guaranteed map. These are not soft skills. They are the skills that determine whether a person can lead, and no algorithm will replicate them. The universities that will matter in the decade ahead are those that hold both commitments together — building genuine AI literacy while investing with equal seriousness in human character and capability. These are not competing priorities. They are the two halves of the same task. The graduates who will shape the world ahead are not those who can use AI most fluently. They are those who bring to it the judgement, empathy, and wisdom that no machine will ever be able to supply.

FROM THE WORLD

THAILAND

Tourist charged with murder

An Australian man was charged with murder and concealment of a body in connection with the death of a teenage girl in an eastern tourist city in Thailand, police said on Tuesday. The 17-year-old girl was reported missing on Friday. Police said she was last seen on security footage walking into a condominium with the suspect, Simon Peter Carman, in the popular beach city of Pattaya about 150 km east of Bangkok. Carman was later seen leaving the building alone with a large suitcase and security footage showed him loading the suitcase onto a motorbike and riding into a deserted area along the railway, local police said. Carman was arrested early Saturday at a Bangkok airport before boarding a flight bound for Perth, Australia, and charged with raping a minor.

ITALY

Ancient paintings unveiled publicly

Italy on Tuesday put on display one of the best-known examples of Etruscan painting, from a tomb that has become the latest acquisition in the Culture Ministry's buying spree of big-ticket pieces of the country's cultural heritage. The ministry announced in May that it had acquired the fresco panels, dating from the 4th century, from members of the Torlonia family, one of Italy's ancient noble families whose vast collection of antiquity has long been kept out of the public domain.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Anam D/o Mr. Ahmed Raza who is purchasing first floor without roof terrace rights of property bearing no. 8, area measuring 50 Sq. Yds. out of Khata no. 380, 391, 395, 404, 405, 415, Situated in the area of Village Bindapur, Delhi State, Delhi colony known as G-block Extn., Uttam Nagar New Delhi-110059. from Mrs. Pinki Singhal W/o Mr. Dinesh Singhal who had owned the subject property vide Notarized GPA, ATS & Will dated 04.02.2026 executed by Mrs. Madhu Rani Gupta W/o Mr. Shyam Kumar Gupta, now Mrs. Anam D/o Mr. Ahmed Raza is intend to purchase the subject property and same to be mortgaged with ADITYA GIRLA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucem Legal LLP No-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Vihar Saira Community Centre New Delhi-110048 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41687327

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Shalu Jain claims to be owner and in possession of First Floor of Property No.C-167, VivekVihar Phase-1, Delhi-95 (hereinafter called the said property) by virtue of Sale Deed dated 17.02.2025 reg vide Doc No.2025/18/1290 having purchased from Chamell Devi Construction Pvt. Ltd. & said Shalu Jain has agreed to create a mortgage in favour of our clients IDFC FIRST BANK LTD, Rajendra Place Branch, any persons/ having claim against the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, lien or otherwise howsoever, are hereby intimated to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7days from the date hereof, failing which claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned and our client shall proceed with the disbursement of loan and subsequent creation of mortgage in respect thereof.

Vishal Diwan (Advocate)

Diwan & Company

Ho.No.2 (LGF), NRI Complex, N.D-19

Email: vishal@diwan.com

Gor dismisses row over renaming Indo-Pacific command

SAGAR KULKARNI

■ Washington

US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor dismissed the row over the renaming of the Indo-Pacific Command, saying the "name on the letterhead" does not matter rather look at what America is actually doing.

Addressing the US-India Strategic Partnership Forum Leadership Summit Gor said India still conducts more military exercises with the US than any other country and has regular bilateral visits of defence officials.

Gor's remarks came in the wake of a row over dropping 'Indo' from the Indo-Pacific Command. Established in 1947,



US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor

the US Pacific Command is among the oldest unified commands of the US that extends from the west coast of the US to India's western border.

During US President Donald Trump's first term, the Pacific Command was renamed as

Indo-Pacific Command, citing the growing importance of India in the Indo-Pacific region.

Earlier, this month the US restored the original name of the unified command. "I just want to mention something because a lot of individuals

made hay over a name change. I don't care what name is on a letterhead, but look at what the United States is actually doing," Gor said.

"Yes, the name changed; we're still there. India still has more exercises with the United States than any other country by far. Every single month there's something happening, whether it's Indian troops coming here or whether it's US troops going into the region," the US envoy said.

He said in the next two weeks, a delegation of the Indian Navy will be visiting the US. Gor also rejected suggestions that bilateral ties had weakened. Gor said the overall relationship remained on a strong footing. "So to all

those pundits that sit online and tweet and say, this relationship is in trouble, when you look at the facts of where this relationship stands, whether it's trade, whether it's defence, whether it's the people to people ties, the relationship is on strong footing," he said.

Gor said President Trump attached significant importance to ties with India and remained committed to expanding cooperation across trade, technology, defence and investment.

The US envoy to India recalled an incident when Trump decided to call Modi from Miami, where he was attending the Ultimate Fighting Championship

bouts. "It was a couple months ago... with the president at UFC in Miami and we're sitting backstage and he said to me, 'Let's call the Prime Minister'," Gor said.

"I said, 'Sir, it's 6:00 AM in the morning there (India).'" He said, 'He(Modi) will be up. He (Modi) is like me,'" Gor said, recalling Trump's remarks. Gor said by the time he managed to speak to a few people in New Delhi, Trump was already on the UFC stage and eventually the call with Modi was scheduled for the following day. Gor said the incident showcased the nature of the relationship between Trump and Prime Minister Modi. "The louder message of that story is when

you're friends with somebody, not everything has to be scheduled," Gor said, adding that the president truly considers the Prime Minister a friend.

"His years with the Prime Minister go back to his first term. There's warm memories of India. And so that's an incredible benefit," he said.

"The United States wants to work hand in hand with India," Gor said, adding that the next two years would be critical in shaping bilateral ties for decades to come. "These next two years will set the relationship on a path for several decades ahead. So for everyone here who participates in this, think of this as a long-term project. (PTI)

Tribunal sentences Hasina's ally to 10 years

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Dhaka

A Bangladeshi tribunal on Tuesday sentenced an ally of deposed former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina to 10 years' imprisonment on charges of committing "crimes against humanity" during the 2024 street protests.

Hasanul Haque Inu, a left-leaning politician, served as a minister in Hasina's coalition government from 2012 to 2018 but had no links to the regime since then.

A 1971 Liberation War veteran and president of Jatiya Samajtantrik Dal, Inu was accused of ordering police to kill six people in his home district, Kushtia, during the 2024 uprising, inciting attacks on protesters and maintaining telephonic links with Hasina, who fled to India in August 2024.

Bangladesh's International Crimes Tribunal (ICT-BD) handed down the punishment to Inu as he stood trial in person on eight separate charges. Other charges included incitement of "use of deadly force" against protesters and direct involvement in decisions for military deployment, curfew imposition and "shoot



Hasanul Haque Inu

on sight" orders. The tribunal's three-judge panel pronounced the verdict as police brought Inu from jail under heavy security.

"We are totally dissatisfied with the verdict. We think he deserved capital punishment. Definitely we will appeal against the judgment (in the Supreme Court)," ICT-BD Chief Prosecutor Aminul Islam said.

UK launches defence plan after bitter budget delays

JILL LAWLESS

■ London

Self-flying fighter jets, uncrewed submarines and drones will be at the center of Britain's future military under a defence plan being announced on Tuesday that reflects a world of conflicts transformed by technology.

The Defense Investment Plan has been repeatedly delayed as military leaders and Treasury officials wrangled over the cost of equipping the UK military for an increasingly dangerous world.

Like other NATO countries, the UK is under pressure to increase defence spending to counter a more aggressive Russia and less reliable United States. John Healey resigned as defence secretary on June 11, accusing the Government



of being unwilling to spend enough on the military at a time of "rising threats."

Healey argued that UK defence spending must reach 3 per cent of GDP by 2030, citing a British intelligence assessment that Russia

could attack a NATO member country by then. He said that the plan put forward by the Treasury would see spending rise to just 2.68 per cent in 2030, after hitting 2.6 per cent next year.

The Government says the spending plan has been "refocused" in the past few weeks under Healey's successor, Defence Secretary Dan Jarvis.

That includes a bit more money than the 13.5 billion pounds (\$18 billion) Healey was offered, but likely far less than the 28 billion pounds (\$37 billion) that defence officials called for.

Prime Minister Keir Starmer said the plan will ensure "our servicemen and women have the cutting-edge capabilities they need to deter evolving threats and keep the British

people safe." The full document is due to be published later Tuesday. The plan is a road map for how the UK will increase military spending to NATO's target of 3.5 per cent of GDP by 2035.

The UK military is seeking to reverse years of decline in the face of an increasingly assertive Russia, which invaded its neighbour Ukraine in 2022 and increasingly tests the defences of European nations with overt and covert activity.

The UK has watched how drones have transformed war in Ukraine, which uses 200,000 of them a month to defend against Russian forces. Britain plans to invest billions in drone systems across all branches of the military. (AP)

US envoy Steve Witkoff arrives in Qatar for talks

JON GAMBRELL

■ Dubai

Two US envoys arrived in Qatar on Tuesday for talks with mediators about the implementation of an initial deal to end the war in Iran, an official said.

The visit by Steve Witkoff, US President Donald Trump's special Mideast envoy, and Jared Kushner, his son-in-law, comes after a weekend of crossfire in the Persian Gulf over efforts to reopen the Strait of Hormuz to shipping traffic. The envoys won't be having direct negotiations with Iranian diplomats while in Qatar's



capital, Doha, said Majed al-Ansari, a spokesman for Qatar's Foreign Ministry. Instead, mediators are working for the time being as go-betweens for the talks, which won't include any high-level officials, he added.

Indian envoy to visit INS Sudarshini in Baltimore

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Washington

Indian Ambassador to the US, Vinay Kwatra, visited INS Sudarshini at a port in Maryland and lauded the crew for their efforts to build bridges of mutual cooperation and trust.

INS Sudarshini is participating in the SAIL 250 Maryland event, commemorating America's 250th anniversary.

"Ambassador Vinay Kwatra visited Indian Naval Ship Sudarshini at the port of Baltimore, Maryland on 28 June 26, which is currently participating in the SAIL 250 Maryland event from 25-29 June 26," the Embassy of India in Washington posted on X.

"The Commanding Officer briefed the Ambassador on the LOKAYAN 26 progress, conduct of the five months long transoceanic voyage covering around 13000 nm (nautical miles) and the preparation towards forth-



Indian Ambassador to the US, Vinay Kwatra

coming SAIL 4th 250 New York and SAIL Boston events." "The Ambassador wished the crew the very best towards continuing their spectacular voyage and sustaining efforts to build bridges of mutual cooperation and trust amongst nations," it said.

Protests in South Africa over illegal migration

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Johannesburg

Thousands of demonstrators gathered in parts of South Africa to rally against illegal immigration on Tuesday, which some protest groups set as a deadline for the departure of all illegal migrants from the country.

South African groups are planning to blame illegal immigrants for causing unemployment among South Africans by accepting low wages, as well as high levels of crime and other problems.

The Tuesday deadline set by the groups for migrants to leave was not recognised by South Africa's Government, which has

maintained that only authorities can enforce immigration laws. The most prominent groups opposing illegal immigration include March and March, Operation Dudula and Progressive Forces.

President Cyril Ramaphosa met Monday night with leaders of some of the groups and asked them to conduct peaceful demonstrations. The South African police have deployed hundreds of officers in cities including Johannesburg in Gauteng province and Durban in KwaZulu-Natal province to prepare for potential violence. Previous marches against illegal immigration have resulted in attacks on migrants and vandalism of



foreign-owned businesses.

Officers and private security firms have also been deployed in the Eastern Cape province, where previous demonstrations against illegal immigration have

turned violent, with some public infrastructure destroyed and shops owned by foreign nationals forced to close.

The planned protests have sparked fear of violence

among thousands of migrants, primarily from neighbouring Zimbabwe and Malawi, who have gathered at their embassies and consulates to request transport back to their countries.

There has been increased traffic over the past few days at the Beitbridge checkpoint along the Zimbabwe border as buses carrying migrants left South Africa. Thousands of Malawian nationals have also returned to their country from a temporary repatriation centre in Durban.

Demonstrators were seen gathering early Tuesday in parts of Durban, while there were reports of more protesters in parts of the North West and Free State provinces.



Consul General of India in New York Binaya Srikanta Pradhan and Vikas Khanna during India Pavilion inauguration at the Summer Fancy Food 2026, in New York, United States

Indian food products showcased at trade show in New York

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ New York

More than 70 Indian exhibitors are showcasing agricultural and processed food products at a food show in New York, providing exporters an opportunity to strengthen their business in the US market.

The 2026 Summer Fancy Food Show saw India's largest-ever participation at America's premier speciality food exhibition, bringing together Indian food brands, exporters and innovators.

The North American market for Indian consumer packaged food products is



Consul General of India in New York Binaya Srikanta Pradhan and Vikas Khanna during India Pavilion inauguration at the Summer Fancy Food 2026, in New York, United States

estimated to represent about \$30-50 billion worth. Consul General of India in New York, Binaya Pradhan and Michelin-starred chef Vikas Khanna

inaugurated the India Pavilion on Monday at the Jacob K Javits Convention Centre, where the trade show is being held from June 28-30.

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE						
SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	PWD B&R, SIRSA	DNIT FOR CONSTRUCTION OF BOUNDARY WALL AND PROVIDING CONCERTINA COIL FENCINGCH. DEVT LAL GOVT. POLYTECHNIC COLLEGE AT NATHUSARI CHOPTA IN SIRSA DISTT.(WITHOUT GST) + 1 WORKS	26.06.2026 03.07.2026	85.70 lacs	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01666222959 pwd-eeep2-sirsa@hry.nic.in
2	PWD B&R, PALWAL	ANNUAL MAINTENANCE OF PONTOON BRIDGE OVER YAMUNA RIVER NEAR VILLAGE GURWARI IN PALWAL DISTT. FOR THE YEAR 2026-27 (DISMANTLING AND LAUNCHING) (WZTHOUT GST). + 2 WORKS	26.06.2026 02.07.2026	61.84 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9466219169 pwd-eeepd-palwal@hry.nic.in
3	PWD B&R, HANSI	CONSTRUCTION OF CRECHE IN JUDICIAL COURT COMPLEX AT HANSI DISTRICT (WITHOUT GST).	26.06.2026 02.07.2026	15.61 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01163259688 pwd-eeepd-hansi@hry.nic.in
4	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, CHARGH DADRI	SUPPLY AND FIXING OF 05 NOS. MS DELIVERY PIPE OF 35 CS VT PUMP AT PUMP HOUSE NO. 1 OF LOHARU CANAL	CLOSING DATE 02.07.2026	7.71 lacs	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01250-220058 xenlwsmech@gmail.com
5	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING,MANDI DABWALI	MANDI DABWALI:- "DNIT FOR THE WORK OF CONSTRUCTION OF IPS IN UTTAM NAGAR, COLLECTING TANK (6.00 A— 4.00 M), PUMP CHAMBER, BOUNDARY WALL, INSTALLATION OF PUMPING MACHINERY AND PROVIDING AND LAYING OF SEWERAGE SYSTEM, ALONG WITH ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO" . CH. HEAD:- MANDI DABWALI:- PROVIDING SEWERAGE SYSTEM IN NEWLY APPROVED COLONY AND CONSTRUCTION OF IPS AT UTTAM NAGAR AT DABWALI TOWN DISTT. SIRSA.	26.06.2026 13.07.2026	1487.45 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8730000001 ee.mandidabwali@gmail.com
6	ZILA PARISHAD, PANIPAT.	CONSTRUCTION OF PRIMARY HEALTH CENTRE AT VILLAGE-KABRI,BLOCK-PANIPAT	25.06.2026 06.07.2026	409.57 lacs	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	7027133058 xenzilparishadpanipat@gmail.co
7	ZILA PARISHAD, AMBALA	SIRSGARH BLOCK BARARA CONST. OF IPB STREET FROM MAIN ROAD TO SUNIL ADVOCATE CONST. OF IPB STREET FROM OM PARKASH TO MINTU AT SIRASGARH (DOSARKA) BLOCK BARARA DISTT. AMBALA (VANGY) + 21 WORKS	26.06.2026 03.07.2026	162.42 lacs	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01712975281 zpexenambala@gmail.com
8	PANCHAYATI RAJ, AMBALA	HGVY CONST. OF BRICK PAVED RASTA FROM FIELD OF HARKIRAT TO FIELD OF KULBHUSAN IN VILL. BEGOMAJRA BLOCK AMBALA-1	26.06.2026 02.07.2026	7.69 lacs	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0171-2551368 prexeeng.amb@hry.nic.in
9	PANCHAYATI RAJ, SONIPAT	CONSTRUCTION OF IPB SHAMSHAN GHAT RASTA AT VILLAGE TEHA + 1 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 02.07.2026	107.30 lacs	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416391006 prexeeng.snp@gmail.com
FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in						RO 46684-I-27-7

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

After Trent, Noel Tata to step down as Voltas chairman

Almost a week after stepping down as chairman of Trent, Noel Tata announced on Tuesday that he would also relinquish the chairmanship of another Tata group firm, Voltas. Addressing shareholders of the leading cooling products maker in its 72nd annual general meeting (AGM), Noel Tata, 69, said this would be his last AGM as Chairman of Voltas. “As you might be aware, this will be my last annual general meeting as Chairman,” Noel Tata said in his address to shareholders.

He said the company has developed its next generation of leaders through a combination of internal promotions and lateral hiring and expressed confidence in the management’s ability to drive future growth. “The company has developed our next generation of leaders, from both in-house promotions and lateral hires. I am confident that with the close cooperation of seasoned practitioners and new talent, your company will continue to take big strides in all business segments,” he said. Thanking shareholders, employees and business partners for their support over the years, Tata said he was satisfied with the company’s current position and growth trajectory. “I would like to sincerely thank all our shareholders, colleagues and partners for your trust, understanding and constant support over the years,” he said. Noel Tata had joined the board of Voltas on January 27, 2003. He was appointed as the non-executive chairman of Voltas on September 1, 2017, succeeding the outgoing chairman, Ishaat Hussain. (PTI)

JFE Steel Corp acquires additional 25% stake in JSW JFE Kalinga for ₹ 7,875 cr

JFE Steel Corporation on Monday acquired an additional 25 per cent stake in JSW JFE Kalinga for ₹7,875 crore. The transaction stands fully completed and JFE now holds 50 per cent of the shareholding in JSW JFE Kalinga and, JSW Steel said in an exchange filing. On March 30, 2026, JSW Steel said JFE investing ₹7,875 crores, being the first tranche of its investment in JSW JFE Kalinga Steel Limited, formerly known as JSW Kalinga Steel Limited (JSW JFE Kalinga), resulting in JFE holding 25 per cent of the shareholding (on a fully diluted basis) in JSW JFE Kalinga. JSW Steel had also intimated that consequent to the said investment and changes in the board composition of JSW JFE Kalinga in terms of the Joint Venture Agreement dated December 3, 2025, the company and JFE had established joint control over JSW JFE Kalinga and its wholly-owned subsidiary, JSW JFE Steel, formerly known as JSW Sambalpur Steel Limited. (PTI)

Supply chain integrity: Enforcement against black marketing

The true strength of an energy supply chain is not measured only by how much fuel it imports or how efficiently it refines crude. It is measured by something far less visible: whether every litre of petrol, every drop of diesel and every LPG cylinder reaches the citizen it is meant for. In a country as large and diverse as India, with over 90,000 fuel retail outlets, thousands of LPG distributorships and more than 33 crore domestic LPG consumers, maintaining this integrity is not merely a logistics challenge-it is a governance challenge. Every supply chain creates opportunities for leakages. Diversion of diesel to industrial users, hoarding during periods of uncertainty, illegal decanting of LPG cylinders, duplicate domestic connections, adulteration of transport fuels and unauthorised resale have historically threatened both consumer confidence and public resources. Left unchecked, these practices distort markets, create artificial shortages and undermine the very purpose of equitable energy access. What distinguishes India’s approach today is that enforcement is no longer dependent only on physical inspections. It has evolved into a technology-enabled ecosystem where digital visibility, predictive surveillance and strict regulatory action work together to ensure that the supply chain remains transparent from refinery gate to retail

outlet and from LPG bottling plant to household kitchen. The recent global energy disruption once again demonstrated why such systems matter. Whenever uncertainty enters the market, black marketing follows close behind. Anticipating this risk, the Government moved quickly to strengthen surveillance across the country. States established dedicated control rooms to monitor petroleum supplies, while Oil Marketing Companies intensified inspections across retail outlets and LPG distributorships. Thousands of enforcement raids were carried out against illegal storage and diversion, leading to large-scale seizure of illegally stocked LPG cylinders and prosecution of offenders. At the same time, OMC field teams conducted thousands of surprise inspections every day, ensuring that distribution remained uninterrupted while preventing panic-driven hoarding. The response was equally proactive in the retail fuel sector. In June 2026, the Government introduced new regulations governing the sale of petrol and diesel through retail outlets. The objective was simple but significant: eliminate opportunities for diversion before they occur. Diesel sales were restricted primarily to vehicle fuel tanks and approved containers, daily quantity limits were prescribed, and resale of retail fuel was prohibited. Bulk industrial consumers were required to procure fuel through designated bulk supply channels rather than purchasing subsidised retail fuel. These measures addressed a growing arbitrage where lower retail diesel prices had encouraged illegal diversion into commercial markets. Yet regulation alone cannot protect a supply chain of this scale. The real

transformation has been digital. Today’s fuel distribution network generates continuous streams of operational data. Tank trucks transporting petroleum products are GPS tracked from dispatch to delivery. Tamper-proof electronic locking systems help detect unauthorised access during transit. Automated tank gauging systems continuously reconcile inventory at retail outlets, while digitally integrated dispensing units maintain transaction records that significantly reduce the possibility of manual manipulation. Every delivery creates a digital audit trail, allowing abnormal patterns to be identified much earlier than traditional inspection-based systems ever could. LPG distribution has undergone an equally significant transformation. The entire consumer lifecycle-from new connection to refill booking, subsidy transfer, portability and Know

Your Customer verification-has progressively shifted onto digital platforms. Every refill leaves behind a digital record, allowing distributors and Oil Marketing Companies to analyse unusual booking behaviour, identify duplicate usage patterns and detect abnormal consumption trends that may indicate diversion. Even structural reforms have been designed with supply integrity in mind. Consumers connected to piped natural gas networks are now required to surrender domestic LPG connections, preventing duplicate entitlements and ensuring that subsidised household LPG reaches only genuine beneficiaries. Similarly, rationalisation of refill booking intervals during periods of supply stress helped discourage panic booking while maintaining equitable distribution across urban and rural consumers alike. Technology, however,

is only as effective as the enforcement framework that supports it. India’s petroleum supply chain today operates within a multi-layered regulatory structure involving Oil Marketing Companies, State Civil Supplies Departments, Legal Metrology authorities, the Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation (PESO), district administrations and law enforcement agencies. Retail outlets undergo routine and surprise inspections where fuel quality, quantity, dispensing accuracy and inventory reconciliation are verified. Mobile testing laboratories conduct random sampling of petrol and diesel to detect adulteration, while calibrated dispensing equipment and statutory verification by Legal Metrology authorities protect consumers against short delivery. Importantly, enforcement has become increasingly intelligence-led rather than complaint-driven. Digital transaction records, inventory movement, transport tracking and consumption analytics now enable authorities to identify anomalies before they escalate into large-scale diversion. Instead of reacting to black marketing after shortages emerge, surveillance systems increasingly seek to prevent those shortages from materialising in the first place. Consumers themselves have also become part of the integrity framework. Unified grievance platforms, online complaint mechanisms and digital service portals have improved transparency by allowing consumers to report irregularities directly. This additional layer of public oversight strengthens accountability across the distribution network and reinforces trust in the system. Perhaps the most significant achievement is that supply chain integrity has

become invisible to the ordinary citizen-and that is precisely how it should be. When consumers visit a fuel station, they expect accurate quantity, genuine quality and uninterrupted availability. When an LPG refill is booked, they expect timely delivery without questioning whether the cylinder has been diverted elsewhere. These expectations are fulfilled not by chance but through thousands of daily operational decisions, digital checkpoints and enforcement actions taking place quietly across the country. Supply chain resilience is often discussed in terms of ports, pipelines, refineries and inventories. Those remain essential. But resilience also depends on ensuring that products do not disappear after entering the distribution network. A resilient supply chain is one where every legitimate consumer receives uninterrupted service, every transaction can be traced, every anomaly can be investigated and every violation carries meaningful consequences. India’s energy sector is increasingly demonstrating that supply chain integrity is not built solely through larger infrastructure, but through smarter governance. Technology provides visibility. Digital transformation creates traceability. Enforcement establishes credibility. Together, they ensure that fuel reaches citizens-not black markets. That may ultimately be the most important measure of an energy system. Not simply that it can produce, import or distribute at scale, but that it can do so fairly, transparently and with the confidence that every litre and every cylinder reaches exactly where it is intended to go.

Rajkumar Dubey is the ex-Director (HR) of Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited and ex-Chairman of Indraprastha Gas Limited

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | JULY 1, 2026

Finance Ministry panel clears ₹1.25 lakh cr outlay for ISM 2.0

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The expenditure department under the Finance Ministry has cleared a Budget proposal entailing an allocation of ₹1.25 lakh crore for India Semiconductor Mission 2.0, as the country looks to advance global chip-making ambitions and cement its position as a semiconductor destination for the world, according to sources. The approval is significant as it is higher than the outlay of ₹76,000 crore earmarked for ISM 1.0. Sources said that the Expenditure Finance Committee has greenlit the ₹1.25 lakh crore outlay for ISM 2.0, and that the same will be placed before the Cabinet. The Budget, in February, had sought to give a big boost to the country’s manufacturing

pro prowess announcing, among various measures, the second edition of India Semiconductor Mission with a broad objective to promote chip manufacturing ecosystem in the country covering equipment, materials, indigenous designs and other related components. The government has maintained that India Semiconductor Mission

2.0 - announced in the Union Budget 2026-27 - signals India’s deep commitment to chip manufacturing, with a focus on semiconductor equipment, materials, indigenous intellectual property and resilient supply chains. Union Minister for Electronics and IT Ashwini Vaishnaw had earlier said that the India Semiconductor

Mission 2.0 will prioritise indigenous chip design, production, attracting ecosystem partners and development of talent. As many as 12 semiconductor manufacturing projects have been approved with an investment pipeline of about ₹1.64 lakh crore under the India Semiconductor Mission, including one semiconductor fabrication unit, two compound semiconductor fabrication units and nine packaging units. On the design side, 24 projects are being supported under the Design Linked Incentive Scheme, 105 companies have been assisted with advanced chip design tools and 23 design ‘tapeouts’ have been completed at various foundries, including at advanced nodes, reflecting India’s growing depth in semiconductor design.

Govt extends customs duty waiver on import of key petrochemical products till July 15

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The government on Tuesday extended nil customs duty on import of critical petrochemical products by 15 days till July 15 to ensure continuity of supply stability amid the West Asia crisis. The full customs duty waiver on about 40 critical petrochemical products provided on April 2 was a “temporary and targeted relief”, and was set to lapse on June 30. In a notification on Tuesday, the Finance Ministry extended the

customs duty exemption to July 15. The import duty exemption was intended to benefit sectors dependent on petrochemical feedstock and intermediates, such as plastics, packaging, textiles, pharmaceuticals, chemicals, automotive components and other manufacturing segments.

On April 2, the Finance Ministry had said that in light of the ongoing conflict in West Asia and the consequent disruptions in global supply chains, the government has decided to provide full customs duty exemption on critical petrochemical products till June 30. This measure was aimed to ensure the continued availability of critical petrochemical inputs for the domestic industry, reduce cost pressures on downstream sectors, and safeguard supply stability in the country, the ministry had said.

This will also provide relief to consumers of final products, it added. The goods on which the customs duty has been exempted include Methanol, Anhydrous ammonia, Toluene, Styrene, Dichloromethane (methylene chloride), Vinyl chloride monomer, Polybutadiene, Styrene butadiene and Unsaturated polyester resins. Disruption in shipping routes amid the West Asia war has raised concerns over imports of fertiliser, crude oil and natural gas. India is a major importer of fertiliser and petroleum.

India remains fastest-growing economy; reforms key to momentum: HUL Chairman

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India remains the world’s fastest-growing major economy despite a challenging global environment, and sustaining high growth will require continued reforms, investments and execution, HUL Chairman Nitin Paranjpe said on Tuesday. Addressing shareholders at the 93rd AGM, India has demonstrated “structural resilience” at a time when global economies are grappling with geopolitical conflicts, climate volatility, tightening financial conditions and shifting consumer behaviour. “While growth expectations have moderated, India continues to be the fastest-

growing major economy,” he said. India’s long-term growth prospects are supported by “three drivers”, which are favourable demographics, digital public infrastructure and a proactive policy environment. According to Paranjpe, India’s young population can

become a force multiplier for consumption, productivity and innovation, while the country’s digital public infrastructure has created a unique foundation for commerce, credit and financial inclusion at scale. He also credited policy initiatives for creating a growth-oriented environment for businesses and consumers. “This is infrastructure that no other large company or economy has built at this scale, and it creates the rails on which the next generation of commerce, credit and inclusion will run,” he said. Over the recent reforms, Paranjpe said the Goods and Services Tax (GST) has helped spur a broad-based consumption revival.

US-Iran thaw to provide tailwinds for growth: RBI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank on Tuesday said the interim peace deal between Iran and the US can provide tailwinds to Indian economic growth. In its bi-annual financial stability report released on Tuesday, the central bank also said that the growth in gold imports has decelerated “substantially” in May 2026 over April. It, however, flagged that fiscal deficit can come under pressure because of the higher prices of energy and other commodities, their limited pass through to pump prices, excise duty cuts and higher outgo on

subsidies. “... the interim peace deal has laid the foundation for cessation of this conflict and normalisation of supply chains, which could provide tailwinds to growth,” the report said. The country entered the recent bout of global turbu-

lence triggered by the West Asia conflict with stronger macroeconomic fundamentals, it said, conceding that while India’s resilience provides an important buffer, some impact is inevitable given the country’s substantial dependence on imported energy. The RBI said most of the high-frequency indicators for April-May 2026 point to continued resilience in economic activity which suggests that growth has remained “firm” in Q1FY27. “Nevertheless, elevated oil and other commodity prices and weaker global growth could adversely affect India’s domestic growth in 2026-27,” it said.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty declined on Tuesday due to selling in IT, oil & gas and select banking shares amid uncertainty over the next round of US-Iran negotiations in Doha. The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 249.70 points, or 0.33 per cent, to settle at 76,478.67, paring its opening gains. During the day, it fell by 398.98 points, or 0.51 per cent, to a low of 76,329.39. The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 80.50 points, or 0.34 per cent, to end at 23,865.75. The delayed onset and sluggish progress of the southwest monsoon, fresh foreign fund outflows and decline in blue-chip IT stocks weighed on market sentiment, analysts said. Among Sensex shares, Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, HCL Tech, Tech Mahindra, ITC and Hindustan Unilever were the major laggards. Maruti, Titan, Bajaj Finance and Eternal were among the gainers. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded

equities worth ₹1,350.10 crore on Monday, according to exchange data. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, rose by 0.23 per cent to \$73.32 per barrel. “The domestic market remained in a consolidation phase, trading within a narrow range and exhibiting a mixed trend. Although geopolitical concerns have eased, the fragile nature of the US-Iran peace deal continues to weigh on sentiment, preventing any meaningful directional move,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said. Sectoral performance was mixed but tilted to the downside, with IT emerging as the primary drag, he said. “On the domestic front, the current monsoon trend – pointing to the worst deficit in a decade – raises concerns about agricultural output and allied sectors, further impacting sentiment amid expectations of weak Q1FY27 earnings,” Nair added. Broader markets also advanced as the BSE SmallCap Select index went up by 0.59 per cent MidCap Select index rose by 0.46 per cent.

PROSPECT



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman receives a dividend cheque of ₹1,553 crore for FY 2025-26 from Rajneesh Karnatak, Managing Director & CEO, Bank of India.

Govt approves proposal to amend KVIC Act

The Government has approved a proposal to amend the Khadi and Village Industries Commission (KVIC) Act, 1956, with the objective of modernising the legal framework governing the Khadi and Village Industries (KVI) sector, the MSME Ministry said on Tuesday. The proposed amendments aim to align the Act with contemporary economic and rural development priorities, strengthen institutional governance, promote inclusivity, formalise rural enterprises, and enhance the competitiveness of village industries in domestic and global markets. They seek to bring the KVIC Act in line with current policy frameworks and support the Government's vision of inclusive and sustainable rural economic development.

(PNS)

Assam Rifles assists in recovery of civil vehicle near Zochachhua, Mizoram



Assam Rifles promptly responded to a civil vehicle accident in which a civilian vehicle had fallen off the road approximately 300 metres short of Zochachhua Bridge towards Zorinpui in Lawngtlai District, Mizoram. Demonstrating swift coordination and commitment towards public assistance, a recovery operation was immediately initiated at the site. A joint recovery effort involving one JCB from the Assam Rifles and one from SIB was launched to retrieve the vehicle from the difficult terrain. Troops on ground extended all possible assistance and coordinated efforts to ensure the safe and timely conduct of the recovery operation. The prompt response reflects Assam Rifles' continued commitment towards humanitarian assistance and support to local communities in remote border areas, reaffirming its role as the Sentinels of the North East.

(PNS)

Security forces seize major cache of arms in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

During the period of June 21 to June 27, Indian Army and Assam Rifles formations under Spear Corps, in close coordination with Manipur Police and Central Security Forces, conducted a series of intelligence-based joint operations across Kangpokpi, Imphal West, Imphal East, Thoubal and Kakching districts.

The operations led to the apprehension of six cadres belonging to various proscribed outfits and the recovery of arms, ammunition, explosives and other warlike stores.

On June 24 and June 26, Assam Rifles, in joint operations with Manipur Police



and a CRPF Battalion, unearthed a major cache of arms, ammunition, and warlike stores from the general areas of Loiching Ridge, Maohing, and North Changoubung in Kangpokpi District. The successful seizures comprised two

rifles, one carbine machine gun, one rifle, 42 country-made rifles, multiple pistols, improvised mortars, pumpis, and one under-barrel grenade launcher.

The search columns also recovered a significant quantity of ammunition, explo-

sives, and equipment, including multiple grenades, over 250 rounds of ammunition, and communication equipment. During the same operational window, Assam Rifles and Manipur Police launched massive intelligence-led joint operations across Imphal West, Imphal East, Thoubal, and Kakching districts.

The crackdown resulted in the intercept and apprehension of six active cadres from the proscribed outfits SOREPA, KCP(N), KYKL, and RPF(PLA), including a self-styled Captain. Security forces also executed a major weapon recovery during these targeted operations, seizing one pistol, 97 rounds of mixed ammunition, gunpowder, and an unregistered vehicle.

Team IndianOil spreads smiles at Saikripa NGO



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

IndianOil's Refineries Division continued its commitment towards inclusive community engagement through its "Smiles We Spread" initiative with a heartwarming visit to Saikripa NGO in Noida, which has been working for the welfare of orphaned, abandoned and underprivileged children since 1988.

"Smiles We Spread" is IndianOil's people-centric social outreach initiative that reflects the corporation's core value of care. It encourages IOCIans to go beyond their workplaces and connect with communities through meaningful acts of service, compassion and inclusion.

The visit was led by Anurag Sachdev, ED (M&C, Shipping),

RHQ, accompanied by senior officials from CSR, Contracts and Shipping. The interaction brought moments of joy, encouragement and shared warmth as children at Saikripa presented a lively cultural programme and shared their dreams and aspirations.

Speaking on the occasion, Sachdev encouraged the children to dream big and pursue their aspirations with sincerity and discipline. He also encouraged them to actively pursue hobbies such as music, art and dance, which can help build confidence and shape their future.

The visiting officials interacted warmly with the children, sharing conversations, motivation and encouragement. Goodies were also distributed among the children, adding to the cheer and excitement of the occasion.

Illness to Wellness Foundation celebrates National Doctors Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As India observed National Doctors Day, the Illness to Wellness Foundation organised a special programme that brought together a distinguished gathering of healthcare leaders, senior doctors and eminent members of the medical fraternity. The event recognised the invaluable contribution of doctors in safeguarding public health and reaffirmed the importance of preventive healthcare in reducing India's growing disease burden.

The Foundation expressed its heartfelt gratitude to these silent heroes whose unwavering commitment to humanity continues to inspire hope and build a healthier, stronger and more resilient nation. The programme was also attended by diplomats from countries such as Sri Lanka, New Zealand, Ireland, and Jordan, reflecting the growing global interest in India's preventive healthcare initiatives. The event also brought together policymakers, industry leaders, academicians, researchers and wellness



The Illness to Wellness Annual Report 2025-26 was unveiled by (L-R) Prof Nirmal Kumar Ganguly, former Director General, ICMR and Member, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation (IWF); Prashant Tewari, CMD, Opinion Express and Editorial Member, *The Pioneer*; Kiran Chopra, Director, Punjab Kesari; Rajesh Bhushan, former Secretary, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Government of India, Chairperson, Governing Council, IWF and Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, IWF.

Pioneer Photo

experts from across the country, fostering a meaningful dialogue on strengthening preventive healthcare and improving public health outcomes.

During the occasion, the Illness to Wellness Annual Report 2025-26 was also unveiled. The report was released by Rajesh Bhushan, Former Secretary, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Government of India, and Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation; Prof. Nirmal Kumar Ganguly, Former Director General, Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and Member, Governing Council, Illness to

Wellness Foundation; Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation; Prashant Tewari, CMD, Opinion Express and Editorial Member, *The Pioneer* amongst other dignitaries.

The Annual Report 2025-26 highlights the Foundation's year-long efforts to advance preventive healthcare through health awareness campaigns, community outreach programmes, school health initiatives, workplace wellness interventions and preventive health screening drives across the country.

On the occasion, Bhushan said India has made significant strides in expanding

access to healthcare and strengthening its treatment infrastructure. The next phase of our healthcare journey must focus equally on prevention, he added.

In his speech, Rajput said as healthcare evolves, the role of doctors continues to expand—from treating illness to advancing wellness, from responding to disease to encouraging prevention.

Prof. (Dr.) G. C. Khilnani, Chairman, PSRI Institute of Pulmonary; and Dr Yash Gulati, Padma Shri, Senior Consultant Orthopaedic and Joint Replacement Surgeon, Apollo Hospitals, New Delhi, were also present on the occasion.

Central Bank of India inaugurates its IFSC Banking Unit at GIFT City

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

The Central Bank of India has inaugurated its IFSC Banking Unit (IBU) at the Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (GIFT City), Gandhinagar, Gujarat. The unit was inaugurated by Kalyan Kumar, MD & CEO, marking a significant milestone in the bank's journey towards building a global banking presence.

The IBU will operate as the bank's offshore banking arm, transacting in foreign currency and offering a comprehensive suite of



international banking services, viz., cross-border banking solutions, foreign currency deposits, investment banking services and foreign currency loan solutions, alongside trade finance, treasury and correspondent banking capabilities to corporates, institutions and eligible customers across the globe.

Speaking on the occa-

sion, the MD&CEO reaffirmed the bank's commitment to supporting India's growing integration with global financial markets and to serving the international aspirations of the bank's existing and prospective customers, thereby aligning with the national vision of developing GIFT City as a leading global financial hub.

Jeevdaya Year campaign to be launched

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A resolve to make Delhi a City of Jeevdaya, the 'Jeevdaya Year' campaign will be launched with the commencement of Chaturmas. Throughout the year, a series of initiatives dedicated to compassion for all living beings will be undertaken, including animal welfare, cow protection and care, *Abhaydaan* (granting protection to living beings), bird and wildlife conservation, veterinary assistance, environmental protection, tree plantation, and various public awareness and community service programmes.

The campaign aims to develop Delhi as a "City of Compassion (Jeevdaya Nagan)" while strengthening the values of compassion and non-violence. Under the auspices of the Delhi Gujarati

Shwetambar Murtipujak Jain Sangh (Regd.), the Grand Chaturmas Praves Mahotsav of the revered disciple group of Pujya Adhyatmayogi Acharyadev Shrimad Vijay Kalapur Surishwar Ji Maharaj will be celebrated with great devotion and enthusiasm on Sunday, July 12.

The Chaturmas will be held at Shri Delhi Gujarati Kunthunath Trust (Regd.), Zone H-4/5, Shri Atma Vallabh Vidya Mandir (Jain Pathshala), Shri Kalyan Parshvanath Jain Mandir Marg, Parwana Road, Pitampura, Delhi.

In the Indian spiritual tradition, Chaturmas is regarded as a sacred period dedicated to self-realisation, penance, discipline, scriptural study, non-violence, and compassion for all living beings. During this auspicious period, the revered Jain monks will inspire devo-

tees to embrace righteousness, compassion, self-discipline, and moral values.

Pujya Munishri Tirthtarak Vijayji Maharaj Saheb, through his inspiring discourses and guidance based on a rare 1,200-year-old astrological tradition, will provide spiritual counsel on family, marital, business, and personal life challenges.

Many devotees have shared that they experienced positive transformation and meaningful guidance through his blessings and teachings. On July 12, the programme will commence with Navkarsi at 6:30 am, followed by a Grand Procession (Shobha Yatra) from Pushpanjali Enclave, Pitampura, at 7:45 am, Dharma Sabha and auspicious discourses by the revered Gurudev at 9:00 AM, and conclude with Sangh Swami Vatsalya at 11:45 am.

Flytxt launches AI research centre in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Flytxt launched a new AI research centre in Delhi, aiming to advance India's role in the global artificial intelligence race. The centre will develop next-generation AI systems capable of analysing data, making decisions, taking autonomous actions, and learning continuously. It was inaugurated by NITI Aayog member Prof Abhay Karandikar. Dr Vinod Vasudevan said the move marks a shift from predictive AI to "trusted AI co-workers" that deliver measurable business outcomes. "Our new AI research centre represents a significant investment in building the next generation of enterprise AI from India for the world," he said.



Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar

Advertisement No. 5/2026

Online applications are invited for the Non-Teaching posts in the University. Online registration of application for the post will start w.e.f. 01.07.2026 and end on 10.07.2026. Last Date for submitting Hard Copy of the Online submitted application is 17.07.2026. For further details visit Website: <http://www.digital.gndu.ac.in>. Amritsar 30.06.2026

REGISTRAR

2426/12/2026-27/12824

Dated CHD :- 30/06/2026

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (30.6.26)

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

WEDNESDAY | JULY 1, 2026

ACROSS

DOWN

ACROSS

DOWN

BRIEFLY

Lebanon’s Brazil fans celebrate win against Japan



In the northern Lebanese town of Zgharta, Brazilian flags hung from balconies and stone alleyways as families prepared for Brazil’s Round of 32 FIFA World Cup match against Japan. Children wearing yellow jerseys played soccer in the streets, while cafes and public squares filled with supporters draped in green and yellow, reflecting a passion for Brazil that stretches across Lebanon. The connection between the two countries runs deep. Government estimates say between 7 million and 10 million Brazilians have Lebanese ancestry, more than Lebanon’s population of about 6 million.

Those family and cultural ties, shaped by over a century of migration, have helped make Brazil one of the most widely supported national soccer teams across Lebanon. For many Lebanese fans, Brazil’s attacking style of play, flair and history of producing legendary players have also inspired generations of supporters, passing that passion from parents to their children. As kickoff approached, drums echoed through the streets and fans gathered around screens to cheer every attack. “Today we had to work a bit for the win, but I was sure we were going to win,” said Brazil supporter Bagus Fadlallah. “We’re Brazil, and we’ll show everyone what Brazil is really made of.” After Brazil’s victory, supporters across Lebanon took to the streets, waving Brazilian flags, beating drums and celebrating a team many Lebanese have supported for generations. (AP)

Son Heung-min hurt by South Korea’s World Cup exit



South Korea captain Son Heung-min has apologised for the team’s group-stage exit at the World Cup, saying he is “indescribably hurt” and eager to “win the hearts” of the nation once again. In a long post on Instagram on Monday night, Son – a soccer superstar in South Korea and a big name in Major League Soccer with Los Angeles FC – said he understood the disappointment of the team’s fans after its performances in the tournament that have drawn harsh criticism from the country’s president and led to the resignation of coach Hong Myung-bo. “I don’t dare to convey the disappointment and hurt of the fans with a single word sorry,” Son wrote, “so even saying those words feels insufficient. “The child’s dream stage’ that I always talked about has collapsed,” he added. “I’m indescribably stuck and hurt. To be honest, it’s still not easy to accept this reality.”

South Korea won its opening match against Czech Republic, then lost its next two Group A matches – to Mexico and South Africa. The team failed to advance as one of the third-place group finishers. Son, who started on the bench for the group closer against South Africa, didn’t score a goal at the World Cup and said he felt a personal responsibility that “I couldn’t repay the time, heart, and constant support and love” that the fans gave. (AP)

Norway-Ivory Coast winner to play Brazil in Round of 16

STEPHEN HAWKINS
■ Arlington (USA)

Norway’s Sander Berge is very aware of what many consider the greatest win in his country’s soccer history, though it happened only months after the 28-year-old midfielder was born.

Memories of that World Cup upset of Brazil are now being stirred up for Norway because of the success of its current World Cup squad – and the possibility of playing the five-time champion again. The rested Norwegians are preparing to play Ivory Coast on Tuesday at the home of the NFL’s



Dallas Cowboys. It will be their first knockout game in a World Cup since 1998, the year they advanced out of the group stage only after an incredible comeback in the closing minutes for a 2-1 victory against the then-reigning champion.

“I feel like I’ve lived

through a translator. “We should work toward that goal, which is what we’ve been doing.”

Four years ago, Japan led early but eventually fell to Croatia on penalty kicks in the round of 16. The Samurai Blue suffered a similar fate in the same round in 2018 when they led Belgium 2-0 in the second half but lost 3-2 on a stoppage time goal.

“I don’t think history would be gentle to us,” Moriyasu said. “But if we are to overcome today maybe we will see a time where history will change.” Things looked good early for Japan on Monday. Kaishu Sano put his team ahead in the 29th minute, but Casemiro equalized on a header in the 56th and

Paraguay upsets Germany on penalty kicks

KYLE HIGHTOWER
■ Foxborough

Jose Canale scored on the first sudden death penalty kick, Orlando Gill made two key saves in the shootout, and Paraguay beat Germany 4-3 on penalties Monday to earn the biggest upset of the 2026 World Cup so far.

The round of 32 match ended 1-1 after extra time. Paraguay took the lead when Julio Enciso scored on a header late in the first half, but Kai Havertz equalized in the 52nd minute for four-time champion Germany.

“We had to analyse every player, every detail. Thanks to that I was able to only miss two penalties,” Gill said after-

ward. “This is for all the people of Paraguay.”

Paraguay, ranked 34th by FIFA, is the deepest betting long shot to win a World Cup match and did it against 12th-ranked Germany.

The Paraguayans will next face the winner of Tuesday’s match between France and Sweden in the round of 16 on Saturday in Philadelphia. A win in that match would land them back in Foxborough for a quarterfinal match on July 9.

“I think we deserved one more game and to be honest considering everything that was said, everything we went through,” Canale said. “What I wan to highlight from our team is how united we are. ...



Today was a game we really needed to show our true colors.” Germany had won six of seven penalty shootouts in

major tournaments, including six straight since losing to Czechoslovakia in the 1976 European Championship

Soccer fans clash with police at The Hague

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ The Hague

Soccer fans clashed with police in The Hague and celebrated in Casablanca after Morocco sent the Netherlands to its earliest World Cup exit, eliminating the Dutch on penalties on Monday night.

The Netherlands has a sizable Moroccan community and fans of the Morocco soccer team were in a festive mood after the win, though sporadic clashes also erupted. Police in The Hague said “heavy fireworks were set off” in the Schilderswijk district, and that police officers were pelted with fireworks and stones. Riot



squads charged the crowd and used a water cannon to break up the gathering.

“A few individuals have been arrested for committing open violence,” police said. As the penalty shootout

spot kick, sending his team into the Round of 16.

The celebrations soon poured into the streets, with flares and fireworks cracking overhead, horns blaring and engines revving as fans celebrated deep into the night.

Despite the late kickoff and the workday ahead, dozens of jubilant fans gathered on a main boulevard in Casablanca around 5 a.m. local time, dancing in the streets, waving Moroccan flags and chanting, “Canada, we’re coming for you.”

Morocco moved on to face co-host Canada in the next round on Saturday. The Atlas Lions previously beat Canada 2-1 in the group stage of the 2022 World Cup.

Saibari’s goal sends Morocco past the Netherlands

ETHAN WILCOX
■ Guadalupe (Mexico)

Ismael Saibari scored the decisive goal in a penalty shootout, and Morocco sent the Netherlands to its earliest World Cup exit, eliminating the Dutch 3-2 after a 1-1 draw.

With the shootout tied at 2-all after four rounds on Monday night, Morocco goalkeeper Yassine Bounou made a strong save of Crysenicio Summerville’s attempt, batting it away with his left hand. Saibari then sent the winner into the low left corner as goalkeeper Bart Verbruggen went the other direction. The midfielder tore off his shirt and screamed with joy as he was mobbed by teammates.

Earlier in the shootout with Morocco trailing 1-0, Verbruggen appeared to

have stopped an attempt by Soufiane Rahimi, but the goalkeeper couldn’t secure the ball and deflected it over the line with the back of his leg. “We know when we do everything on the pitch, it’s God that gives something back to us as well,” Morocco head coach Mohamed Ouahbi said.

“We give all the energy that we have on the field. Rahimi’s goal could have not been a goal, but it went in thankfully.”

The Netherlands had reached at least the Round of 16 in 11 previous World Cups, including a quarterfinal appearance four years ago in Qatar, when Morocco made a breakthrough run to become the first team from Africa to reach the semifinals. In this year’s expanded tournament, 32 teams



reached its climax, the tense silence inside a coffee shop popular with fans in Casablanca, Morocco’s largest city, gave way to a deafening roar when Ismael Saibari buried the decisive

the game on Monday. The Netherlands instead focused on counterattacking.

“I think Morocco has gained everybody’s respect now,” said Ouahbi, who took over as head coach in March.

“I saw [the Netherlands’ style of play] as a form of respect.” (AP)

Paraguay goalkeeper Orlando Gill bests German idol

JIMMY GOLEN
■ Foxborough (USA)

Orlando Gill knew Paraguay was a big underdog against Germany in their World Cup knockout-round opener.

Heck, he was even a little starstruck himself. But the 26-year-old goalkeeper, appearing in his first World Cup, bested German great Manuel Neuer in a penalty shootout to help La Albirroja send the four-time World Cup champions home.

“It showed that you shouldn’t speak too soon,” Gill said after helping the 5-to-1 underdogs advance to the Round of 16. “This proves that Paraguay is capable of achieving great things. The opportunity was bound to

come sooner or later.” A 6-foot-6 monolith who plays for Argentine club San Lorenzo, Gill helped Paraguay reach the knockout round with clean sheets in a 1-0 group victory over Turkey and a 0-0 draw with Australia.

But Gill, who also gave up four goals to the United States in the group stage, would need to be even better against the powerful Germans, who possessed the ball more than twice as long as Paraguay and attempted 21 shots on goal to Paraguay’s seven. “It was like a horror movie. Germans were popping up everywhere,” Gill said. “Even I still can’t believe it.” And backing them up was Neuer, who was playing in his fifth World Cup, having led



Germany to the 2014 championship – finishing third in the Ballon d’Or balloting that year behind Cristiano Ronaldo and Lionel Messi – and taken Bayern Munich to two Champions League titles and 13 Bundesliga championships. “Neuer is a world-

class goalkeeper,” Gill said. “I shared a shootout with him, and he managed to save a penalty, too. I have nothing but respect for an idol like him.” Gill made one mistake in regulation, allowing Kai Havertz’s equalizer in the 54th minute. Another



A standing ovation for Cody Gakpo amid personal grief

MAYA KOLUDER-RAMIREZ
■ Guadalupe (Mexico)

After scoring in the 72nd minute, Cody Gakpo immediately sank to his knees.

As his teammates immediately rushed toward him in celebration, the 27-year-old forward covered his face while weeping, later pointing to the sky and appearing to pray.

While this marked Gakpo’s third goal of the World Cup, this goal in the Round of 32 loss to Morocco on Monday was especially emotional for him.

On Saturday, Gakpo and his partner, model Noa van

der Bij, announced the death of their unborn child.

Despite the grief, Gakpo was determined to continue on in the tournament.

“I think he dealt with it very well,” Netherlands head coach Ronald Koeman had

The Germans were eliminated from the group stage at the last two World Cup tournaments. “We had very big plans for this World Cup. It’s very difficult to disappoint again,” Havertz said. “It was difficult to create chances and keep the pace.”

Paraguay broke the early stalemate in the 42nd minute Monday with some perfect ball movement to setup Enciso. Miguel Almiron split Germany’s Aleksandar Pavlovic and Nathaniel Brown with a left-footed pass to Matias Galarza. Galarza sent a cross to Enciso, who was unmarked by Germany’s defenders and easily headed it past goalkeeper Manuel Neuer. (AP)

US trying to avoid another quick exit from WC knockout rounds



JIM VERTUNO ■ New York

Getting to the knockout rounds of the World Cup is nothing new for the United States. But that’s usually where the American make a quick exit. Wednesday’s match against Bosnia-Herzegovina in Santa Clara, California, marks the eighth time the U.S. has played in an elimination round in 12 World Cups. But only once, in 2002, have the Americans a won a match in the knockout rounds.

Because this year’s tournament was expanded to 48 teams, the first knockout round includes 32, creating an extra round of elimination play. Here’s a look at the short and mostly unsuccessful US record once the World Cup reaches the win-or-go-home stage.

Uruguay, 1930: SemifinalsThe first World Cup was played with 13 teams and the US advanced straight to the semifinals as winner of its group. That’s where the Americans’ tournament ended with a 6-1 loss to Argentina.

Italy, 1934: One and done – The second edition of the World Cup was the only tournament that did not use

groups for the early matches. Instead, all 16 teams played a straight knockout format. The U.S. was eliminated with a 7-1 loss to host and eventual champion Italy.

US, 1994: Round of 16 – The US didn’t qualify for the World Cup from 1954 through 1986, was eliminated in the group stage in 1990 and then got an automatic bid as the host nation in ’94. A 1-1 tie with Switzerland and shocking 2-1 victory over Colombia in the Rose Bowl in the group stage earned the Americans a match against Brazil in the knockout round. Brazil was down to 10 men after a first-half red card: Leonardo threw an elbow that fractured American midfielder Tab Ramos’ skull. The Brazilians still controlled the match and won 1-0 on the way to their fourth World Cup title.

South Korea-Japan, 2002: Quarterfinals – The best US showing in the modern era of the tournament. An upset of European heavyweight Portugal and a draw with co-host South Korea sent the Americans to the knockout round against regional rival Mexico. Goals from Brian McBride and Landon Donovan led to a 2-0 victory. (AP)

Japan faces heartbreak as Brazil scores in injury time

KRISTIE RIEKEN ■ Houston

The heartbreak was all too familiar for Japan at the World Cup. The country’s national team hung in until the very end Monday but was eliminated from the tournament - the third straight time Japan has had the lead in the knockout round and lost. This year, it was to five-time champion Brazil 2-1 on a late goal in injury time.

After four previous losses in such matches at World Cups, Japan is still searching for its first knockout victory.

“We were not able to achieve our goal this time but then we can aim for the next World Cup or maybe even one after that,” Japan coach Hajime Moriyasu said

through a translator. “We should work toward that goal, which is what we’ve been doing.”

Four years ago, Japan led early but eventually fell to Croatia on penalty kicks in the round of 16. The Samurai Blue suffered a similar fate in the same round in 2018 when they led Belgium 2-0 in the second half but lost 3-2 on a stoppage time goal.

“I don’t think history would be gentle to us,” Moriyasu said. “But if we are to overcome today maybe we will see a time where history will change.” Things looked good early for Japan on Monday. Kaishu Sano put his team ahead in the 29th minute, but Casemiro equalized on a header in the 56th and



Gabriel Martinelli scored the winning goal late in injury time. Japan goalkeeper Zion Suzuki finished with four saves. He declined to answer questions in English after the

tough loss despite a strong showing against one of the best teams in the world. Japan has only beaten Brazil once in 15 matches, with two games ending in draws. The

lone victory came in a friendly in October.

“The gap between us is closing now,” Moriyasu said. “Brazil is a top-tier team and we’re definitely approaching that level.” Then he mentioned the loss in Qatar four years ago before adding: “We have to up our game.”

Moriyasu said he told the players after the match they should remember the frustration they felt in that moment and use it to help them grow. Then he took the blame for the loss. “To win the title was our dream and our goal and we couldn’t achieve that,” he said. “As a head coach I told them that I was really sorry that I was not good enough to lead them to that level to achieve that goal.” (AP)

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's debut in focus against England

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chester-Le-Street (UK)

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's eagerly-awaited debut and the thoroughly exposed batting frailties on challenging wickets dominate the discourse on India as they take on England in a five-match T20 International series starting here on Wednesday.

India's assistant coach Ryan ten Doeschate has said that Sooryavanshi will have to "go through the process and bide his time" like any other cricketer to get a place in the eleven. At the same time, he had no hesitation in declaring that the 15-year-old swashbuckler seems ready

for the grind. But it remains to be seen whether the management will hold firm on its resolve that Sooryavanshi must follow the process amid the growing clamour to blood the explosive hitter.

Ten Doeschate was candid enough to admit that there is disbelief in the camp after being whitewashed 0-2 by Ireland last week and it could well become the trigger for drastic action.

The twin failure of Sanju Samson against Ireland offers them a perfect excuse to bench the opener and pair Sooryavanshi with Abhishek Sharma, who could be saved by that 20-ball 49 in the first T20I at Belfast. It could end up being the move that gives the

visitors a strong start against England in the five-match series. Ishan Kishan also did not cover himself in glory during the two-match series against Ireland and was dismissed for 1, 12.

So, the management can bench any of those two to accommodate Sooryavanshi but they will ponder the possible effect such a move can have on the morale of the omitted batter.

If one takes the case of Samson, he had a wonderful run in the back-end of the T20 World Cup earlier this year and also scored two centuries for Chennai Super Kings in the IPL.

However, the think tank led by chairman of selectors



Ajit Agarkar and head coach Gautam Gambhir is not averse to taking some harsh calls, and those in doubt can re-read the Suryakumar Yadav story. They also

handed debuts to Suryansh Shedge and Prince Yadav against Ireland, leaving Sooryavanshi waiting for his national cap.

Sooryavanshi is no quick

fix: But then the inclusion of Sooryavanshi alone should not be viewed as a quick fix to India's batting travails, which have many contours.

None of the Indian batters looked comfortable in conditions at Belfast that offered considerable assistance to pacers. They looked like fishes out of the pond once routes to aggressive batting were blocked by conditions and spot-on Irish bowlers.

In the second T20I, Tilak Varma appeared to have ace the situation with a measured fifty but his patience too ran out after playing the hanging-in-there kind of cricket for 46 balls.

That impatience was the facemark of several other

Indian batters too while chasing perfectly achievable targets like 183 and 155.

It required a slightly different mindset than batting on the flatbeds of IPL, but it was not coming through.

The Indian batters will need to adjust their conceptualisation and execution, as England will offer more or less the same conditions, and a better and more seasoned package of cricketers.

England have extreme pace in Jofra Archer, Josh Tongue, Saqib Mahmood, and Sonny Baker and wiliness in Aadil Rashid and Rehan Ahmed. That the average T20I score in the Riverside Ground is 138, with a highest of 195, hints at bowlers' dominance

across eight previous matches held here. So, if there is a delay from batters in adjusting to the rival attack and pitches here, then England can run away with the five-match series in the blink of an eye.

India's new T20I captain Shreyas Iyer would certainly not want a second series defeat in a row.

England's batting line-up too has some powerhouses in skipper Harry Brook, Jos Buttler, Jordan Cox, Jacob Bethell, Will Jacks, Phil Salt and Tom Banton.

In both the T20Is against Ireland, the Indian bowlers let the rival batters off the hook in the middle overs after taking an initial grip.

India retains Harmanpreet as captain for Asiad despite debacle in WC



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Harmanpreet Kaur was on Tuesday retained as captain of a largely predictable 15-member India squad for this year's Asian Games in Japan despite the side's earlier than expected exit from the ICC Women's T20 World Cup in England. The Asian Games is scheduled to be held in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan from September 19 to October 4. The Indian team's World Cup campaign ended on Sunday after a group stage loss to Australia.

The team will enter the Asian Games as defending champions, having won the gold medal at the event's previous edition in Hangzhou, China in 2023.

Both men's and women's cricket competition at the Asian Games is played in the T20 format.

Smriti Mandhana will continue to be Harmanpreet's deputy. The 37-year-old Harmanpreet, under whom India won the women's ODI World Cup last year, is facing criticism for the underwhelming show in England.

Wicketkeeper-batter

Yastika Bhatia is the only player to be dropped from the World Cup squad and in her place, G Kamalini has been drafted into the side.

All-rounder Shreyanka Patil, who was ruled out with an ankle injury in the middle of the World Cup, has been included in the squad but her availability will be subject to fitness clearance.

Harmanpreet will be supported in the batting lineup by Mandhana, Shafali Verma, Jemimah Rodrigues and Richa Ghosh, while the bowling responsibilities will largely be shouldered by Deepti Sharma, Renuka Singh, Shree Charani, Arundhati Reddy and Nandini Sharma.

During an erratic World Cup campaign, the Indians fell well short of expectations. They registered comfortable wins over relatively weaker Pakistan, Bangladesh and the Netherlands, but losses to South Africa and Australia put paid to their hopes. The team, despite the group stage exit, has qualified for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics as the highest-placed Asian team in the competition.

I tried to talk but he made his decision: McCullum on Stokes' retirement

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

England head coach Brendon McCullum revealed that he tried to persuade Ben Stokes to reconsider his decision to retire from international cricket, but said the captain had made up his mind by then. England lost the third and final Test against New Zealand at Trent Bridge by 160 on Monday, conceding the series 1-2. But Stokes announced his adieu on the fourth day of the match itself, shocking everyone around.

But McCullum said he "tried to talk him down."

"When he confirmed to me that he was going to retire, first I tried to talk him down (laughs) and... (it) became pretty obvious that

he had made his decision and he was at peace within," McCullum told Sky Sports.

"From that point of view, I guess your emotion then leads on to just a bit of sadness really because you have been on this journey together for four years and it's been a real thrill. I feel very privileged that I've been able to work intimately with Stokesy throughout that and consider him a friend, a good friend." McCullum lauded Stokes' contribution as captain and player, terming him "a leader of men."

"He is a leader of men, people follow him wherever he goes, whether that's on the field, whether that's in the dressing room, whether that's at the team hotel, people follow him because



he's a vivacious character and he's a big presence and he has conviction in his thoughts and his methods.

"In a game of cricket, which has so many variables and inconsistencies, that is one level of consistency that he brings...he truly believes in every situation. I think

deserved a fitting farewell from fans.

"I was quite strong in my opinions that I thought we should get it out there when we could because I think he's been a cricketer that's been able to transcend the sport into other aspects of society and the popularity throughout society," he said.

"I felt that the people that have supported Ben and this cricket team over the last 13 years since he's been involved, deserve the opportunity to say goodbye and to show their appreciation for how much he means to them with one final walk out there.

"Ben Stokes was very much his own type of leader which we all adored. There will need to be some work put in there but that's just the

nature of things. No one can play forever, no one can captain forever. We want to celebrate Stokes' time as our captain of his career and then in time we'll start to think about those decisions."

McCullum said he is now looking forward to taking English cricket forward with a new leader.

"My enthusiasm for English cricket and my commitment to English cricket has never wavered. I've got a firm belief in the direction that this team can go," he said.

"We still have an identity about us but we want to continue to furnish and harness that to get us in a direction that we are the team that we want to be and that we want to represent the people of this country," he added.

VALORANT team qualifies for Esports Nations Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Rlyadh

India have booked their place in the VALORANT main event at the Esports Nations Cup (ENC) 2026 following a resilient campaign in the Asia regional qualifiers.

The team emerged as one of only two sides from the region to qualify for the global esports competition, which will be held here from November 2 to 29.

VALORANT at ENC 2026 features 32 teams competing for a prize pool of USD 1.5 million. Sixteen countries and territories received direct invitations from the Esports Foundation through the ENC Rankings, which are based on performances in official Riot Games com-



petitions. The remaining 14 qualification spots were decided through regional online qualifiers across Asia, Eastern Europe, Western Europe, Middle East and North Africa, North America, South America, Sub-Saharan Africa, and Southeast Asia and Oceania. The Asia regional qualifier featured nine teams competing in a

double-elimination bracket. All matches before the Upper Bracket (UB) Final and Lower Bracket (LB) Final were played as best-of-one, while both bracket finals were contested as best-of-three series.

India's roster, led by in-game leader (IGL) Sagnik Roy (Hellfi), featured Abhirup Choudhury (Lightningfast),

Aman Yadav (Hoax), Venkatesh Sharma (Venky), and Daivik Chauhan (DC), with Norbu Tsering (KaramIL) and Shravana Sahoo (Techno) serving as substitutes.

Abhishek Bajaj (GodspeedXD) was as the team's coach, appointed by NODWIN Gaming, India's National Team Partner (NTP) for ENC 2026.

India began their campaign with a dominant 13-2 victory over Nepal in the UB quarterfinals before falling 5-13 to eventual qualifier Japan in the UB semifinals.

Facing elimination, the team responded with composure, defeating Pakistan 13-9 in the LB quarterfinals and overcoming Mongolia 13-10 to reach the LB Final.

Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa lead challenge at Zagreb Rapid, Blitz

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Zagreb (Croatia)

World champion D Gukesh might have taken a sabbatical from classical chess but his commitment to major events remains intact and he will be up against some of the world's best players in the Zagreb Rapid and Blitz Tournament beginning here on Wednesday.

The event is part of the Grand Chess Tour or GCT, which is the biggest platform to bring together top players. This will be the third event under the GCT brand this year with three more to come. This event will also feature Indian star R Praggnanandhaa, who is



fresh from his victory at the Norway Chess ahead of none other than world number one Magnus Carlsen.

The event will feature nine rounds of rapid and 18 rounds of blitz chess.

Hardik shifts to Bengaluru, makes COE training base

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

Star all-rounder Hardik Pandya has shifted base to Bengaluru with the aim of making the BCCI's Centre of Excellence (COE) his permanent training base for the remainder of his career, becoming the first prominent current India cricketer to do so.

The move is unique as India's centrally-contracted players normally visit the Centre of Excellence (COE) only for injury rehabilitation, fitness assessments or national camps.

Though Pandya is originally from Baroda in Gujarat, he has spent most of the last decade living in Mumbai and training primarily at his IPL



franchise Mumbai Indians' facility in Ghansoli.

The 32-year-old, who is currently recovering from a quadriceps injury and was ruled out of the ongoing white-ball tour of UK, has

spent considerable time at the COE over the last six months. "Hardik has already permanently shifted to Bengaluru. He has rented a property on the outskirts of the city, close to the COE. He will be the first Indian cricketer to make the COE his permanent training base for the remainder of his career," a BCCI source told PTI on conditions of anonymity.

"Hardik wanted to move out of Mumbai as commuting every day from his Lower Parel residence for training had become a problem. As a centrally-contracted cricketer, he has access to every facility at the COE, from injury management to skills training. "Hence, he took the decision to make the COE his per-

manent base whenever he is not on IPL, state or national duty," the source said.

It is understood that Hardik will also have his own physiotherapist and a personal strength and conditioning (S&C) coach to help him with his training routines outside the COE.

"It is like shifting his base to Bengaluru as long as he plays white-ball cricket for India, and he intends to play for at least another five to six years. "Even when he does skill work, such as batting against net bowlers hired by the COE, Hardik pays them from his own pocket," the source added. As for his comeback, it is understood that his rehabilitation is still ongoing. (PTI)

Serena Williams' return at Wimbledon is 'the ticket to have' for the grass-court Grand Slam

ANDREW DAMPF ■ London

Anticipation is building at Wimbledon for Serena Williams' first singles match in nearly four years.

The 44-year-old Williams is scheduled to play an opponent less than half her age, 20-year-old Maya Joint of Australia, in the third match Tuesday on Centre Court — the patch of grass where the American standout won seven of her 23 Grand Slam singles titles.

"I think everyone's feeling the same way: Cannot wait to be watching Serena back on Centre Court again," Sally Bolton, the chief executive of the All England Club, said



Monday. Wimbledon organisers took the unusual step of holding up an eighth and final wild card spot for Williams until she accepted

the invitation at almost the last possible moment the weekend before qualifying began. "We were all sitting there sort of quietly keeping

our fingers crossed that that's what would happen," Bolton said when asked by The Associated Press how anxious the club was while Williams pondered her decision. "She is such an icon of the sport and particularly here at the championship she's one of our most special champions," Bolton added. "So it really will be the ticket to have tomorrow when she walks back on Centre Court."

Whether it was related to Williams or not, the queue (line) of would-be-spectators camping out overnight for the daily batches of Wimbledon tickets on offer had reached 10,000 people by Monday morning. (AP)

Anmol to lead India junior hockey team in Belgium exposure tour

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Defender Anmol Ekka will lead a 22-member Indian Junior (U-21) men's hockey team at the upcoming exposure tour of Belgium, scheduled from July 5 to 18.

The tour will be the team's first assignment under coach Frederic Soye of France and will serve as a key preparatory phase ahead of the Junior Asia Cup later this year. The young Indian side will face some of Europe's strongest



hockey nations during the tour, playing two matches each against Austria and

Belgium, and one match each against Germany and the Netherlands. The exposure

tour is expected to provide valuable international match experience while helping the team test its combinations and playing style ahead of the continental tournament. The goalkeeping unit comprises Vivek Lakra and Kunal Tewatia, while Anmol leads the backline that also has Rohit Kullu, Chirag, Ravinder, Prasant Barla, Sanjit Tirkey and V Manimaran.

The midfield will be manned by Adrohit Ekka, Harpal, Jeetpal, Mukesh Toppo, Mannu Malik and Ritik Lakra. The

forward line consists of Ajeet Yadav, Prabhdeep Singh, Arjun Hargude, Aryan Xess, Lovenoor Singh, Mohd Konain Dad and Gurusewak Singh. Four members of the squad — Anmol, Adrohit, Yadav and Kullu — were also part of the Indian team who secured a bronze medal at the Junior World Cup in Tamil Nadu last year. "I expect this tour to help us progress on several levels. First, in terms of our game, by improving our connections, our tactical discipline and our efficiency in key moments.

BWF unveils 2027-28 calendar; India Open moves to February next year

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The India Open Super 750 will be held in February next year and at the end of January in 2028, according to the World Tour Calendar for the next two years announced by the Badminton World Federation (BWF) on Tuesday.

The 2026 edition of the country's flagship event was held from January 13 to 18 at the Indira Gandhi Indoor



Stadium. It will now be staged from February 2 to 7 in 2027, and from January 25 to 30 in 2028 in the national capital.

The 2026 edition had faced widespread criticism from elite international players over hazardous air quality, freezing indoor court temperatures, and concerns related to venue hygiene.

The Syed Modi India International, which has been downgraded to a Super 100 event, will be held in Lucknow from July 27 to August 1 in 2027 and from July 25 to 30 in 2028.